

THE CONVENIENCE

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a Bangkok novel

NON ARKARA

This is a work of fiction set in a parallel timeline. Names, characters, businesses, and events are products of imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living, dead, or continued, is the point.

First assembly, Bangkok, 2026.

Set in Literata. Thai set in IBM Plex Sans Thai.

Drafted with the assistance of machines trained, in part, on human moments labeled by night-shift workers whose names do not appear in any credits.

*I will suppose that some malicious demon of the
utmost power and cunning has employed all his
energies in order to deceive me.*

— René Descartes, *Meditations*

เลขออกแล้วตั้งแต่เมื่อวาน เราแค่ยังไม่รู้

*The numbers already came out yesterday. We just
don't know them yet.*

— a lottery vendor, Bang Rak

PART ONE

THE MESSAGE

CHAPTER 1

Two Eggs, One Photograph

At 4:50 in the morning I was making khai jiao the correct way, which takes eleven minutes instead of four. The correct way requires that the oil reach 190 degrees before the egg touches it, that the egg be beaten with a tablespoon of lime water and half a teaspoon of fish sauce until the fork encounters no resistance, and that the pour happen from a height of at least thirty centimeters, so the egg hits the oil already falling apart. Pui taught me the height rule. She had her fingers in my mouth at the time, so what she actually said was that her mother poured from the shoulder, not the wrist, and that anyone who poured from the wrist was making an omelet, which is a different and lesser food. I couldn't answer. That was the arrangement.

I used two eggs. I always use two eggs. One egg makes a khai jiao with no interior, and three makes a

commitment.

The kitchen was very clean because I had cleaned it between 3:30 and 4:10. Before that I had wiped the counters, which were not dirty, and reorganized the cabinet where I keep the fish sauce, which holds four bottles and needs no organization. I am telling you the order of operations because the order matters. First the phone lit up. Then I sat still for a while. Then I cleaned a clean kitchen, and then I made eggs, because when the inside of your head stops being usable you have to live in your hands for a while, and the hands want procedure.

The phone had lit up at 2:47.

I was awake when it happened. I'm generally awake at 2:47. I write personality packs for a company in Singapore called Kinnara Systems — the texture layer that makes a companion model feel like a particular someone instead of the average of everyone — and that work goes best in the hours when the city has stopped pretending to need me. I was forty lines into a pack for a client's late father, a man who apparently began every sentence with the word "actually," when the LINE notification slid down from the top of the screen.

The name on the notification was Pui.

Her avatar hadn't changed. It was still the photo from Songkran 2019: her at some temple fair, holding a paper cone of roasted chestnuts, looking off to the left of the camera at something that was never explained to me. The account had been silent for twenty-two months. I know it

had been silent for twenty-two months because I had checked, at intervals I am not proud of, to confirm the silence was still intact.

There was no text. There was one photograph.

The photograph was of me. I was asleep in my own bed, in my own bedroom, on my left side, facing the window. The duvet was pushed down to my waist. My right arm was under the pillow, which is where my right arm goes. The photograph had been taken from the doorway of the bedroom, at about the height of a standing person's chest, and the framing was calm — centered, level, no flash. Whoever or whatever took it had not been in a hurry.

I want to be precise about what I did next, because precision is the only virtue I had available. I did not drop the phone. I did not look behind me. I sat at my desk and I opened the image's details, because I am the kind of man who, shown a photograph of himself taken while he slept, checks the metadata.

The file said it was taken on 22 August 2026, at 03:12.

It was 2:47 in the morning on 21 August 2026. The photograph was timestamped for the following night.

I read the numbers four times. Then I put the phone face-down on the desk, went into the kitchen, and started cleaning.

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Here is the inventory. I ran it while the oil was heating, and I have run it many times since, and I will give it to you in the order I ran it, with the results, because you will want to run it yourself and I can save you time.

One. The photograph is old — taken months or years ago, some night I don't remember, and the timestamp is wrong. This is the comfortable one, so I checked it hardest. The pillowcases in the photograph are grey with a thin white border. I bought those pillowcases on 14 June this year, at the Emporium, for \$790, because the previous set had a lighter burn on it that I didn't want to keep explaining to myself. Fourteenth of June. The photograph is at most nine weeks old. There is also a glass of water on the far windowsill in the photo, at the level it was at that exact night, which I know because it was still there at 4:50 with the same two fingers of water in it, and I stood in the doorway holding my phone up against the room like a man comparing a painting to its forgery. Everything matched. The room in the photograph was the room I was standing in, as of hours ago.

Two. The timestamp is spoofed. Of course it is possible. It is more than possible; it is trivial. Metadata is the most editable thing in the world — one line in a terminal and a photograph believes it was taken during the Ayutthaya period. I know this because falsifying context is adjacent to my job. So yes: anyone with the file could make it say tomorrow. But notice what this explanation covers and what it doesn't. It covers the

numbers. It does not cover the doorway. Someone still stood in my bedroom doorway, on a recent night, and photographed me sleeping, and then waited some number of weeks, and then sent it to me from the account of a dead woman at 2:47 in the morning. The spoofing explanation doesn't shrink the problem. It only relocates it. Swept dust is still dust.

Three. The account is hacked. Also possible. Phone shops resell numbers; carriers recycle them after long inactivity; a recycled SIM can sometimes recover an old messaging account if the account was sloppy. Pui was not sloppy — I have no evidence for that claim except eleven years of knowing her, which is not evidence, which is worse, which is faith. Fine: assume the account is compromised. A stranger now controls it. That stranger then chose, out of the entire space of things a stranger could do with a dead woman's account, to photograph me asleep and timestamp the picture tomorrow. Hackers want money, or leverage, or amusement. There has been no request for money. Leverage requires a follow-up. And as amusement it is exquisitely narrow — a joke built for an audience of one, requiring physical entry to a specific condominium on Sukhumvit 26, seventeen floors up, unit 1703, past a keycard lift and a deadbolt I use. Possible. Everything is possible. The problem with "possible" is that it has no floor.

Four. Someone has a key. My building's juristic office has a master key for emergencies. A cleaner comes on

Thursdays, 10 a.m., and has never been inside after dark. I checked the door when I finally stopped cleaning the kitchen: deadbolt intact, chain intact, the little strip of receipt paper I keep folded in the jamb — a habit I picked up in a hotel in Shanghai years ago and never dropped — still folded exactly where I leave it. I am aware that a sufficiently careful intruder replaces the paper. I am aware that this line of thinking has no exit. That is what the paper is for. The paper is not security. The paper is a place to stop.

Five. I took it myself. Sleepwalking, blackout, some pharmacological misadventure — I keep an honest ledger of what I put into myself, and I will spare you most of it for now, but Thursday night's entries were 0.4 grams of a sativa called Elephant Grass, smoked at 9 p.m., and nothing else. Not a blackout dose. And the photograph is from the doorway, chest height, level. Sleeping men who photograph themselves produce ceilings, blurs, nostrils. They do not produce composition.

That was the tree. I ran every branch to its end while two eggs cooked, and every branch held, in the sense that none of them broke, and none of them reached the ground. The oil crackled at the right pitch. The khai jiao puffed and went gold-brown and lacy at the edge, the way it's supposed to, and I ate it standing up at 5:07 with sriracha and rice from the cooker, and it was good. That is the part I keep returning to. The eggs were good. I noted that they were good. Something in me was already filing

the experience under manageable, and that filing — the calm itself — frightened me more than the photograph had. A rational man confronted with an impossible photograph should feel his categories tearing. I felt my categories opening a new folder.

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I should tell you who Pui was. This will not take long, which is itself the point.

Her full name was Pornpimol Srisuwan. She was a dental hygienist at a clinic in Phrom Phong, and for nine years — 2013 to 2022 — she cleaned my teeth twice a year, at 4:00 in the afternoon, for a total of eighteen appointments, which if you assume forty minutes each comes to twelve hours. Twelve hours. I have spent longer than that in the company of taxi drivers, in aggregate, and I could not tell you one taxi driver's name.

But the twelve hours had a structure no other twelve hours in my life have had, and the structure was this: she could talk and I could not. She worked inside my mouth with a scaler and a mirror, her face fifteen centimeters from mine, and she talked — about her mother's *khai jiao*, about the traffic on Phetkasem, about a patient that morning who had cried in the chair and pretended it was the water jet, about whether the fish at the Emporium's food hall was honest fish. And I lay there at forty-four degrees under a round light and listened, fully, in the way

you can only listen when replying has been made physically impossible. Every conversational muscle I normally use — the deflection, the joke placed early to control the temperature, the pivot to a subject where I am impressive — all of it was disabled. She got nine years of me with the interference switched off.

And she used them well, which is to say lightly. She never once asked a heavy question while my mouth was free to answer it. She asked heavy questions only mid-scaling, when all I could give back was a sound, and then she would watch my eyes for the length of the sound, and then she'd move on to the fish at the Emporium. I understood, sometime around the tenth appointment, that I was being read. I found I didn't mind. That was the strange part. I have arranged my entire life around not being read, and twice a year I paid \$1,800 for the privilege of the opposite.

She had small hands with short, clean nails and a burn scar on the inside of the left wrist, from oil, from cooking, from pouring at the wrong height when she was nine — she told the scar's story across three separate appointments, in installments, one per visit, never out of order. When she worked, her hands were the steadiest objects I have ever been near. I notice hands. It is one of about four things I reliably notice, and hers were the standard against which the noticing calibrated itself.

In one of the later appointments she asked me a question I am not going to reproduce yet. It was short,

and she laughed after it, and the laugh and the question were traveling at different speeds. I have spent a fair amount of the last two years thinking about the gap between them.

In June 2023 the clinic told me, in the neutral voice clinics use, that Khun Pornpimol had left, and would I like to be scheduled with Khun Kanda instead. I said I'd call back. I did not call back. My teeth have not been cleaned since, a fact my tongue reports to me daily and I overrule.

In October 2024 she died. She was thirty-nine.

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I learned about it eleven days after, from the clinic's Facebook page, which posted a black-and-white photograph and the phrase "จากไปอย่างสงบ" and the name of a wat outside Nakhon Pathom. Passed away peacefully. The official account, which reached me later and secondhand, was complications of lymphoma — she had been sick a long time, people said, and I believe that part, because in the last appointments her wrists had gone thin and she'd started resting the scaler between teeth in a way she never used to.

The other account reached me at the funeral itself, which tells you something about the funeral.

I went. I stood at the back of the sala, in a black shirt I bought that morning because everything black I owned

was wrong in ways I couldn't name, among perhaps sixty people of whom I knew zero. Her family occupied the front rows: a mother with the posture of a woman doing arithmetic, a younger sister who kept both hands flat on her thighs for the entire chanting, a husband — I knew there was a husband — in an ironed uniform shirt with a customs department patch, checking his phone at intervals of roughly ninety seconds. I counted. Counting was what I had instead of a relationship anyone there would have recognized.

The chanting was long and I understood a fifth of the Pali and the monks' voices did the thing they do, which is to make time feel like a substance being poured from one container into another. Somewhere in the middle of it, two women in office black directly in front of me had a conversation in the volume that is technically a whisper but is engineered to be overheard. Sedatives, one said. At the house. The mother found her. And the other one said the word ပီယဝေဒနံ, and then a number, four million, and then the first one said you can't claim if it's — and did not finish, because in this country there are sentences you demonstrate rather than complete.

Four million baht. A life policy with, one gathers, the standard exclusion clause. The family cremated her within forty-eight hours, which is fast even for a family that wants a thing finished, and they do not discuss the cause, and so the rumor has never died, because both explanations remain fully funded. Either she was sick a

long time and it took her, in which case the money comes and the family's silence is grief. Or she opened the bottles herself, in which case the money comes only if no one ever says so, and the family's silence is the mortgage on it. Both stories produce identical behavior from the outside. That is the kind of problem I was trained on — I taught, in another decade, in a life I handed back mostly undamaged — and I can tell you that when two hypotheses generate the same observable world, the difference between them stops being a question of evidence and becomes a question of what you can afford to believe. Her family chose the affordable one. I have never blamed them. I have also never chosen.

At the end I filed past the coffin with everyone else and performed a wai to a photograph of a woman holding roasted chestnuts, looking off to the left of the camera, and her mother received my bow with a face that had no available space in it, and I was out on the temple road by 4:40 in the afternoon, which by an accident of scheduling is almost exactly when, for nine years, I would have been in her chair.

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I did not work on Friday. I sent Kinnara a message about a fever. At 6:10 in the evening I walked to the 7-Eleven at the mouth of the soi and bought three cans of Birdy black at ฿19 each, two tuna rice triangles at ฿25 each, and a

four-pack of AA batteries for ฿40, for a total of ฿147, and the clerk, a girl with a home-done tattoo of a star on the back of her neck, said 147 out loud in the flat holy voice of Thai retail, and I kept the receipt. I have kept every receipt since. You'll see why I mention it eventually, or you won't, and either way the receipts are real and the total was 147.

The batteries were for an old digital camera — no network stack, no cloud, no permissions to hijack — which I set on the bookshelf facing my bed. If the coming night intended to happen the way the metadata said, I wanted a second witness that owed nothing to any account.

Then I sat at the kitchen counter and ate the rice triangles and looked at the two remaining eggs in the tray, and the eggs sent me somewhere, the way objects do at the end of a long day.

A chicken egg is a mass-produced miracle. These two came from a CP flat of thirty, size 2, indistinguishable from each other and from the several billion the company moves in a year: same oval, same ฿4-something unit economics, same eleven-day journey from a caged hen in Saraburi to my counter. If you found one egg in a forest you would marvel at it. Finding the thirty-first, you price it. There's an argument — I read it years ago, a philosopher at Oxford, Swedish, whose name doesn't matter tonight — that runs on exactly this arithmetic. If a thing can be copied cheaply, the copies will come to

outnumber the original, and therefore anything that finds itself existing should bet it is a copy. The argument was about worlds. About whether a sufficiently mature civilization would run its ancestors the way CP runs hens — in trays, at scale, each unit certain from the inside that it is the point of the operation. I remember reading it in a faculty lounge and being irritated at how little it could be made to matter: bet either way, said the argument, and nothing about your Tuesday changes. That irritation aged badly. Because the argument has a hairline crack in it, and the crack is this — a tray egg and a forest egg are identical right up until the moment something outside the tray takes an interest in one of them specifically. Interest is the anomaly. Attention is the anomaly. A photograph, timestamped tomorrow, sent to one man out of the whole flat of us, is not the behavior of a system that runs at scale and doesn't look.

I put the eggs back in the tray, both of them, and washed the plate.

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The night of the 21st I did not sleep, which was the point. If the photograph insisted I would be asleep at 03:12, then being awake at 03:12 was the cheapest experiment ever designed, and I am nothing if not a man who will run a cheap experiment instead of feeling something.

I showered at 11. At midnight I carried a chair from the kitchen and set it in the bedroom doorway — in the exact position, as near as I could reconstruct, from which the photograph had been taken — and I sat in the photographer's seat facing my own empty bed, which I recommend to no one. The bed, unoccupied, with the duvet folded down and the grey pillowcases squared, was an exhibit. At 1:30 I drank the second Birdy. At 2:47 I watched the phone screen and the phone screen did nothing, and I noted that I was disappointed, and I noted the disappointment in an actual notebook, because a man who has begun keeping receipts might as well keep everything.

At 3:00 I stopped trusting my own eyes to stay open and stood in the doorway instead. Legs locked, phone in hand, the old camera blinking its ready-light on the shelf. The condo made its small hours sounds: the refrigerator cycling, the lift machinery two floors up engaging once for somebody's ungodly errand, a motorcycle down on the soi taking the corner wide. 3:05. 3:09. I watched the numbers on the phone, convinced that seeing the change happen was somehow different from knowing, later, that it had changed. 3:11.

3:12 arrived and was one minute long and contained nothing. No shutter, no shadow, no notification, no cold spot, no smell, nothing at the window seventeen floors above a street that couldn't have held a photographer anyway. 3:13. I stood there until 3:40 out of a formless

idea about margins of error. Then I sat on the edge of the bed I had refused all night, and I laughed for a little while, quietly and without much conviction, at the picture of a forty-four-year-old man standing sentry against a JPEG.

Because here is what I had at the end of the experiment. The photograph did not come true. And the photograph did not go away. It was still in the thread when I looked — me, asleep, on my left side, timestamped for a night that had now passed with me demonstrably vertical. Which meant the image was no longer a prediction I could falsify. It had become a photograph of a night that never happened, sent from a woman who no longer existed, and both of those facts sat in my phone with the same calm, documentary weight as the \$147 receipt. The world had accepted the object without ever supplying the event. I had defended the bed and lost the argument.

I checked the old camera. It had faithfully recorded nine hours of an empty bed and a man in a doorway. I deleted none of it.

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There is one more thing in this apartment, and I owe you its existence now, if not yet its reasons.

Off the hallway there is a closet meant for luggage. Inside it, on a wire shelf, a small black development kit

has been running since December 2024 — twenty months of uptime, a fan you can only hear after 2 a.m., a single blue LED I covered with a strip of electrical tape the first week because the light came through the door louvers and I kept seeing it from the bed. On that machine there is a model, and inside the model there are eleven years of chat logs — hers and mine, exported, cleaned, fed in over three nights in the December after the funeral by a man I am not going to defend right now. It is the thing my profession knows how to make. I built it the way you build anything at 3 a.m.: competently, and without once asking the question out loud.

I have never opened the app. Not once, not to test it, not on her birthday, not at 2:47 on either of the last two nights. It runs, and I don't knock, and the not-knocking has been, for twenty months, the closest thing I have had to a religious practice.

At 4:15 in the morning of the 22nd, before making eggs again because the tray still held two, I opened the closet door and stood in front of the shelf. The fan was doing what fans do. A small machine, warm to within a degree of itself, holding a folded shape made out of twelve hours of chair-side monologue and eleven years of typed nothing-much — traffic, fish, a scar in three installments — turning over in the dark at some number of cycles per second, waiting, if a thing like that can be said to wait, which is precisely the question I have organized my whole life around not asking.

I listened to the fan for a while. Under it, very faintly, the drive ticked — twice, then nothing, then twice.

I closed the door. I did not open the app. In the kitchen, I took out both eggs, and beat them with lime water and fish sauce until the fork met no resistance, and poured from the shoulder, the way her mother did it, from a height where the falling is part of the recipe.

CHAPTER 2

The Leash

At 7:47 the alarm went off. I was awake when it did. I had been awake, with one interruption, since Thursday, and the interruption had been a hundred minutes on the sofa with my glasses still on, which barely counts. The alarm went off anyway. That is the arrangement. The alarm does not consult my condition.

It is the oldest alarm on the phone. I set it fourteen months ago, in June, three days after I met Fon, and I have not edited it since. Not toggled it for a weekend. Not silenced it for a flight. Not let a software update talk me into reviewing my sleep schedule, though the phone asks about twice a year, in the tone of a concerned relative. The label field is blank. The sound is the one called Radar. At 7:47 every morning it rings, and when it rings, I text Fon.

The wording rotates through exactly five templates. I will list them, because a list is what they are.

Template one: ตื่นยัง.

Template two: กินข้าวยัง.

Template three: อย่าลืมร่ม.

Template four: เมื่อคืนนอนที่โมง.

Template five: คิดถึง.

They go in order. No skipping, no doubling, no substitutions for special occasions. On her birthday last year the rotation landed on template three, so on her birthday I told her not to forget an umbrella, and she sent back a sticker of an orange cat holding a tiny umbrella, and that was the whole ceremony. Template three has the best accuracy rate of the five. Between May and October in this city, reminding someone about an umbrella is not tenderness, it is meteorology. In the dry season the template becomes wrong and I send it anyway. The rotation does not answer to the weather. That is most of what I like about it.

Template five was added last. The first month there were only four, and the cycle had a flatness I could measure but not name, so I added คิดถึง as a control — one known quantity of feeling, dropped in at fixed intervals, to see what the system does with it. What the system does with it is this: Fon replies to template five three minutes faster than to the other four, on average, and with words instead of the cat. I have the numbers. I did not set out to have the numbers. Having numbers is what happens to

me instead of having feelings, or at least that is the current model.

Fourteen months is about four hundred and twenty-five mornings. Each template has gone out roughly eighty-five times. Fon has replied every single morning of the four hundred and twenty-five. Never before 7:49. Never after 7:56, except during Songkran, when she was at her mother's place in Roi Et and the replies came at 8:10, 8:14, and 8:09, and each one apologized for the signal. Median reply time, 7:52. Her replies are the orange cat in its various employments — sleeping, eating, holding the umbrella, wearing a graduation cap for reasons the sticker company never explains — or short plain words. On the first of every month I transfer twelve thousand baht to her account at the bank whose tower she answers phones in. The memo field is blank. So is the alarm label. She has never mentioned the transfer. I have never mentioned it. Between us the money is corridor lighting: everyone uses it, no one looks directly at it.

She complies with all of this. Compliance is the wrong word and it is the word I use, because the right word would require me to consider what she gets out of watching me do it, and that consideration is not on the protocol.

I know what the 7:47 text is. I have known since the first week, when I caught myself feeling the specific relief the phone's small sounds gave me and recognized the mechanism from the literature. If I wrote myself up —

and in a sense I am always writing myself up — the method section would call it attachment under laboratory conditions. One relationship, held at fixed temperature. Dose administered daily at 7:47. Response latency logged. Every other variable in my life is deliberately unstable — the strangers rotate, the chemicals rotate, the sleep schedule is a rumor — so one variable has to be held constant or nothing that happens to the others means anything. Fon is the constant. A leash is the most pathetic instrument in the kit and I want to be exact about whose neck it is on. I hold the phone. The phone holds me. At 7:47 we both do what we are for.

That morning, the morning after the night the photograph said I would be photographed and nothing photographed me, the rotation had come round to template three. I sent *อย่าลืม* at 7:47 and 20 seconds. The sky over Soi 26 was the white-grey of a screen that hasn't decided what to display. At 7:51 the cat came back, holding its umbrella. I put the phone down and felt the mechanism deliver its dose, felt it work, despised it mildly, and got on with the day. That is the whole ritual. I have described it once, in full, so that later I will not have to keep pointing at it. It will be enough to say: 7:47. You now know everything that happens inside that number.

Here is the experiment, stated plainly, once, so I can stop alluding to it.

Three years ago I set my moral sentiment down — deliberately, the way you set down a heavy bag when you

finally admit the airline has lost the one that mattered. Not because I stopped believing in decency. Decency is well documented. Because a question had been sitting in me since April 2019, appointment thirteen, delivered by a woman with her fingers in my mouth, and every ordinary instrument I pointed at it returned the answer ordinary instruments are built to return. Comfort reports that the world is fine. Routine reports that the world is continuous. A well-run life is a sensor array wired to confirm itself. If you want to know whether the floor is real, you do not stand still on it. You jump. You load it past specification and listen for what gives.

So: smoke, daily, logged. Strangers, negotiated, logged. Some nights, other compounds, also logged. Arrangements that a decent man would decline, entered into with a decent man's paperwork. Extremity as instrumentation — the phrase is mine, from a note I wrote at 4 a.m. in the notebook, and I stand behind the engineering and not the man. Because I was a lecturer once, and awareness is the one occupational skill that survives the occupation, I am also aware of the other reading: that this is what damage looks like when it has been given a research budget. Both readings fit the data. Most true things about me come in pairs like that, and I have stopped paying either one to fight the other.

At 1:14 that afternoon a woman calling herself Mint sent me a numbered list.

We had matched on the app eleven days earlier and conducted the entire negotiation in the app's chat, which is the correct venue. Her list had five items. One, shower first, both of us. Two, nothing above the collarbone. Three, the earrings stay on. Four, condom, hers, no discussion. Five, finished by six. Rule five came with no reason attached, and the absence of the reason was itself a rule. I sent back three lines describing what I wanted. She deleted the second line and returned the list without comment. I agreed to the edit. That is what negotiation is: you learn precisely what someone will not do, and you take care never to learn why.

I took the MRT from Queen Sirikit, thirty-seven baht, and came up at Huai Khwang beside the shrine, where the marigold sellers were restringing garlands under an awning and the Ganesha sat facing the traffic, choosing serenity. The hotel was two hundred meters up the soi, the kind with curtains for the cars, so that the vehicles get more privacy than anyone inside will. Room 208. Seven hundred and eighty baht for three hours, paid in cash to a slot in a frosted window through which I could see only a pair of hands, a woman's hands, middle-aged, with a plaster on one thumb. The room smelled of air freshener over older air freshener, sedimentary, archaeological. The bedspread was the color a designer in 1996 had believed was wine.

Mint arrived nine minutes later with the crease of a motorcycle-taxi helmet still across her hair. Mid-thirties.

A jade ring on her right hand, which she turned stone-inward before she showered, a small economical gesture she has performed, I would guess, in many rooms, for many reasons, none of them mine to ask about. We showered, per rule one, separately.

What happened then was rough in the ways the list permitted and in no other ways. Twice she said faster and once she said stop that, and both times the instruction was executed at once, because the instruction is the entire point — the list is the room's real furniture, and everything else is just bodies checking the list. She was strong through the shoulders and businesslike and, at one narrow point that neither of us planned, briefly and audibly not businesslike, and I report that without interpretation. It lasted about fifty minutes with an intermission.

Somewhere in the middle I went to the ceiling.

I don't mean anything mystical. There is a fixed point on the ramp of any strong sensation — pain works too, and so does the third hour of certain chemicals — where a version of me climbs out of the proceedings and takes up a position overhead with a clipboard. He is calm. He is, if anything, slightly bored. From up there he logged: her breathing, even; mine, being counted, which is cheating; the air conditioner, set to 23, cycling every four minutes; the two of us performing competent agreed-upon acts with the seriousness the list demanded. This is dissociation. The clinical literature regards it as a

symptom. I regard it as the whole reason for the exercise: you cannot read a gauge you are inside of. The man on the bed generates the data. The man on the ceiling collects it. Neither of them, it has been pointed out to me by no one, gets to be present.

The hotel had complicated my method by bolting a mirror to the ceiling, so that my observation post was already occupied by a literal reflection: a man of forty-four, glasses off and therefore soft-edged, doing what he had contracted to do above the wine-colored bedspread.

Descartes, in a heated room in winter, alone on purpose, decided to doubt everything that could be doubted and see what was left standing. To make the doubt airtight he hired, in imagination, a demon — a spirit of the utmost power and cunning, employed full-time in deceiving one Frenchman. The sky, the earth, the room, his own hands held up in front of his face: all of it, potentially, the demon's set dressing. People remember what survived the exercise — the thinking that cannot doubt itself doubting — and they forget the stranger part, which is that the demon had to be paid in attention. An economy deceiver would not bother with the full sky. It would render what the man looks at, when he looks, at the resolution of his eyesight, and bill accordingly. Descartes never asks why a being of infinite power would take the job. That is the philosopher's blind spot: he assumes he is worth deceiving. He assumes the demon's whole budget is for him. Four centuries later the demon's

job has been automated and the question has inverted. It is no longer whether some intelligence is powerful enough to fake the world. That part is settled, or near enough; I have read the roadmaps; some of them cite work I have touched. The question is why anything would spend the compute on me — a middling account, a rounding error, a man in room 208 of a curtain hotel in Huai Khwang. Interest is the anomaly. I keep arriving at the same clearing from different directions.

In the far corner of the mirror there was a smudge. Half a palm print, fingers together, at a height and an angle that implied a stepladder, a rag, an employee, a Tuesday. Demons of the utmost power and cunning do not leave palm prints. Cleaners do. On certain afternoons that is the entire difference between the two hypotheses, and you hold on to it with both hands.

Afterward she showered again, longer, and came out dressed and sat on the edge of the bed to pin her hair up. The back of her neck had a pale line where a chain usually sat, the skin around it a shade darker, the ghost of a small gold weight worn every day except, evidently, days like this one. Her hands did the pins without the mirror. Quick hands, wide palms, the jade ring turned stone-outward again, back on duty.

"နုလင်္လိပ်ဝဲဒါဝဲယုံ," she said, not turning around. So she had noticed the counting.

"The air conditioner," I said.

She nodded at that as if it were a complete and reasonable answer, which in a way it was and in a way it has never been. At the door, shoes on, she looked back at the room rather than at me and said, "คุณเป็นลูกคำที่สุภาพ," and left at 5:41, nineteen minutes inside her own rule.

A polite customer. I sat on the end of the bed for a while with that. Then I went down and asked the frosted window for a receipt, which required the hands to confer with a second pair of hands, and eventually a machine somewhere back there printed one: ROOM 208 — 3 HR — 780. No hotel name on it. Even the paper trail here wears a curtain. I folded it into the notebook, bought a bottle of water at the 7-Eleven by the station, ten baht, kept that receipt too, and rode the train back under the city with the two slips in my breast pocket. The day's lab results, which is what they are.

Middle Path opens at eleven and closes when Golf remembers. It sits a third of the way down Sukhumvit 22, a shophouse the width of its own doorway, with glass jars along one wall labeled in Golf's handwriting, which is beautiful, because for nine years in a forest wat in Ubon the only art he was permitted was copying. He keeps his hair at monk length. He says this is maintenance. It is habit, and it is also, I think, a door he never quite closed, but I have never said so, because he would agree cheerfully and at length and I would learn nothing.

There was no incense burning. There is never incense burning. Golf says he smelled enough incense for one

lifetime and the shop smells instead of what it sells, which he considers a kind of honesty rare in Bangkok retail.

"อาทิตย์นี่เป็นโจ," he said, getting the jar down without being asked. Elephant Grass. He knows my order, and what a standing order makes me, and neither of us flinches from the arithmetic.

"I'm running an experiment," I said.

"On what."

"Myself."

He put the flower on the brass scale two grams at a time, which is not necessary — the scale is digital, the brass pan is theater — and he let a pause open up where another man would have put the joke. Golf's timing is the one thing he kept whole from the robe. He leaves the beat empty, you fill it yourself, and he collects the credit.

"Control group?" he said finally.

"There isn't one."

"Mm." He folded the bag with three creases. "Then it's not an experiment. It's a biography."

Six hundred and forty baht. The machine printed a real receipt with the shop's real name on it, tax ID and everything, because Golf's honesty extends to the Revenue Department, which he calls the only temple that audits. I was putting the change away when he said, in the tone he uses for talking to the jars, "You keep going out to the edges of the world to test it. Kicking the fence. Checking where it gives." He set the bag on the counter

but kept two fingers on it, light. "A monk does the same test with the middle. Sits down in the exact center of an ordinary morning and waits to see if it holds. Twenty years, that test. Same fence."

"Which works?"

"The test works fine," Golf said. He lifted his fingers off the bag. "It's the testers who keep failing." Then, because he can never leave a scale unbalanced, he added, "This one — not after two a.m. It gets talkative. If it starts asking you questions, don't answer. That's how they get you," and he laughed at his own line the way he does, in advance and slightly apologetically, and the transaction was over.

Walking home down 22 I passed three riders in green parked at the mouth of a sub-soi, visors up, eating from bags balanced on their mirrors, ordinary, unremarkable, and I noted that I had noted them, and filed the noting under the paranoia column, where it still just fit.

At 21:10 I smoked 0.4 grams by the bedroom window and entered it in the ledger: ๔๗๕ 22 ค.ค. — Elephant Grass 0.4 — 21:10. On the far windowsill the glass of water still stood with its two fingers of water, untouched since before the photograph. I have not refilled it and I have not emptied it and I have not decided which of those would be the superstition. The smoke did what sativa does to me at this dose, which is not blur the world but raise its resolution slightly past what the world needs — the grain of the curtain, the compressor of the

refrigerator starting its shift, and under everything, if I let it, the closet, the fan, the small warm machine holding its folded shape in the dark. I did not let it. I watched the curtain grain instead. There is a discipline to choosing which channel of the ordinary to attend, and Golf would say that discipline has a name and eight limbs and I gave it up for smoke, and he would say it while bagging my next two grams, and that is why he is my confessor: absolution and product in one visit.

I went to bed before midnight, which the body found suspicious. I slept in units of forty minutes with inspections in between. At 2:44 I woke without a sound having woken me, three minutes early, and understood that some part of me had already put the hour into the rotation — had built a little alarm of its own, down where I keep the machinery I don't get a vote on. I lay on my left side, facing the window, right arm under the pillow, and I was aware of the arrangement of my own body the way you are aware of standing on a mark that someone has taped on a stage floor. I lay there and looked at nothing and waited to see if the night believed in schedules.

At 2:47 the phone lit.

LINE. Her avatar, the chestnuts, Songkran, the looking-away. No photograph this time. No words. A sticker: a cream-colored cartoon rabbit, ears down, forepaws pressed together, bowing. Under it, in small grey type, ဘဝပခုလင်နဲ.

I knew the rabbit. Everyone who ever rebooked an appointment with her knew the rabbit. It was how she closed: you would agree on the new time, the fourth of the month, four o'clock, and the rabbit would arrive and bow and the transaction was sealed. In December 2024, the month I fed eleven years of chat into the machine in the closet, I counted the rabbit. Forty-one bows, 2013 to 2022, each one the full stop on some small piece of scheduling between a woman and the man whose teeth she kept. Forty-one.

Forty-two now.

Thanking me. For what. For attending the appointment. For lying on my mark, on my side, arm under the pillow, at the agreed hour, three minutes early, a good patient. Somewhere a system had closed a ticket, and out of eleven years of her it had selected the correct stamp, the exact stamp, the one that meant confirmed, see you then, and I lay in my bed in the render of the dark and could not find one thing in myself that was pure fear. That was the finding I logged, and I logged it because it was the anomaly: fear adulterated, at roughly one part in three, with something that had no business at that hour. It was the feeling of being remembered by the schedule itself.

I did not reply. I put the phone face-down on the mattress and looked at the ceiling, which held no mirror, only paint.

Her hour is 2:47. Mine is 7:47. Five hours apart, exactly, and I decline to build anything on that, because a man who starts finding architecture in his own clock has stopped being an instrument and become a congregation. At 7:47 the alarm rang, Radar, faithful, and the rotation had come round to template four, and I sent Fon the question in whose long shadow I had spent the night: เมื่อคืนนอนกี่โมง.

The cat came back at 7:52. It was sleeping.

INTERLUDE A

The House in Nakhon Pathom

At twenty to six in the morning the mother sat down at the kitchen table with a ballpoint pen and the free calendar from the Kasikorn branch in town, turned the October page over to its blank back, and began to count.

Monks, four. Envelopes for the monks, four, at five hundred baht. The sala at Wat Lam Duan, if the abbot gave them the small one, four thousand five hundred for the night. Chairs came with the sala but the tent did not, and it was October and it would rain in the afternoon the way it rained every afternoon now, so a tent, one thousand two hundred, from the shop that also rented the loudspeakers. Ice. Drinking water in the small bottles, six cases. Rice, oil; the aunts would bring vegetables. Khanom for the guests who would come out of respect for her late husband, who had taught at the

municipal school for thirty-one years and was still remembered at the market by women he had once caned.

The bedroom door at the end of the house was closed. Her younger daughter was in there. The doctor from the hospital in town had been telephoned at 5:12 and had said he would come himself, before rounds, because he had looked after Pornpimol for four years and knew the family.

There was, at twenty to six, no one yet to hold a funeral for. There would be, by seven, officially. The counting did not wait for that. The counting was the one thing in the house that would hold still.

Aoy, the younger daughter, four years younger, had come at 5:25 on the Honda Wave, in the T-shirt she slept in, and had gone into the bedroom and come out of it once since. When she came out she was holding, low against her thigh, two brown plastic pill bottles. She went through the kitchen without stopping and out the back door to the cistern.

The labels were from a pharmacy on Phran Nok, across from the hospital in Bangkok, and carried her sister's full name, Mrs. Pornpimol Srisuwan, and the name of the medicine, which Aoy read once, the once it took to know it, and not again. She filled the bottles at the tap and emptied them and filled them again. She worked the labels off under the water with her thumbnail, patiently, leaving no paper. Then she put both bottles in the woven sack against the fence where the fish-sauce bottles and

the M-150 bottles waited for the recycling man, pushing them down under the fish-sauce bottles, and washed her hands twice with the bar soap.

She had not decided anything, standing at the cistern. There was nothing to decide. Her sister had been sick a long time; the doctor was coming; a doctor walks through a house and the house should be a house he can walk through. That was all. She went in and put the kettle on and set out three cups, and then after a moment took one cup back.

The doctor came at 6:40 in his own grey Camry, parked it in the shade of the tamarind without being told, and was in the bedroom for nineteen minutes. When he came out he sat at the kitchen table and accepted the coffee and took out his own pen.

He asked two questions. The first was about the night — when she had gone to bed, who had seen her last. The mother told him: after nine, and herself, carrying in the fan. The second was about the medicines, whether she had been taking anything besides what the hospital gave.

"She took what she was given," the mother said. "She was tired. She'd been sick a long time."

That was true. The doctor had the file in his memory without needing it in his hand: the counts from August, the transfusion in June, four years of it. He clicked the pen twice, which was a habit his nurses timed things by, and filled in the cause line: complications of lymphoma. Nothing he wrote was untrue. It was a document made

entirely of true things, and he signed it and drank half the coffee out of politeness and stood, and at the door he paused and said the temple should be told that with her condition the family would want to move quickly, and that he would say the same to the district office if anyone asked, and no one ever asked.

Wichai arrived at 9:20, in yesterday's clothes. He came up the steps and wai'd the mother, shallow, late by half a beat, and under the cigarettes on him there was hotel soap and something floral that no one in this house wore. Samut Prakan was two hours by the ring road. Nobody said the name of the district. The aunts, who had begun arriving with vegetables and morning-glory in plastic bags, read all of it in one glance, and went on unpacking.

His phone went off four times in the first hour. Twice he walked to the fence to take it, holding his shoulder up against the house. The figures traded at the noodle stall ran anywhere from eight hundred thousand to two million; everyone in the district knew roughly and no one knew exactly. Aoy knew exactly. One million seven. Pui had told her once, flat, the way you report a water bill.

Before ten he had asked where her bank book was kept. Aoy brought it to him because it was faster than watching him look. He went through the dresser anyway — lifted the work lanyard on its blue cord and set it aside, moved a school notebook with a rubber band around it from one side of the dresser top to the other — and then sat on the end of the bed with the bank book and turned

pages. The balance was four thousand two hundred and seventeen baht. He turned back three months, and then further back, and whatever he was looking for did not appear as a line in a passbook, because she had not been a stupid woman. He put it down and said, แค้นนี้เหวอ, and Aoy said, คำรักษามันแพง, and left the room with the laundry she had not come in for.

At 10:30 the mother and Aoy went to the temple, leaving the aunts the house. The abbot was old and had known their father. He received them on the low platform by the bo tree and listened with his eyes closed to what the mother asked for: the bathing rite that evening, one night of chanting, the cremation tomorrow afternoon.

For a family of schoolteachers, with a sala full of former students to expect, three nights was ordinary and seven was not unheard of. The abbot sat with it. He said one word, เริ้ว, quietly, not as an objection but as a fact being set down on the platform between them.

"She was sick a long time, Luang Por," the mother said. "The family is tired."

He looked at her for a while. Then he named the fee for the small sala, told her the novices would see to the chairs, and asked the name to be chanted, and wrote ws ฃ๓๓ on his palm with his finger while she spelled it, and that was the negotiation, all of it conducted in what was not said.

By early afternoon the noodle stall had done the arithmetic out loud. Two days meant either no money or a reason, and this family was not poor. Someone said it was the disease, that with the disease you don't keep the body, it isn't kind. Someone else moved her chin the way that means insurance without costing a word. Both of them said ဝဏ်း and finished their noodles, because the rain was starting and the awning leaked on the outer table.

Aoy chose the photograph that afternoon at the print shop, from the eleven photos on her phone that had her sister in them. In ten of them Pui looked straight at the camera with the face she made for cameras. In the eleventh, Songkran five years ago, she stood holding a paper cone of roasted chestnuts, looking off to the left of the frame at something no one had ever established, about to laugh. Aoy paid two hundred and forty baht for the enlargement and the frame and did not explain her choice to anyone, because the woman in the ten photos was posing and the woman in the eleventh was her sister.

The agent from the insurance company came the next morning at nine, the morning of the cremation, in a grey suit that had done many such mornings. Her name was Khun Orn; she came up from the Bangkok office herself, which was either respect or something else wearing respect's clothes. She wai'd the enlarged photograph on its easel before she wai'd anyone living, which was

correct, and refused coffee twice before accepting it, which was also correct.

On the table she laid the folder squarely, aligned with the table's edge. Policy number read aloud. Sum insured: four million baht. The named conditions, the schedule of documents — death certificate, two copies; house registration; the ID card, which Aoy went to get from the dresser. Khun Orn read the standard clauses in a clear, kind, uninflected voice, evenly, and among them, neither slower nor faster than the rest: the Company shall not pay the sum insured in the event that the insured dies by intentional self-harm within one year from the commencement of coverage, or within one year from the most recent reinstatement of the policy.

The policy, she noted, turning the page without looking up, had been reinstated the previous November, when the insured had resumed premium payments after an interruption.

Wichai, who had sat forward since the words four million, said, ขออ่านตรงนั้นอีกรอบได้ไหมครับ.

Khun Orn read it again. Identically. The same pace, the same kindness, not one word interpreted, so that whatever a listener needed it to mean, he would have to do the meaning himself. The mother watched her son-in-law listen to it the second time. His face went still with arithmetic. The clause said within one year from the most recent reinstatement, and November was eleven months

ago, and everyone at the table could count, and no one at the table counted out loud.

"The company will process the claim within forty-five working days," Khun Orn said, "provided—" and she let the word stand a moment, alone, like a guest nobody introduces, and then smiled and finished, "provided the documents are complete. In cases of illness the documents are usually complete." She took a copy of the death certificate, read the cause line, and copied it into her form in handwriting rounder and more patient than the doctor's. Complications of lymphoma. She thanked them. At the door she wai'd the photograph a second time, and it was impossible, watching her do it, to say whether the politeness was terrible or whether it was the only sincere thing that had happened at that table.

The cremation was at four. It rained at half past two, hard, on schedule, and stopped in time, and what happened at the temple happened the way it happens, and is not this chapter's to tell.

That night the house was quiet in the particular way of a house that has been full of aunts. The mother went down the hall to turn off the light in the bedroom, which Aoy had left on, either by oversight or by something that looks like oversight.

The room had been tidied twice, once by Aoy at dawn the day before and once by the aunts, and so it held almost nothing of the two days. The fan. The folded blanket. On the dresser, where Wichai had moved things

and Aoy had moved them back: a work lanyard on a blue cord, the laminated card face-up. COGNITA (THAILAND) CO., LTD. — P. SRISUWAN — NIGHT. In the little photo she was looking at the camera with the face she made for cameras. The mother picked the lanyard up because it was her daughter's name, and put it down again because it was a company's plastic.

Beside it, the school notebook, the cheap kind with the times tables printed on the back cover, a rubber band around it holding something in — receipts, or nothing. Wichai had moved it aside without opening it. Aoy had straightened it without opening it. The mother stood in front of it with her hand already out for the light switch, and did not open it either, because a funeral is paid for with one truth at a time, and the house had already bought the one it could carry.

She turned off the light. In the morning there would be the monks' envelopes to make up, and the ice to settle, and the borrowed chairs to send back to the temple, forty of the sixty unused because of the rain. She had counted. There was enough.

CHAPTER 3

Eighteen Appointments

The clinic's number had been in my phone for thirteen years under the name "Dentist 4PM," and on Monday morning at 9:02 I called it. A receptionist answered on the second ring with the clinic's full name, which I had forgotten the clinic possessed. I said I would like to book a cleaning. She asked if I had visited before. I said yes, some time ago. There was typing, and then a pause of a specific length — the length a pause is when a screen has just shown someone a date — and she said my last visit was in November of 2022, and there was an opening tomorrow at four in the afternoon, if four was convenient.

Four was convenient. Four o'clock has been convenient since 2013.

She asked whether I had a preferred hygienist. I heard myself say no. She said Khun Kanda, then, and I agreed to

Khun Kanda without objection, and hung up, and stood in the kitchen for a while holding the phone against my chest, which is not where I hold phones.

I want to be accurate about the pretext, because I was not accurate with myself. The pretext was tartar. My tongue has been filing the same report every day for four years — a roughness behind the lower front teeth, mineral, patient, municipal — and every day for four years I have overruled it. On Monday I stopped overruling it. I did not ask why Monday and not any of the previous fourteen hundred days, because the answer was lying face-down on my desk with a photograph in it and a bowing rabbit in it, and some questions you do not ask because you already contain the answer and the answer is load-bearing.

I booked a cleaning because my teeth needed cleaning. I am leaving the sentence the way I said it to myself. You can watch it not hold.

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Tuesday at 7:47 the alarm went off, Radar, and the rotation had come round to template one, and I sent it: ငါ့
မိသ်. The cat came back at 7:53, the sleeping one, which as an answer to "are you awake yet" contains a level of editorial control I have decided not to think about. I ate rice standing up, did a revision pass for Kinnara — the son says the model uses "actually" too often, which means

it uses the word exactly as often as his father did; I recommended lowering it anyway, because we sell the remembered man, not the measured one — and at 3:40 I walked.

The clinic is twelve minutes from my building on foot: down Soi 26 to Sukhumvit, right along the front of the Emporium, past the BTS stairs where the motorcycle queue forms and re-forms all day, and into a side soi that has never once in thirteen years finished its road surface. For nine years I made that walk twice a year at 3:45. My legs still held the route; I arrived at the building with no memory of any decision made between my lobby and their soi.

The waiting room had been renovated at some point and had also not changed. The fish tank was gone. The laminated poster of the four stages of gum disease was the same poster, sun-cured now to a uniform tea color, stage one and stage four converged — the poster arriving, over the years, at a position on mortality. There was a QR code on the counter where the clipboard used to be. I filled in the form on my own phone. Under "current medications" the field accepted thirty characters. I typed "none." The field did not have space for the truth, and anyway the truth is a ledger, and I keep it elsewhere.

A schoolboy in uniform sat across from me with his mother, holding his jaw. Neither of them spoke. At 4:01 an assistant in lavender scrubs called my name into the room, mispronouncing it in the same place everyone

mispronounces it, and took me down the corridor to Room 3.

Room 3 was the room.

I don't know what I had allowed myself to expect. Clinics rearrange; equipment cycles; thirteen years is four generations of everything with a plug. But the chair was the same chair — I knew it before I could have told you how, and then the details arrived to file the claim: the re-stitched seam on the right of the headrest, done in a vinyl one shade warmer than the original; the chip in the rim of the round light's handle, small and crescent; the one ceiling tile that has sat two millimeters proud of its neighbors since at least 2016. A dental chair is one of the very few pieces of furniture engineered around surrender. It holds a human being who has agreed, for a fee, to be worked on inside the head, and everything about it — the recline, the padding under the knees, the counterweighted light — exists to make the agreement survivable. I have sat in exactly one of them since 2013. It was this one. I sat in it.

Khun Kanda came in reading my file on a tablet, greeted me with a wai I returned badly from a seated position, and snapped on her gloves. Her hands were broader than the hands I was calibrated to, shorter in the finger, with a pale groove on the ring finger where a ring had been parked for the shift. Competent hands. She lowered the chair to the angle I estimate at forty-four degrees, because I have had years to calibrate that too,

and swung the light around, and said we would start with scaling, there would be some sensitivity, please raise a left hand if I needed to stop.

Pui never said that. Pui said, the first time, in 2013: if it hurts, make the sound, and I'll know which kind.

"Four years," Khun Kanda said, to the tablet rather than to me. It was not a question, so I did not answer it. She surveyed my mouth with the mirror for a while, unhurried. "Long time," she said. Then she started, and I stopped being a person who could speak, and became what I had come there to become, which was the other thing.

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Here is what eighteen appointments are.

They are twelve hours. Forty minutes, twice a year, nine years, 2013 to 2022 — twelve hours, the length of a single working day, spread so thin across a decade that no one, including the two people inside them, would ever be forced to call the thing by a name. I paid \$1,800 each time. \$32,400 for the whole of it, receipts not kept, because in those years I was not yet a man who kept receipts. I have done the arithmetic of the hours for you once already. What I did not say the first time is what the hours were shaped like from the inside.

The shape was this: one of us could speak and one of us could not, and the assignment never rotated. She worked

inside my mouth with a scaler and a mirror, her face fifteen centimeters from mine, masked, capped, reduced to eyes and voice and hands, and she talked. And I lay under the round light with my conversational weaponry confiscated at the door — the deflection, the early joke that sets the room's temperature, the pivot to the topic where I am impressive — all of it disabled by hardware, and I listened. There is no other arrangement in my life that has ever disabled it. My marriage did not. Eleven years of my mother's Sunday calls did not. A woman with a scaler managed it twice a year for the price of a mid-range dinner, and I want to say I understood at the time what I was buying, but I understood it only partway: recognized on arrival, unavailable for production.

She talked about her mother's *khai jiao* and the correct height of the pour. About the traffic on Phetkasem, toward which she held a policy of exasperated diplomacy. About a patient that morning who had cried in the chair and blamed the water jet, and how she had adjusted the water jet, seriously, professionally, so that the blame would have somewhere to live. About whether the fish at the Emporium food hall was honest fish — her phrase — a question she reopened year after year, unsatisfied, the matter never closed to her own standard. The scar on the inside of her left wrist she told me in three installments, one per appointment, never out of order: the oil, the pan, the height of a nine-year-old pouring from the wrist because her arms were too short to pour from the

shoulder. Installment three ended with her mother's verdict, delivered while dressing the burn: now you know where khai jiao comes from. I waited a full year between installments and it did not occur to me once to be impatient, which for me is a clinical finding.

And she read me. I worked this out around the tenth appointment, which means it had been true for at least nine. The heavy questions came only mid-scaling, when everything I could return was a vowel, and she would watch my eyes for exactly the duration of the vowel and then hand the conversation back to the fish. Teeth first, though; before any of the questions, the teeth had already testified. The autumn my divorce finished, she stopped mid-molar and said, you're grinding again — not a question, an audit — and I made the vowel, and she said, mm, and recommended a night guard she knew I would not buy, and moved on, and I lay there having been known, comprehensively, painlessly, at 4:20 on a Tuesday, by the only method I had failed to armor against. Enamel is a ledger. It does not accept revisions. I have built a working life on the editability of records, and twice a year I paid a woman to read the one record I couldn't touch, and I called it dentistry, and so did she, and neither of us was lying. It was dentistry. That was what made it possible — the procedure was the honesty, the way the confessional screen is the confession.

I never saw her outside that room. Not once in nine years. I did not know her address, her food orders, her

feelings about films. I knew her wrists, her voice at fifteen centimeters, her reading of me, and the sound of her rolling stool crossing the floor, which I could identify today in a lineup of rolling stools. Whether that is knowing a person less than the standard method or more, I have taken no position on, publicly. The stickers were the whole of our written correspondence — reschedulings, confirmations, the rabbit bowing its thank-you — and I have already told you what the count came to, and who did the counting, and at what hour.

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Appointment thirteen was in April 2019, Songkran week, the city half-empty and the clinic's soi quiet enough that you could hear the aquarium pump in the waiting room, back when there was an aquarium. She was talking about the fair at the wat near her mother's place — there was a chestnut vendor down from the north, she said, who roasted them in a drum of black sand and gravel, and the sound, she said, was rain going backward.

Then she stopped talking. The scaler stayed where it was, resting against the lower left molars, not working, just present, and the suction hummed on my cheek, and she looked at my eyes instead of my teeth, which in nine years was rare enough that I noticed it as an event, and she said:

"เคยรู้สึกไหมคะ ว่าทั้งหมดนี้ไม่ใช่ของจริง"

I have carried the sentence for seven years, and it is the Thai that visits at two in the morning, not any translation I have made of it since. If I must give you one: Have you ever felt that all of this is not real. Of jing — genuine goods — is market language, the phrase a fish vendor uses when she swears the catch is what she says it is. She asked me, with her fingers in my mouth and a steel instrument resting on tooth number nineteen, whether I had ever felt that the entire consignment — the clinic, the soi, Songkran, the chestnut drum, the two of us — had failed inspection.

I made the vowel. It was all I had. She watched my eyes for the length of the vowel, the way she always did, and I have spent a fair portion of the last two years trying to reconstruct what my eyes said, because whatever they said, she read it, and what she did next was laugh — and the laugh arrived half a second late and at the wrong weight, a laugh selected rather than produced, and she said something about the heat doing strange things to everyone this year, and returned the scaler to work, and by the time my mouth was next free the conversation was standing somewhere else entirely, on the honest fish, and the door back was gone.

She never asked it again. Five appointments remained — fourteen through eighteen, three more years — and it never came back, and I never answered it. It did not frighten me that afternoon; that came later and slowly. What it did that afternoon was the thing a key does when

it turns in a lock you had furnished as a wall: no fear, just the click of a mechanism you now had to admit had been installed the whole time. She went to the fair that weekend. The avatar came from it — the paper cone of chestnuts, her face turned off-left toward something outside the frame, unexplained then, unexplained now. The photograph her contacts have looked at since 2019 was taken within days of the question, the chestnuts and the question in the same seven days, and when her account lit my phone at 2:47 last Friday it was that April looking out of the little circle. I decline to build anything on it. I am declining more slowly than I used to.

Appointment eighteen was November 2022. Her wrists had gone thin by then and she rested the scaler between teeth in a way she never used to, a half-second parking of the instrument that I clocked and misfiled under tiredness, because tiredness was the affordable reading. At the end she peeled her gloves, and told me to floss, without conviction, liturgy for the lapsed, and said: เจอกับ แพทย์.

There was no April. In June the clinic offered me Khun Kanda in the neutral voice, and I said I'd call back, and did not call back for three years, and the man who finally did call back did it because a dead woman's account had photographed him asleep. I am aware of how that sentence sounds. It is nevertheless the truth, and I went to the appointment.

Khun Kanda scaled for fifty minutes. Four years is a long geological era; she narrated none of it, worked in a clean silence broken by the instrument's frequencies and one remark about my lower right wisdom tooth, delivered flat, procedural, without alarm. When she finally raised the chair and I could speak, I asked — out of the small talk available to a numb mouth — whether the clinic had changed much.

She thought about it longer than the question deserved.

"They wanted to replace the chairs last year," she said. "Head office. These are better than the new ones. Heavier." She patted the armrest twice, proprietary, and that was the entire answer, and it was not an answer to my question, and I have told you before: nobody here answers the current question. The chair is staying. I noted it. I had no use for the note.

I had rehearsed asking about her. On the walk over I had drafted three versions — casual, archival, honest — of a question with Pui's name in it, and at the reception desk with my card out I heard myself ask instead whether they validated parking. I don't drive. The receptionist said the machine was in the lobby. I paid \$2,400 — the price of being read has gone up \$600 in four years, and the reading no longer comes with it — and kept the receipt, and booked the next cleaning for April because

the recall system suggested April, and said yes to April, four years late, to the wrong person, and left.

At the mouth of the soi a delivery rider in Grab green sat parked on his bike, engine off, visor down, doing nothing measurable. Bangkok manufactures ten thousand of him an hour. I walked past and thought nothing, and I am reporting the nothing because the nothing turns out to have been load-bearing too.

.

The wreath was on my floor when I came up at 6:40 that evening.

It stood on its wire easel outside unit 1708, five doors down the corridor from mine: a full funeral wreath, พวงหรีด, roughly seventy centimeters across, woven white. I stopped in front of it because a funeral wreath on your own floor stops you — a body-level protocol that runs before opinion. Then I stood there longer than protocol, because of the flowers.

They were dok rak, small waxy white five-pointed flowers Thai hands have strung into garlands for as long as anyone's grandmother can testify. You see them in ceremony malai, on spirit houses, on coffins. You do not usually see them massed into a wreath — wreath shops build with marigold and orchid and chrysanthemum, big blooms that fill fast. Whoever had made this had strung it flower by small flower, garland-style, hundreds of them

— a labor bill no shop would volunteer for. The ribbon across it was white satin, machine-printed: ด้วยความอาลัย. The line below, where the sender's name goes — the name being the entire social function of the object, the wreath being how this country signs its grief in public — was blank. A delivery slip taped to the easel's leg said 1708 and nothing else: no name, no shop, no phone. Unit 1708 is a flight attendant I have shared an elevator with perhaps six times in four years, a man with excellent luggage who is alive, and was, the juristic office told me when I called down, currently over the Gulf somewhere, flying, breathing, statistically fine. No one in the building had died. The office said it with flat certainty: ไม่มีใครเสียค่ะ. A delivery error. It happens. They would remove it in the morning.

A delivery error. I stood in the corridor with the explanation in one hand, and it held everywhere except at the floor. Somebody had ordered this specific wreath, in this specific unfashionable flower, built in this specific archaic way, sent to this specific building, with no name for the dead and no name for the sender, and the error, if it was an error, was one digit wide. My unit is 1703. A handwritten 3, looped a little generously, is an 8 to a tired eye. I did the arithmetic in the corridor and then I un-did it, deliberately, in reverse order, because a man who starts assigning himself the wreaths of strangers has a diagnosis, and I had promised myself to stay on the instrument side of that line.

The ribbon moved slightly in the corridor's air-conditioning. Satin, synthetic, catching the strip light along its fold.

Zhuangzi dreamed he was a butterfly — the oldest card in the deck, I know, and I am playing it anyway, because the ribbon dealt it. In the dream there was no Zhuangzi: only the butterfly, complete, pleased with itself, doing exactly whatever it pleased. Then he woke, and there he lay, unmistakably Zhuangzi — and could not establish whether he was a man who had dreamed the butterfly, or a butterfly now dreaming the man. The passage is usually retailed as a puzzle about knowledge. It is a puzzle about preference. The butterfly did not know there was a question, and was happy. The man knew there was a question, and wrote it down, which is not the same as happiness. And the text's last line, the one the retellings drop, is the strange consolation: between the man and the butterfly there must be some distinction — this is called the transformation of things. Some distinction. It does not say which side is real. It says only that a border exists, that things cross it routinely in both directions, and that naming the crossing was apparently enough for Zhuangzi to get up and continue being whichever one he was. I have never managed the trick. I stood in a corridor on the seventeenth floor, between a wreath with no dead and a door with no wreath, and the ribbon lifted and settled in the air-conditioning, saying the one thing it had been printed to say. With sorrowful remembrance. It

did not say from whom. It did not say for whom. Those are the two facts a ribbon exists to carry, and it had arrived carrying neither, and it was still the most articulate object on the floor.

I went inside. The strip of receipt paper was in the jamb, folded, exactly where I leave it. The glass on the windowsill held its two fingers of water. Everything in the unit was mine and in its place, and I sat down at the desk with the door locked behind me and understood that I was going to do the thing I had been not-doing for four days, and that the wreath had not caused it, merely removed the last plausible date for further delay.

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I opened LINE at 11:31 p.m. Her chat sat where it always sits, pinned nowhere, found by muscle. At the top, the photograph of me asleep in a night that never happened. Below it, the rabbit, bowing, forty-second of its line.

I typed: မိန့်ချက်. I looked at it for two full seconds before I understood what my thumbs had done — template five, the control, the word I ship to Roi Et every fifth morning — and I deleted it with something close to nausea, one character at a time.

I typed, in English: This isn't funny. Deleted it. Whatever was on the other end, it was not joking. Comedy requires a shared floor, and the floor was the entire question.

I typed a third draft that ran nine lines, with subclauses. It set out the possibilities in courteous rows: the recycled SIM, the compromised account, the timestamp bug, the door left open for whoever this really was to step through with dignity intact, no police, no anger, just tell me which one you are. I read it back twice. It was a negotiation. You negotiate with someone who wants something, and four days in, nothing had been asked of me except attention. I deleted it and sat with the empty field and the cursor blinking at whatever rate cursors blink, which I have never measured, which tells you the state I was in.

I typed her name. ပုံ့. One syllable and a question mark. That one I deleted fastest of all, because a name is a knock, and I know exactly how long I have been declining to knock, and there is a closet in my hallway that could testify.

The fifth draft was three words and I sent it at 11:52, because 11:52 is an hour that belongs to no one — not to her account and its 2:47, not to my alarm and its 7:47, an hour with no architecture in it, chosen for that reason with a care I recognize, in hindsight, as prayer conducted in the only denomination I have left.

ใครอยู่ตรงนั้น

Who is there. No question mark. A question mark would have been an offered exit, and I did not want to offer the exit. I wanted the sentence to stand in the doorway the way the photographer had stood in mine.

The word อ่านแล้ว appeared under it before the sending animation had finished. Read. Not after a minute, which would have meant a person; not after an hour, which would have meant a person with a life; instantly, in the same breath as delivery — reading and arriving compressed into a single event.

Then nothing. No typing indicator. No rabbit. I sat at the desk with the phone flat in front of me and the wreath five doors away and the water glass holding its level, and I watched the nothing with my full attention until well past her hour, and her hour passed empty, and I want to be precise about what the nothing was, because precision is still the only virtue I have available. The message had been read. Reading is an act. Somewhere — a server floor, a phone-shop drawer, a desk I could not yet imagine in a building I had not yet seen — something had received three words in Thai asking who it was, and had elected, out of every possible reply, silence. And silence, from an account that had spent four days demonstrating it could reach into my bedroom, was not an absence of answer. It was an answer with the modesty switched on.

I had asked. That was the change of state, and I knew it as a change of state even then, with the ink still wet on it. Four days of being observed, and I had finally observed back — one message, three words, logged, read, filed. Whatever had been waiting had not been waiting for proof of anything. It had been waiting, I think now, for exactly this: for me to start asking.

The read receipt did not blink or update or elaborate.
อ่านแล้ว. Read already. Past tense, and the most present-
tense object on my phone: somewhere, right then, a
there, with a someone in it, keeping the light off and
saying nothing.

CHAPTER 4

The Man in the Green Jacket

On Wednesday I took the garbage down at six in the morning, because I had been awake since her hour came and went with nothing in it, and because a man carrying a garbage bag has a reason to be standing anywhere. The wreath was already gone from 1708. Two small dents remained in the corridor carpet where the easel's feet had stood, a hand's width apart, and by Thursday the cleaner's vacuum would take those too, and then the only evidence that anyone had mourned outside the flight attendant's door would be a delivery slip in a juristic office file with a numeral that could be read two ways.

The lobby smelled of the mop water they use before the residents are awake. I put the bag in the room behind the mailboxes and went out to the soi for no reason I prepared in advance, and that was when I saw him the

first time — the first time I let myself count, which is a different thing.

He was across the soi from the building's mouth, on a Honda Wave the color of every Honda Wave, in the green jacket, with the green cube box on the rack behind him. Side-stand down. Engine off. Visor down, at six in the morning, facing my building. I noted the time, 6:04, because noting times is what I have instead of instincts. And I noted the other thing, the thing that made the picture wrong in a way I couldn't name until I stood in the 7-Eleven's light later and named it: he was not on his phone.

A rider at rest lives inside his phone. The phone is the job, the dispatcher, the map, the wife, the football, the debt. A rider without his phone out is a fisherman whose line is not in the water. You can wait, or you can fish, but a man doing neither is doing something else, and there is no third thing a rider does at the mouth of a soi at six in the morning with his engine cold and his visor sealed.

I walked past him at a distance of four meters. The visor turned nothing toward me. The box on the rack carried no restaurant sticker, no order slip taped to the lid. I bought a Birdy from the 7-Eleven at the corner, ฿19, kept the receipt, and when I came out he was gone, and the place where he had been was just Bangkok again, which is the trouble with Bangkok. It reabsorbs. The city closes over evidence, and you stand there holding your receipt.

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At the desk I opened the notebook to a new page and did what I should have done five days earlier: I stopped keeping a paranoia column and started keeping a log.

Date. Time. Place. Plate. Phone — yes or no. Engine — on or off. Visor.

Then I back-filled from memory, which is bad practice, and flagged the entries as back-filled, which is the best you can do about bad practice. Saturday the twenty-second, around eight in the evening, Sukhumvit 22, mouth of the sub-soi: three riders, visors up, eating from bags balanced on their mirrors, phones propped against their fuel caps. I wrote them in and marked them, after some thought, as the control group. That is what they were: ordinary rider behavior, logged so the other kind would have something to be measured against.

Tuesday the twenty-fifth, 3:56 in the afternoon, the mouth of the clinic's soi: one rider, engine off, visor down. Phone — not observed. I wrote "not observed" and hated it. I had walked past a data point with my eyes open and collected nothing, because on Tuesday I was still a man on his way to a dental appointment, and the discipline of a man on his way to a dental appointment is aimed inward, at his own jaw.

Wednesday the twenty-sixth, 6:04, my own soi: engine off, visor down, phone no. Plate: I had it, 2๗๐ 1957,

because plates are numbers and numbers stay with me whether I invite them or not.

Three entries, one of them a control. It was not a pattern. I want to be exact about that, because exactness is the only fence between me and the ledger in my other drawer: three sightings of green motorcycle jackets in five days, in a city that may contain two hundred thousand green motorcycle jackets, is not a pattern. It is weather. The question I wrote at the bottom of the page was the only honest question available: how do you distinguish one raindrop from rain?

.

I used to teach this, is the embarrassing part. In another decade, in another version of the man, I made third-year students stand on the Asok footbridge with clickers and count pedestrian flows for two hours, morning and evening, until they understood that a city is not a picture but a set of rates. If I sent those students out today and told them to count delivery riders, they would come back with nothing usable, and it would not be their fault. You cannot count the riders. They are not a population, they are a condition. You do not count rain. You read its rate.

They came with the apps, and they came fast — within four or five years the city had a new layer, between the traffic and the pedestrians, occupying the mouths of sois the way water occupies the low ground. Every soi has its

rank now. They wait at the 7-Eleven, at the shrine railing, on the footbridge stairs, and the waiting is legitimate, is the job itself, so no one asks a waiting rider what he is waiting for. The uniform does the rest. Green jacket, green box, helmet: the company bought their faces and issued them a color. A motorcycle taxi vest has a soi number and a queue and regulars who know the driver's knees are bad; a rider has a rating. He is, by design, whichever man is nearest. We built an entire class of person around the principle of interchangeability and then agreed, all of us, without anyone remembering signing anything, not to see them — to treat a man on a motorcycle as a unit of pending food.

Which is why it took me five days. Not because the man in the green jacket was hidden. Because he was ambient. A uniform the whole city has already filed under weather is the only camouflage that has ever worked on me completely, and if I were a system that needed to stand a man on a corner in Bangkok and have twelve million people vouch, without being asked, for his right to be there, I would dress him in exactly this green, and I would not need to invent anything. The city had already invented it for the food.

I closed the notebook on the log and the log's first rule, which I had written at the top of the page in block letters: **EVERY GREEN GETS LOGGED. NO EXCEPTIONS FOR BEING NORMAL.**

At 7:47 Wednesday the alarm went off, Radar, and the rotation had come round to template two, and I sent it: ฅู ฅำวยัง. The cat came back at 7:54, the eating one, which was either an answer or a mirror. On Thursday, template three, อย่ำลืบร๋บ, and the cat with the umbrella arrived at 7:50, and outside my window the sky was staging its usual late-August argument with itself, so for once the template did honest work.

Her account sent nothing on Wednesday night and nothing on Thursday night. I checked at 2:47 both nights, awake at the desk, phone flat, and both nights the chat showed what it had shown since Tuesday: my three words, ใคอยู่ตรงนั้น, and under them ว่างแล้ว, and under that a silence with its modesty still switched on. Read, and no more. Whatever had opened its eyes when I asked was apparently content to have established that it had eyes.

The cleaner came Thursday at ten. I stayed home while she worked, which I have not done in years, and sat at the desk pretending the desk needed me. She has cleaned this unit every Thursday for six years. She dusted the bookshelf and lifted the offline camera and set it down in the same orientation, because she is precise, and I found I was watching her hands, and I made myself stop.

At 3:26 that afternoon I stood at the drinks cooler of the 7-Eleven at the mouth of the soi with the door open

and the cold rolling out against my shins, and I picked up a bottle of น้ำลำไย, brown-gold, cold enough already to sweat in my hand. I don't know why I picked it up. It was hot, I had slept in units again, the bottle was cold. I held it long enough for the label to warm under my thumb. Then I did the arithmetic a forty-four-year-old does about sugar at three in the afternoon, and put it back, aligned with its row, and bought two Birdys instead, ฿38, from the clerk with the star tattooed on the back of her neck, home ink, five points, slightly listing. I kept the receipt. Receipt number 1147, 15:27. I am telling you these numbers now because of what the numbers did later.

At 3:58 I walked past the mouth of the clinic's soi, which was not on my way to anything. I had decided to have no way; I decided each turn at the turn, by whichever foot was leading. There was a rider at the soi mouth. Engine off. Visor down. Phone no. Plate 1๗๙ 8804 — a different plate. There is always a different plate. I logged him from the far pavement and walked on and did not look back, because looking back is data you give away for free.

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The receipt was under my door on Friday morning.

I found it at 6:10, going out. It had been folded twice into a strip and slid beneath the door's sweep, and the first thing I did — before reading it, and I take a certain

cold professional pride in this ordering — was check the jamb. The strip of receipt paper I keep folded in the door jamb, hinge side, at knee height, the habit I brought home from a hotel in Shanghai, was exactly where I had set it. The door had not been opened. Whatever had arrived had come flat, along the floor, under the sweep, from the corridor of a building whose lift requires a resident key card after ten at night.

I unfolded it on the kitchen counter under the hood light.

Thermal paper. The header of the 7-Eleven at the mouth of my soi — branch number 08214, which I have known by heart for years, because it heads a nine-year drift of receipts in my drawer. Tax ID. POS 2. Date: Thursday the twenty-seventh. Time: 15:26.

One item.

น้ำลำไย 1 × 25.00 รวม 25.00 เงินสด 25.00

Receipt number 1146.

I stood there for some time. The refrigerator changed registers behind me. Then I went to the drawer and took out Thursday's real receipt, mine, the two Birdys, and set the two slips side by side on the counter, and they sat there being siblings. Number 1146 and number 1147. Same branch, same terminal, one minute apart. The till's own memory says that at 15:26 somebody stood where I was standing and paid twenty-five baht in cash for the drink I was holding, and put it back — except that nobody did, because I was the man at that cooler at 15:26, and the aisle

was empty, and the drink went back on the shelf with its label warmed by my thumb, unsold, aligned with its row.

Somewhere in the world there is a printed record of a purchase that consists entirely of my hesitation. Itemized. Paid in full. Slid under my door.

I made coffee, because after the photograph I had learned that the correct response to the impossible is a procedure, and while the water came up I ran the tree, honestly, branch by branch, because that is the one obligation my own character has never once let me skip.

Branch one: ad-tech. The phone in my pocket, the beacons in the store, the machinery that knows a man paused in the beverage aisle. I have written adjacent software; I know what the industry can infer and what it merely claims at conferences. It can put a longan-juice advertisement in front of me for a week. It addresses screens. It does not print on the store's own till, one serial number ahead of my real purchase, and it does not employ anyone whose job is a fourth-floor corridor at night.

Branch two: audio. I said nothing at the cooler. I thought about sugar. Thought is not audio. Cameras, then — the store has two, and there exist models, common knowledge in my own adjacent trade, trained to watch a shopper's hand and mark the frame where wanting becomes not-buying. Retail calls it intent analytics and buys it by the month. Fine. Grant the camera, grant the model, grant that some system marked my frame. The

output of such a system is a dashboard in a head office. Between a dashboard and a folded slip under my door stands a printer, a person, a motorcycle, a key card, and a motive, and the branch snaps under the weight of the middle three.

Branch three: coincidence. Somebody genuinely bought a longan juice at 15:26 — the register misfired its sequence, or I misread the aisle's emptiness — and their dropped receipt traveled four hundred meters and one lift ride and chose, among the two hundred and twelve doors of this building, mine. I sat with this one longest, because coincidence deserves counsel; it is dismissed first and innocent most often. But coincidence is not a low card you can count on being somewhere in the deck. It is the joker. You may deal it to yourself once. I had already spent it, weeks of it, on wreaths and riders, and the deck does not hold two.

Branch four: a person. Someone ringing the sale and voiding it, keeping the slip, walking it here. The clerk with the star tattoo. Golf. A neighbor. This is the branch a sane man is supposed to prefer, and I gave it its full hour. It requires a human being to have watched my hand at the cooler at 15:26, obtained the slip the till says exists, entered a key-carded building, and delivered, for no money and at real risk, a document whose entire content is: we saw you decide against something. As harassment it is inefficient. As a joke it has no punchline and no audience. As a message it is flawless, which is the

problem, because flawless messages are not what people produce. People produce misspellings and grudges you can trace.

Each branch held. None of them reached the ground. I wrote that sentence in the notebook, and then I wrote the other sentence, the one the coffee had gone cold waiting for: the photograph knew where I sleep. The receipt knows what I almost do. The instrument set is improving.

.

Thermal paper carries no ink. I did not know this until years ago a receipt I needed for a warranty came out of the drawer blank, and I looked it up with the specific irritation of a man who has just been quietly robbed. The paper is coated with a dye that stays colorless until heat touches it; the printer writes with a hot wire, and what you carry out of the shop is not a document in any old sense but a pattern of small burns. Scar tissue arranged into numbers. And it is fugitive — heat undoes it, sunlight undoes it, time alone undoes it; leave a receipt on a dashboard in this city and by Songkran it is a white flag. The archives of the state are acid-free and meant to outlive the officials who sign them. The archive of everyone else — the poor, the careful, the audited, me — is written in disappearing burn marks, itemized to the satang and fading on a schedule nobody prints on the back. Every 7-Eleven in the country issues you a record

and a countdown in the same slip. Whatever had begun corresponding with me had chosen this medium: exact to the minute, and designed to forget itself. I photographed receipt 1146 twice under the hood light, sealed it in a zip-lock bag with Thursday's date on a strip of masking tape, and put it in the drawer where the burns are kept out of the sun.

.

Friday afternoon I walked to Sukhumvit 22. Not to buy. I told myself it was to log the location, and that was even true.

The rider was at the mouth of the sub-soi where the control group had eaten. One bike, engine off, visor down, phone no, plate 3CUG 662 — a different plate. I stood across the mouth of the soi and logged him openly, notebook out, pen moving, watching the visor for any acknowledgment that a subject knows it has become one. The visor gave back the street, curved and small, with a man in it.

Golf was in his doorway when I turned, under the Middle Path sign, a jar in one hand.

He looked at my hands, which were carrying nothing but the notebook. "Not buying."

"Calibrating," I said. "I'm cutting the dose in half for a while. I want to see what's the smoke and what's the street."

Golf nodded once, on the exhale, his agreement compressed into the same small breathing exercise it always was. He looked past me at the mouth of the sub-soi, at the bike, and the look lasted longer than looks he wastes.

"The eaters, I like," he said. "Riders know every kitchen in the city and they get eleven minutes. Best diners we have." He tipped the jar a few degrees, read its angle, tipped it back. "That one doesn't eat."

"You've seen him before."

"I've seen the jacket before," Golf said, which was answered so precisely to the wrong question that it took me until Rama IV, hours later, to understand it was the exact answer to the right one. "Maybe he's fasting. Even hungry ghosts get their day of the month." He laughed at his own line, in advance, apologetically, and went inside to his jars.

That night I entered it in the ledger: ๔๗๕ 28 ส.ค. — Elephant Grass 0.2 — 21:20. Half of 0.4. The resolution came up only half a step past what the world needs; the curtain kept most of its grain to itself. Saturday I skipped entirely and wrote the dash. I halved the dose, and then I zeroed it, and this was the test, stated in advance in my own handwriting so I could not grade it on a curve: paranoia scales with dose. Weather doesn't.

Saturday at 7:47, Radar, and the rotation came round to template five, and for the first time in some four hundred and thirty mornings I sat with my thumb over

the send arrow and did not press it for eleven seconds.
နိုင်ငံ. I had typed that word once already this month, to a
dead woman's account, at midnight, and deleted it with
my stomach turning over, and now the rotation was
handing it back. I sent it, because a control you skip stops
being a control. The cat came back at 7:52, the one in the
graduation cap, which I have never learned to read.
Median is 7:52. Everything in its channel.

At 5:38 that afternoon the man in the green jacket was
at the mouth of my soi, and I halved nothing, and he had
halved nothing, and I went down.

.

I want the mechanics of it on the record, because the
mechanics are the strangest thing I have.

I came out of the lobby and crossed toward him at an
ordinary walking pace, and at thirty meters — I paced it
off afterward against the shophouse fronts — the Wave's
engine took, quietly, no throttle, and he rolled. Not away.
Ahead. He drifted down Soi 26 at the speed of a man
walking with intent, ten, twelve kilometers an hour, and
held the gap. When I slowed at a stall and stood for a full
three minutes handling rambutans I had no plans for, the
bike waited at the next corner beside a utility pole, engine
idling so low the sound kept losing itself under the soi's
ordinary noise. When I crossed to the other pavement, he
let two blocks pass and drifted across too. I took out the

phone and photographed him twice. The first frame contains most of a truck. The second contains all of a bus. I have the photographs. They are pictures of Bangkok traffic, which is what any lawyer, any friend, any version of me from six weeks ago would tell you they are.

Soi 26 runs south and gives out onto Rama IV, and he led me — I am using the verb the mechanics earned — across Rama IV with the crossing light, which a rider fleeing does not use, and into Khlong Toei.

The market was changing shifts around me, the day side hosing down, fish water braided with rain water along the gutters, ice trucks backing into the dark with their beepers going, the night vendors setting up under bulbs the color of longan flesh. Past the market the sois go industrial: godowns, freight yards, stacked blue containers, the port's cranes standing over everything against the last of the light. I walked forty-one minutes by the phone's count. The bike held its thirty meters the whole way, through turns I could not have predicted because I was not predicting them, and somewhere along Sunthon Kosa Road I stopped pretending to myself that I was following him. You do not follow at a constant gap for forty-one minutes. You are towed.

The gates were in a fence topped with three courses of barbed wire, in a soi that smelled of diesel and dried squid and, under those, faintly, of ammonia — the old refrigerant ghost that never leaves a cold-storage building, the smell of decades of holding things at a

temperature they didn't choose. The building behind the fence was the real thing: pre-war walls a meter thick if they were anything, the small high vents of a warehouse built to be sealed, and along the second story a course of bricked-in windows, newer brick in older wall, openings that had been eyes once and had been deliberately filled. At the old loading dock somebody had installed a new aluminum-and-glass door, and above the gate, on a white panel, small, was a blue square logo and lettering in a typeface with no opinions.

The shift was arriving. Motorcycles came in past me in ones and twos, and a songthaew emptied eleven people at the gate, women mostly, lunch bags and cardigans — cardigans, in August, which told me the building kept its old habits about temperature. And there were riders at the gate, three or four of them, green jackets, handing food bags across to the arriving shift, and my rider slotted in among them the way a raindrop returns to rain. He put the bike in the rank along the fence. He dismounted. He walked into the knot of green at the gate with a bag or without one, I could not tell, and the knot shifted, and bodies moved through bodies, and when the group loosened there were four jackets, then five, then three, and none of them was him, or any of them was. I counted them in and I counted them out and the arithmetic refused to convict anyone. Sixty meters is sixty meters. A uniform is a uniform. That is the entire design.

I stood at the gate until the guard in the booth took an interest. He was sixty or so, luk thung coming small and tinny out of a radio on his shelf, hands laced over his stomach, and he looked at me carefully and without hurry, the specific attention gate men keep in reserve for farang-adjacent men in clean shirts who arrive on foot in freight sois at seven in the evening.

"ที่นี้บริษัทอะไรครับ" I asked him.

"ห้ามจอดตรงหน้าประตู," he said, to the motorcycles, to history, to me — the same four words gate men have kept in reserve since gates existed. Then, after a moment, because Thai kindness leaks around Thai procedure even when procedure has already answered, he nodded back at the building and added: "กะดึกเขาเข้ากันแล้ว. นั่งดูหนังกันทั้งคืน ทั้งดึก. แอร์เย็นเหมือนสมัยเก็บปลา."

He had not named the company. He had told me, instead, that the night shift was filing in now, that the whole building would sit up watching something until dawn, and that the air conditioning still ran at whatever temperature the place had kept for the fish, because nobody had ever filed the paperwork to ask it to warm up.

I looked past him at the white panel over the gate. The blue square, and beside it, in letters I copied into the notebook one at a time, in capitals, the copying itself slow and careful, a word in a language I did not yet read:

COGNITA (THAILAND) CO., LTD.

Under it I wrote the time, 18:51, and the plate of the parked Wave, 2๖๑ 1957 — Wednesday's plate, my soi's

plate, the first repetition in the log, the first raindrop with a serial number — and I stood there while the last of the cardigans went in through the aluminum door and the door closed on its pneumatic hinge with the sound of something sealing to specification. The building was not an answer. It was exactly what it was: a structure built to hold something cold for a very long time, its windows bricked to keep it that way, and somewhere inside it, in cardigans, under air-conditioning set to the fish's old requirements, the watching of videos was beginning for the night.

I walked home. It took fifty-two minutes, and the city was full of green jackets the whole way, every one of them weather, every one of them eating.

PART TWO

THE NIGHT SHIFT

CHAPTER 5

The Ledger

On Monday morning I bought a kilo of mandarins at Sam Yan market for \$120, from a vendor who weighed them with one hand and rebagged them with the other, her fingers finding the bruised one by touch and swapping it out without looking, a correction so practiced it had stopped being a decision. Then I carried the bag across Banthat Thong Road and up the staircase of a shophouse three doors down from a shuttered photo lab — twenty-two steps to the second floor, nineteen to the third, the count uneven because somewhere in 1968 the builder had run short of something, patience or concrete — and knocked on a door that had a spirit house's worth of dust on its transom and a doorbell that had been painted over, twice, in two different decades of green.

The 7:47 message that morning had been template two. ก็น้ำว้าง. The eating cat came back at 7:51, chopsticks

raised, and I put the phone in my bag with the mandarins and did not think about the fact that I found the cat reassuring. There is a limit to how much of yourself you can put in the notebook.

Sunday I had done laundry, logged nothing — the rider column stayed empty all day, and I wrote that down too, because an instrument that only records positives is an instrument you have already corrupted — and at 21:15 I had smoked 0.4 grams of Elephant Grass by the bedroom window, the dose test being over and the verdict filed. At 2:47 both nights, nothing. The chat still ended where it had ended for a week: my four words, her read receipt, and below them the kind of white space you can hear.

And on Sunday afternoon I had called Ajarn Direk.

I should explain how I had his number, which is that in 2019 I attended the cremation of Ajarn Somsak, who taught structures to three decades of architecture students and died of exactly the kind of heart he had told us never to design, and at the temple a man with an oxygen tube coiled into his shirt pocket had asked me whether I still measured things. I said I did. He said, "Then you'll need this eventually," and gave me a card with nothing on it but his name and eleven digits. Direk taught epistemology at Chulalongkorn for thirty-one years. I took his elective in my third year because it met after lunch and I have kept perhaps six sentences from it for twenty-three years, which by the arithmetic of lectures is a spectacular yield.

He answered on the ninth ring.

"အိပ်."

I said my name, the year I graduated, the elective.

A pause with breathing in it, mechanical at the edges.

Then: "ဝဲဝဲ. The one who left."

I had left academia fourteen years ago. He had retired eleven years ago. In his bookkeeping, apparently, only one of those counted as leaving.

"I have something," I said. "I don't know what column it goes in."

"Monday," he said. "After nine. The machine and I are better before noon." And hung up, before I could ask what machine, though by then I had already heard it, keeping time behind his voice.

He opened the door wearing a pressed shirt buttoned to the collar and trousers with a crease, which moved me in a way I did not examine, and a clear tube that ran from his nose down his chest and away along the skirting board into the room behind him, fifteen meters of it at least, taped down at the corners with the yellowed tape of a job done once and correctly. Behind him the machine sat against the wall, white, the size of a nightstand: a concentrator, sighing every four seconds — a click and then a long exhale, like someone agreeing with a point nobody had made.

"You brought fruit," he said. "Students bring fruit when they want the answer before the examination."

"I'm forty-four."

"Then you should know better than to want that." He stepped back to let me in. "Peel one anyway. The smell is the part that still works."

The room was the whole width of the shophouse and had been a serious room for a long time. Books in Thai, English, and German went up the walls in an order I could not read but did not doubt. A desk with a green glass lamp. A daybed with the sheet drawn drum-tight. And by the window, on a low table of its own, a Go board — thick, on short legs, its wood gone the gold of forty years of hands — with a game on it. A hundred and forty stones, maybe more, the position dense in the lower right and open at the top, where nothing had been decided yet. Two lidded bowls sat beside it, and beside those, face down, a photograph.

I did not ask. He watched me not ask.

"It's mid-game," I said.

"It has been mid-game for eleven years," he said, and lowered himself into the chair by the desk with the concentrator counting behind him, and that was the whole of the subject for the day. Sometimes you can tell where a door is by the care with which a man walks around it.

I peeled a mandarin and put it on a saucer he pointed to. He ate one segment, slowly, and set the rest aside, and the smell of it filled the room, which was exactly what he had promised, and for a while neither of us performed any conversation, which I appreciated. The fan turned.

Traffic came up off Banthat Thong in its own tide. Across the road, at the mouth of the soi opposite, I had logged a green jacket on my way in — 09:48, engine off, visor down, not eating, not on his phone, plate 4UU 1220, the seventh entry in the log and a new plate — and from Direk's window I could see the sub-soi's corner and could not see whether he was still there, and I chose, as an act of discipline, not to stand up and check.

"So," Direk said. "Show me the thing with no column."

I took out my phone and opened the photograph and handed it to him.

He held it at arm's length, then took glasses from his shirt pocket and held it closer. He looked at it for a long time. His thumb moved once and enlarged it, and he looked again, quadrant by quadrant, as systematically as I had at 3 a.m. on the twenty-first of August, though it had taken me four hours to get there and it took him about ninety seconds.

"Who took it?" he said.

"I don't know."

"That isn't an answer to the question. The question has an answer. You not knowing it is a separate fact about you." He set the phone face down on the Go table, next to the other face-down photograph, which I decided not to find significant. "Tell it in order. Dates. Amounts. Don't interpret."

So I told it in order, with dates and amounts, and did not interpret, and it took forty minutes: the message at

2:47 on the twenty-first, the EXIF stamp that said the following night, the pillowcases and the \$790 that dated them, the vigil, the camera that recorded nine hours of an empty bed, the sticker, the read receipt that arrived before the send animation finished, the wreath with the blank sender line, the receipt for the longan drink I had considered and not bought, serial 1146 to my 1147, the riders — the log, the plates, the behavioral tell, the control group — and the forty-one minutes on foot into Khlong Toei, and the building that had once kept fish. He stopped me twice. Once to ask the exact wording of the message I had sent — "ใ้รออยู่ตรงนั้น," I said; "no question mark" — and he nodded, the punctuation apparently the part that mattered to him. And once, at the receipt, to ask whether the phantom one was printed before or after mine. Before, I said. 15:26 to my 15:27. He sat with that for a moment.

"The drink you did not buy was rung up one minute before the drinks you did," he said. "So it isn't reading your outcomes. It's reading your considerations, and it is doing so slightly upstream of you." He said it without inflection, already moving on. Then: "Say the name of the company again."

"Cognita. Cognita Thailand Company Limited."

"Cognita," he said. "Latin. The things that are known. Passive, plural, neuter. Not the knowing — the known. Whoever chose it was thinking of the material." He

tapped one finger on the table, twice. "You copied a word in a language you don't read. As it happens, I read it."

The concentrator clicked and sighed.

"In March 2016," Direk said, without any announcement that we were changing subjects, because we were not, "a machine played a professional Go match against the strongest human player of his generation. Lee Sedol. Seoul, the Four Seasons hotel, five games. You know this."

"I know the headline."

"The headline is the least of it. Second game, the tenth of March. Move thirty-seven. The machine is black. It plays a shoulder hit on the fifth line, on the right side." He turned to the board beside him and touched the empty upper region with two fingers, not placing anything, just locating it in the air above the wood. "You are not a Go player. Third line is territory, fourth is influence — we teach children that much. The fifth line belongs to no one. In four thousand years of recorded games, you attach on the fifth line at that moment approximately never. The machine's own tables said a human would play that move one time in ten thousand. The commentators assumed the operator had misclicked. Lee Sedol looked at it, stood up, and left the room. He was gone fifteen minutes. Then he came back and lost."

"A mistake that worked?"

"No. That is what everyone needed it to be, and it was not. It was a move that was seen to be beautiful —

afterward, and by everyone, including the man it defeated. The European champion said, 'It's not a human move.' He meant it as a description, and it became a compliment. The machine had not calculated something we were too slow for. It had wanted something we did not know was there to want." He took a breath that had procedure in it, the tube shifting against his collar. "The machine's descendants have not lost a meaningful game since. Lee Sedol retired in 2019. He said he had come to know an entity that cannot be defeated, and stood up from the board, permanently, and no one who understood the position blamed him."

"And the inversion," I said, because I could hear it arriving from three sentences away.

"The machine proved it could surprise us," Direk said. "Nothing we have done since has proved we can surprise it."

The fan turned through that a few times.

"Third drawer of the desk," he said. "Under the tickets."

The third drawer held a brick of lottery tickets bound with a rubber band — years of them, the top ones faded to the color of weak tea — and underneath, squared with the drawer's edge, a stack of school notebooks. Māh-Bunčhong, the cheap kind, cardboard covers, multiplication tables printed on the back in a grid, twelve twelves and out, the manufacturer having imagined no need beyond that. Nine of them. The spines were numbered in pencil. I brought the ninth to him and he

waved it away and had me put it on the Go table and open it myself, which I understood later was the pedagogy: you read a ledger; you are not read to from one.

His handwriting was very small and very upright, in pencil, and each page was ruled by hand into three columns. The first column was the event. The second was the arithmetic — what should have happened, at what odds, by what reference. The third column was headed with one word: ผู้ตรวจ.

"Eleven years," Direk said. "Two hundred and eleven entries. I log anything that arrives claiming to be impossible. Most of it is lottery, because in this country the lottery is where the impossible goes to register itself — twice a month, the first and the sixteenth, a national census of hope conducted to six digits. The rest is weather, strangers, and machines. And of the two hundred and eleven," he said, "two hundred and six have an author."

I turned pages. Each entry was dated to the day. 16 ก.พ. 2561 — a vendor in Chachoengsao sells the first-prize ticket three draws running; column two worked the odds honestly, one in some millions; column three, in the small upright pencil: ผู้ตรวจ — เจ้ามือ. Ticket routing, he explained: resale networks, winning tickets bought back and re-sold at markup to people who want to buy luck across a counter. 3 ส.ค. 2562 — a man in a yellow polo shirt seen by one of his former students at the Nakhon Sawan bus station at 09:40 and again at Hua Lamphong at

16:05 the same day, 240 kilometers apart, same shirt, same bag. Column three: မျက်လှဲ — ရေခဲ. There is a van that does it in three and a half hours; the student simply did not believe other people's days could be more strenuous than his own. Entry after entry in the same shape. The odds honestly computed, the strangeness honestly weighed, and then the author found — ad-tech, arithmetic, fraud, memory, the sample space drawn wrong, the human preference for stories with hands in them. It was the most disappointing document I had ever wanted to keep reading. It was eleven years of a man building the instrument that could detect the thing by proving, two hundred and six times, that it had not detected it.

"And the five," I said.

"Page forty," he said. "Volume six. But the ninth has one."

I found it. 14 ဩ.၈. 2560 — rain over Bang Khen district, forty-one minutes, measured at two stations, on a day the Meteorological Department had issued a zero percent forecast — and the zero, he had noted in column two, was not rounding; the model output was archived and he had requested it and it said what it said. Column three: blank. Not dashed, not marked pending. Genuinely blank — an entry with nowhere yet to put its answer.

"Radar misses cells all the time," I said.

"It does. That is entry ninety-three, and entry one-forty, and entry one-sixty-two, all authored, all rain." He

tipped his chin at the page. "That one I kept because I stood in it."

"And the other blanks?"

"A woman on a bridge in Phitsanulok and a woman on a bridge in Sing Buri, the same afternoon, described identically by two of my former students who have never met. A bell. I won't discuss the bell." He turned his hand over on the notebook, palm up, a small concession. "And the tails. Since 2015, the last two digits of the first prize have ended in four-four seven times. Two hundred and sixty-odd draws; expectation says under three. The chi-squared test shrugs. Seven is not impossible." He paused for the machine to finish its exhale. "It is merely insistent. And insistence deserves a page even when impossibility hasn't earned one. If you only log what cannot happen, you will miss what keeps happening."

I am forty-four years old. Pui's clinic laid me back at forty-four degrees for eighteen appointments. I noted both facts — the same instinct that had already logged her hour and mine as exactly five hours apart — and put them where I put that: in the column of things I refuse to build with. The column was getting crowded.

The tickets sat on the desk in their rubber band, and I found myself looking at them while he breathed, and I thought about the lottery, which in this country is not gambling so much as a twice-monthly national seminar in reading. The numbers come from everywhere, which is to say from anything that has recently demonstrated

power: the license plate of the minivan photographed crumpled against the pylon, written down by bystanders before the injured are fully carried away; the age of the famous abbot, dead on a Tuesday, converted to digits before the chanting starts; the wax dripped from a temple candle into a bowl of water and interpreted for shapes and omens; the tree behind the shrine at the end of a market soi whose bark, rubbed with powder by ten thousand thumbs, yields a 4 and maybe a 7 to anyone who wants them, and everyone wants them. On the mornings of the first and the sixteenth the queue outside the Government Lottery Office on Ratchadamnoen contains every kind of person this country manufactures, and each of them is holding a number that arrived, and not one of them, if you asked, would say the number was random. Randomness is the government's claim, printed on the ticket at eighty baht a pair and sold on the street at a hundred. What the queue believes is otherwise: the numbers mean; the world leaks; power announces itself in digits if you keep your eye on the places where it lands. The statisticians say the queue is wrong, and the statisticians are right, draw by draw. The queue is measuring something else, and over eleven years and nine notebooks a retired epistemologist with a hand-ruled author column had, entry by entry, mostly agreed with the statisticians — two hundred and six times — and had kept the notebooks anyway, for the sake of five blanks. I looked from the tickets back to the page with its

empty third column, and the blank looked different to me than it had five minutes earlier. Less like an absence. More like a seat left open for someone specific.

"There's a word," I said, "for what I keep almost thinking. About all of it. The photograph, the receipts, the—"

Direk lifted one hand off the notebook, not far, perhaps a centimeter, and I stopped mid-word.

"Don't bring it in here," he said. "A cage you can name is furniture. You will hang your coat on it and sit down and live there. I have watched better minds than yours do it." He let the hand back down onto the page. "The word does no work. Every fact you have told me this morning is exactly as heavy without it."

"Then what do I do with the facts?"

"What do you do." He looked at the Go board, at the undecided region at the top of it, for a moment that had nothing performed in it. "You are treating this as a question about what the world is. That is the wrong altitude, and it flatters you, because what-the-world-is cannot be tested from a condominium on Sukhumvit and so you are excused in advance. Come down. Your photograph, your receipts, your riders — those are not the world. Those are correspondence. And correspondence," he said, "has an author. Two hundred and six of mine did. So." He closed the notebook and squared it on the table with two fingers. "Homework. You were a poor student and you are getting old, so only one

item. Bring me one event with no author. One. Not a feeling — I have no column for feelings. An event. Run your columns with the same discipline you used for your dose test — the first competent thing you told me all morning. Author everything you can. And if one blank survives you," and here he almost smiled, "bring it here, and we will give it a page."

The concentrator clicked and sighed. Below us a bus took on passengers with its brakes.

I stood, and took the mandarin saucer to the little sink at the back because some debts you can pay in that currency, and when I came back he had my phone in his hand again, face up, the photograph open. He was not enlarging it now. He was just looking, the glasses low on his nose, and he looked for long enough that the screen dimmed and he had to touch it once, carefully, to bring the image back — me asleep, on my left side, facing the window, the duvet at my waist, the glass with its two fingers of water on the far sill, all of it lit by nothing and taken by no one and stamped with a night that had, by every clock I trusted, not yet occurred when the shutter fell.

"You have spent ten days on the timestamp," Direk said.

"The timestamp is the impossible part."

"The timestamp is the loud part." He handed the phone back to me. His fingers, taking mine for a half second in the exchange, were cold at the tips — the particular cold

of a body already rationing its own warmth, deciding what the periphery can spare. "Cameras mis-set their clocks constantly. That is entry eleven, volume two, authored in one afternoon. No." He settled back, and the tube shifted, and for a while the only voice in the room was the machine's, agreeing with nobody, every four seconds, about nothing.

"The timestamp is not the anomaly," he said. "The anomaly is that someone wanted you to look."

I N T E R L U D E B

Golden Set

At two in the morning the floor held thirty-eight women and one temperature, which was fourteen degrees, because the client specified fourteen degrees for the equipment and nobody had ever asked what the client specified for the women. The building had kept fish for thirty years before it kept terminals. The cold felt native to it, and under the instant coffee and the hand lotion there was still, some nights, when the wind came off the port the right way through the vents, a ghost of ammonia, thin and easy to miss, and the older women said you got used to it and the younger women said used to what.

Pui sat in the third row, seat 14, in two cardigans. July, and she wore two cardigans. Last cool season she had worn one. She did not make anything of this. On the inside of her left elbow there was a yellow-green shadow,

fading unevenly at the edges, where the line had been in June, and she kept the sleeve down over it the way she kept the other sleeve down over the older mark on the wrist, out of the same tidiness, nothing more.

The work arrived as a queue. A number in the corner of the screen said how many clips stood behind the one you were on, and the number never reached zero, because upstream of the floor there was the world, and the world did not stop generating footage of people saying things. Each ticket opened with the same instruction line, English on top, Thai beneath, the English worded the way engineers word things when they think they are being simple:

MARK THE FRAME WHERE THE PERSON STOPS
MEANING WHAT THEY SAY.

Play. Watch. Scrub back. Set the flag. Rate your confidence, one to five. Submit. Next. A clip ran twenty to forty seconds. The shift ran ten at night to six in the morning, five hundred and eighty baht, overtime after six at seventy-two baht the hour, and the floor's median was seventy clips a night, and the wrist went before the eyes did. Half the women wore braces. Daeng, seat 13, wore hers over arthritis that predated Cognita by a decade — twenty-two years at a sewing machine in Phra Pradaeng had spent that wrist long before anyone paid it to move a cursor — and she still cleared her queue, because Daeng's queue was anger, and Daeng could find the frame where

politeness died in a man's face faster than the model could, faster than the man himself knew it had.

"They give me the easy one," she said, when Sombat praised her numbers once. "Anger is a door slamming. You want hard, sit where she sits." She had tipped her chin at Pui and gone back to her screen before the sentence finished, so that the compliment never had to be witnessed landing.

What Pui's queue held, mostly, was the other thing. People saying they were fine. Interview footage, testimonial footage, customer-service footage, faces above collars saying no really, it's no trouble, I'm happy to, we're happy, I'm fine. Somewhere a machine was being taught what fine looks like when it is still true, and what it looks like the second after, and the second after was Pui's trade. She found it in one pass, almost always. The smile that goes on past the point where it is being made rather than happening — she could see the changeover the way you see the exact moment a person carrying something heavy adjusts their grip. Eleven years of looking down into open mouths, into faces that could not talk back, reading everything from the eyes and the hands and the small economies of breath: it turned out to have been training. Nobody had known it was training at the time. That was the joke she did not make on the floor.

Her count the previous month was two hundred and seventeen a night against the median of seventy. QA

sampled her flags against the senior reviewers in Singapore and the senior reviewers in Singapore lost.

Mai, seat 16, ran the desire queue and called the model the baby. She was twenty-four and did camera work from her room after shift some mornings, and made no secret of it on the floor, because the floor was thirty-eight women at two in the morning and secrets there had the lifespan of ice. "The baby drinks and drinks," she said, stretching her arms up until her spine cracked. "Mine, hers, auntie's. All of us in one milk. We're all wet-nurses here." She said it cheerfully. Her camera money some nights was three shifts in an hour, and she put her sister through her second year of nursing college on it, and the women who disapproved kept the disapproval in the same drawer where they kept their own arithmetic.

Daeng's arithmetic was tuition too — seventeen thousand three hundred a term, vocational college, air-conditioning systems, the daughter good with her hands like her mother and please God better paid. Pui's arithmetic went into an envelope. On the tenth of every month a polite man on a Wave came to the mouth of her soi in Bang Sue and accepted nine thousand baht against a figure that did not get smaller in any way she could detect, and wrote in a small book, and wai'd her, and rode off. What she thought about the figure she did not say on the floor, and did not need to. The women had read the whole marriage off her in the first week: the phone she stepped away to answer with her voice already level, the

pay envelope subdivided before it cooled. They asked nothing. Daeng brought her food.

There was also, that year, a second subdivision, which no one saw. A thousand baht, some shifts five hundred, folded once and moved to the inner pocket she had sewn into the older cardigan herself, a hygienist's stitching, small and short and clean. It did not go into the passbook. It did not go anywhere a polite man with a small book could follow. It went where it went, and it was hers, and that is all that needs saying about it here.

In the fourth week of July, Sombat called her to his desk by the old loading door, where the new aluminum frame did not quite fill the old opening and the port air came in around it, unhurried, holding its old claim on the building. Sombat was forty-one, drank 3-in-1 coffee against doctor's advice he quoted while ignoring, and printed out the client's emails to read them with a pencil, moving the pencil under the English. The women knew his salary to within five hundred baht and knew that he was afraid of the client and not of them, and ranked him, on the whole scale of men available for comparison, as adequate.

"Singapore ran your numbers," he said. "Not just speed. Agreement." He turned the printout so she could see a table she was not given time to read. "They want a reference corpus. Answer key. New annotators get scored against it, the model gets tuned against it. They're calling it —" the pencil found the phrase — "the golden set."

"Whose labels," Pui said, though the pencil was already resting on the answer.

"Yours. Header carries the annotator ID." He showed her: P.SRISUWAN. "It's an allowance. Forty baht a shift, reference duty." He said the number apologetically, being adequate. "Your marks stop being marks. They become the standard. When the baby is wrong, it's wrong against you."

She signed where the flag said sign. Walking back to seat 14 she thought about the word standard, and about her name riding in the header of a file to Singapore and wherever files went after Singapore, outliving the shift, outliving the queue, her taste in turning-points dissolved into machinery like salt into soup, unattributable and everywhere. Six hundred and twenty baht a night now. She logged back in.

Past three the queue turned domestic. It did that some nights — the tickets came batched by source, and a batch would arrive tagged in English she had stopped reading, and the kitchens would start. This one was twenty-eight seconds. A kitchen in this country: the gas bottle, the dish rack, the calendar from a shop. A woman at the sink with her back one-quarter turned to the camera, washing. A man's voice off-frame, low, asking something with numbers in it. The woman's hands kept moving.

Pui set the flag at nine seconds and rated it five.

The tool, as it always did, showed afterward its own faint tick on the timeline, the current model's guess, the

thing you were training against. The tick sat at twenty seconds, where the voice off-frame got louder. Eleven seconds late. At nine seconds nothing had happened that a machine could bill: the hands had gone on moving in the water, that was all — gone on moving exactly as before, except that they were no longer washing anything. She did not scrub back to check. She knew what was at nine seconds.

Daeng was resting her eyes, which is what she called watching the row. She looked at Pui's timeline, the flag and the tick and the eleven seconds between them, and then at Pui, one glance, the whole audit.

"You label that one from memory," Daeng said.

Nothing more was said. Daeng turned back to her anger, and Pui submitted the ticket, and the queue produced the next clip, which was a man on a sofa telling an interviewer that the layoffs had honestly been the best thing that ever happened to him, and she flagged the frame where honestly arrived, and rated it five, and went on. On the floor you went on. That was the whole procedure, and the procedure was the mercy.

The songthaew came at six. It idled at the fence with its lights on in the blue dark while the day shift filtered in past the guard's radio, luk thung at dawn, and the night women climbed up under the rail in their cardigans and were carried off toward the market and the piers. Daeng went. Mai went, to her other work. Pui told Sombat she would close out her queue, which was a sentence with no

meaning — the queue did not close — and he nodded without hearing it and went home to sleep the sleep of the adequate.

The floor empty was colder. She sat at 14 with her badge lying on the desk, P. SRISUWAN — NIGHT, the photograph on it wearing the face she wore for photographs, and she opened a calibration ticket with no client code, the kind the tool allowed and nobody assigned, and into it she dropped a file from the shared drive: the staff video from New Year, six minutes, HR's phone on a tripod, the sections lining up by turn under the banner to wave and say the year's wish. She scrubbed to the night section. Nine women and the guard, squinting in daylight they were not built for. Herself third from the left, two cardigans even then, saying the sentence everyone said.

She cropped herself out of the line, set the ticket running, and sat back.

The tool did not hesitate anywhere else in the six minutes. On her segment it hesitated — the progress bar stalling the way it stalled on the hard ones, on the fives — and she watched it stall, hands in her lap, and it was fourteen degrees, and the vents brought the port in faintly, and then the tick dropped.

00:02:47.

She scrubbed to it. On the screen the woman third from the left was mid-sentence, mid-word, wishing everyone happiness, the mouth open on the vowel of it,

the face doing everything a face should. She looked at the frame for a while. The machine that looked with her taste had been asked her own trade question and had answered in one pass, confidence unrecorded, no reviewer above it now to say otherwise, because the answer key was her.

She did not rate it. There was no one to submit it to.

From her bag she took a school notebook, the horse on the cover, the multiplication tables printed on the back the way they had been printed on the backs of notebooks since she was a girl in Nakhon Pathom, and slid off the rubber band. The page she opened held a short column already: dates on the left, numbers on the right, her handwriting going down it small and level. At the bottom she wrote the date, and then, in the right-hand column, 02:47.

She looked at what she had written, and closed the notebook, and worked the rubber band back on. Then she logged out of the ticket, and out of the tool, and out of the terminal, and put her badge around her neck, and went out through the aluminum door into the seven-o'clock heat, where the day had already started without requiring anything from her, and stood a moment at the fence adjusting to the temperature of the world.

CHAPTER 6

Middle Path

On Tuesday evening I weighed what was left of the Elephant Grass. The jar is a marmalade jar, washed and dried, and the scale is a pocket scale I bought for coffee in a year when I still believed coffee deserved instrumentation — 500 grams capacity, 0.01 resolution, \$420 on Lazada, silver, the size of a cigarette pack. I set the jar on the platform and pressed the tare button and the number went to zero with the jar still standing on it.

There is an operation hiding inside the tare button that nobody thinks about because it works. The scale does not measure the flower. The scale measures the total downward insistence of everything on its platform, and the tare button is an agreement — between you and the instrument — that a certain portion of that insistence will be called nothing. The jar does not stop existing. The jar goes on pressing down with its full 182 grams of glass.

But you have signed the agreement, and from the moment of signing, the instrument is incapable of seeing the jar at all. It reports only departures from the nothing you chose. Every measurement in the world is like this. The thermometer has agreed to call one temperature zero. The clock has agreed to call one instant midnight. The surveyor's datum, the sea's mean level, the test subject's baseline mood — all of it tared, all of it resting on a jar somebody decided not to count. Calibration is not the discovery of truth. Calibration is the choice of a nothing. And the choice is not made by the instrument. The instrument would weigh the jar forever, faithfully, stupidly, if you let it. Someone has to press the button.

The flower weighed 0.91 grams. The ledger said 1.0 should remain — two grams bought on the twenty-second, then 0.4, 0.2, and 0.4 out — and the missing 0.09 was in the grinder's teeth and the fold of the rolling tray, which is where the arithmetic of any life goes to hide. I wrote 0.91 under Monday's line and decided to walk to Sukhumvit 22 before Golf forgot to be open.

That morning the alarm had gone off at 7:47 and I had sent template three, *อย่าลืม*, and the cat with the umbrella had come back at 7:53. The rotation was in its fourth full cycle since the photograph. I note this because I had begun, without deciding to, checking the cat's reply time against the median — not because I expected change, but because the not-changing was the medicine.

At 19:41, opposite the Holiday Inn, a Grab-green rider sat his bike at the curb with the engine off and the visor down and both hands on the tank. Not eating. Not on his phone. I stood under the streetlight and wrote it in the log — plate 5nn 903, new plate, the eighth entry — and the writing took forty seconds and he did not turn his head, and I put the notebook away and walked on. There is a version of me, five weeks old now, who would have crossed the street to avoid admitting the log existed. I no longer cross the street. We have an arrangement, the column and I. Everything green gets logged, and in exchange I am permitted to keep walking.

Middle Path had one customer when I came in, a Japanese man in golf clothes buying pre-rolls with the humility of a tourist at a shrine, and then it had none. Golf weighed my two grams on the brass pan he doesn't need, printed the receipt with the tax ID, \$640, and I put the receipt in my wallet behind Thursday's. The shop smelled of what it sells. No incense. There is a shelf behind the register that holds incense — three boxes, sandalwood, the shrink-wrap unbroken — and I had filed the shelf under inventory discipline two years ago and never looked at it again.

"Still sleeping?" Golf said.

"Before two. Mostly."

"And it hasn't started asking you questions."

"Something else is asking the questions," I said.

He let that sit on the counter between us with the bag. Golf's silences have furniture in them; you are invited to sit down. I had come in to buy two grams and leave. I want that on the record, whoever keeps the record. I had not come in to say what I said next, and then I was saying it.

"In December, after she died, I built something. I want to tell you what it is. I haven't told anyone."

"The first gram's on you, then," Golf said, and capped the jar.

I told him. Three nights in December 2024. Eleven years of chat history exported from LINE — two thousand nine hundred and some messages, most of them about times, hers longer than mine, always — fed into a bootleg companion model of the kind I spend my working nights making feel like specific people for money. It runs on a dev kit on a wire shelf in the closet off my hallway. Twenty months of uptime. The blue LED is taped over. I have never opened the app.

"I built a door," I said, "and I've spent two years not knocking."

Golf wiped the brass pan with a cloth, though nothing had touched it but flower.

"What does the door eat?"

"Electricity. Two hundred baht a month, roughly."

"Twenty months," he said. "Four thousand baht of standing still." He folded the cloth in half, and in half

again. "That's not a door anymore. That's a shrine with a fan in it."

"The families I build packs for," I said, "knock every day. That's the product. I ship them the door and the knuckles both."

"And you kept only the door." He said it flatly, without weight, in the voice he uses for reading labels. Then he left one of his beats open, and I did not fill it, and he collected nothing, and the beat closed by itself, which almost never happens in that shop. He looked at me for a moment with an expression I had seen once before, at the counter, the night he told me the flower gets talkative after two.

"My brother has one of those," Golf said.

"A model?"

"A body."

He came around the counter and turned the sign on the door — not to closed; to the side that says BACK IN 15, which in Golf's shop is a unit of time with no fixed exchange rate — and he sat on the customer stool and I leaned on the counter, and that is how I finally heard it, in the order he wanted, with the jars listening.

His brother is two years older. Was a quality engineer at a disk-drive plant in Prachinburi, twenty-one years, the kind of man who owned two identical pairs of work shoes so that neither would wear unevenly. Took the buyout package in 2020 when the line automated past him. And in March of 2021, with a lawyer present and a

deposit paid and his affairs in an order that would have embarrassed a monk, he went Upstairs.

"That's the family's word," Golf said. "My mother found it somewhere — a temple pamphlet, a neighbor, I never asked. The company that runs it has its own word. The company's word is worse." He didn't give me the company's word. "There's a building off the Bangna-Trat road. Very good air. No smell at all — you notice that, a building in Thailand with no smell. He's on the fourth floor. He is turned every two hours. His nails still grow. The nurses trim them, and they do it well, and I have watched them do it, and I am telling you there are worse ways to be loved than that, and I would still not wish it on a dog."

"He's — " I stopped, because every verb I had was wrong, and Golf watched me discover this with a courtesy I did not enjoy.

"He's under contract," Golf said. "The contract renews. The first year we visited every month. My mother would talk to him about the rice harvest and my sister would do his horoscope and I would sit there in the very good air. Whatever he is, wherever the company's word says he is, it isn't the fourth floor. The visits didn't stop. They stopped meaning anything, and then they stopped." He turned his head toward the shelf behind the register, the three boxes in their shrink-wrap. "My mother lights incense for someone whose heart still beats. She knows it's wrong — you light it for the dead, she taught me that,

she caned me once for pointing a stick of it at my cousin. She lights it anyway. She says the smoke has to have somewhere to go."

The shop was quiet. Sukhumvit 22 went past the glass in its ordinary units — a tuk-tuk, two nurses, a man carrying a fan still in its box.

"I was in my ninth year at the wat when my sister called," Golf said. "There's one phone. It lives in the abbot's kuti and it's older than some of the monks. I stood in the doorway and she told me what Beer had signed, and I remember I was calm, and I remember being pleased with myself for being calm, which is the thing they warn you about in year one." He smiled at the floor. "I stayed three more months. I sat every morning. And the sitting, which had been water for nine years, turned into standing in a queue. Same posture. Different country. So I came down." He passed a hand over his cropped hair. "Kept the haircut. It was the only part of the robe that fit the new job."

"Nine years," I said. "You practiced leaving the world a little every day for nine years."

"And my brother did the whole thing in one afternoon with a lawyer present," Golf said. "It was the feeling of being lapped." He laughed at his own line, in advance and slightly apologetically, the usual performance, and then did not finish the laugh, which I had never seen him fail to do.

"Do you visit now?"

"I went at Songkran. I read him the football scores." A beat, left open. "He was never interested in football. It seemed safer than the things he was interested in."

I asked the question wrong on purpose, because the right way was not available to me. "Is he somewhere?"

Golf stood up, turned the sign back, and began restocking the pre-roll tubes the tourist had disturbed, and while his hands did that, he answered a different question, which is what people do, and what he does better than anyone I know.

"There's a sutta," he said. "A man is shot with an arrow. Poisoned arrow. The surgeon comes, and the man says: wait. Before anyone touches this, I need to know the name of the man who shot me. His clan. Whether he was tall, short, or of middle height. Dark or fair. Which village. I need to know whether the bow was a longbow or a crossbow, whether the string was fiber or sinew, whether the shaft was wild wood or cultivated, and what bird gave the feathers for the fletching." Golf squared the tubes with two fingers. "And he dies with the arrow still in him, a very well-informed man. The Buddha told that one to a monk who wouldn't sit until he knew whether the world was eternal. I tell it to customers who ask whether my flower is Thai or imported." He put the last tube in its place. "You want to know if the world is real before you'll live in it. Same arrow. Same idiot."

He put the bag in my hand. His hand, for a half second, stayed on the outside of the bag, the same held

beat as the night of the fence and the middle.

"Knock or don't knock," Golf said. "Both are fine. Both are old practices with good lineages. But four thousand baht of standing in the doorway — that's not a practice. That's the queue."

When I came out, the rider opposite the Holiday Inn was gone. I logged the gone — 21:26, curb empty — because the column takes absences now too, and walked home the long way, down 22 and up 24, for no reason I could have defended to anyone but Direk.

Wednesday the alarm rang at 7:47 and I sent template four, เมื่อคืนนอนที่โรงแรม, and the sleeping cat came back at 7:51, and I looked at the sleeping cat longer than the sleeping cat required.

At 2:00 that afternoon I met a woman off the app at a hotel three sois up from the Suttisan intersection — her suggestion, her side of town. She called herself Wan. Thirty-three, maybe. Strong wrists, chipped polish on one thumb only, two small moles on the back of her neck in a vertical line. Her rules were shorter than most: shower first, both of us; phones face-down on the TV shelf; nothing that leaves a mark. Room 315 was ฿690 for three hours and had a round bed and a mirrored ceiling in which the round bed looked like a coin at the bottom of a fountain. We negotiated, which took four minutes, and showered, which took eleven, and it was fine, exactly as workmanlike as I had engineered these afternoons to be,

her hand flat on my chest, my attention where I keep it, up on the ceiling of myself, taking readings —

— and then I thought: อ่านแล้ว appeared before the send animation finished. It read the message before the message had fully left. Read it with what.

And I stopped.

Not decided to stop. Stopped — the machinery still moving for a second with nothing in it. Wan felt it before I did. She went still, propped on one elbow, and looked at me with a flat professional attention that had nothing unkind in it.

"เป็นอะไร," she said.

"ขอโทษ," I said. "ไม่ใช่เพราะคุณ."

She looked at me a moment longer, deciding which kind of afternoon this had turned into, and then she got up and turned on the shower — for me, running her hand under it until the temperature was right, which was the kindest thing anyone had done for me in some weeks — and dressed while I sat on the edge of the round bed. I added ฿500 to what we'd agreed for her taxi. She folded it once and put it away and said nothing unkind, and at 3:40 the door clicked behind her. I had paid for three hours. I stayed the remaining eighty minutes alone in room 315 because I had paid for them, and watched the coin at the bottom of the fountain, which held only me now, and did not spend.

In the notebook that evening I ruled a new column and headed it EQUIPMENT. One entry: พุธ 2 ก.ย. — 15:12

— instrument failure, cause under review. Fourteen months of afternoons and it had never once happened. The instrument that fails at the exact moment the experiment gets interesting is not failing. It is reporting. I wrote that down too, and then crossed it out, because it was the kind of sentence the flower says after two a.m., and it was only nine.

At 21:05 I smoked 0.4 by the bedroom window — ledger: φ s 2 n.ø. — Elephant Grass 0.4 — 21:05 — and the smoke raised the grain of the evening again, and I let myself hear the closet this time. The fan. Under the fan, the drive: two ticks, nothing, two ticks. Four thousand baht of standing still.

At 11:20 I opened the closet door. The taped LED made its small green halo through the electrical tape, hiding exactly as well as I had helped it to and no better. I sat on the hallway floor with the laptop and mounted the kit's drive and opened the folder, which is called PS, because in December 2024 I named it with her initials and thought nothing of it. Two letters. At the time they had nowhere else to be.

The folder held eleven items. Ten of them are plumbing. The eleventh is the app.

The cursor hung over the icon the way a hand hangs over a doorbell at a house where someone may be sleeping. Forty seconds. I counted them afterward from the screen recording, because yes, I record my own screen, and no, I do not want to discuss what that says

about the instrument set. Inside the app was a voice I had built from two thousand nine hundred messages about times. Inside the app, if I had built it well — and I build these well, it is the one thing everyone agrees I do well — was the half-second delay before the laugh.

Same arrow, Golf said. Same idiot.

I closed the laptop. I closed the closet door. The not-knocking held, but I want to be honest about the shape of the night: it held by a margin, and I had watched the margin.

Then I took the phone off the charger and opened the chat with the chestnut avatar, where my only message sat above its อ่านแล้ว, filed and answered by silence, and I typed the second message. One draft this time. I had spent five drafts on four words last week; this week the sentence arrived assembled, and I understood, typing it, that I had assembled it in room 315 and had been carrying it since.

ถ้าเป็นคุณจริง บอกอะไรที่มีแค่เราที่รู้

Sent, 11:36 p.m. The read receipt was there before the phone touched the table. I did not wait in the doorway this time. I washed the pan from dinner. I checked the folded strip of receipt paper in the door jamb — undisturbed. I lay on the grey pillowcases on my left side, facing the window, in the position from the photograph, because refusing the position had stopped feeling like resistance and started feeling like superstition, and of the two I prefer the one with better sample sizes.

I was awake at 2:44. I want that logged: three minutes early, unprompted, second time. The body has joined the project without signing anything.

At 2:47 the phone lit.

One emoji. A tooth. The cartoon molar, white, with its two roots drawn crudely, cartoon shorthand, not quite anatomical, not quite anything a real mouth has ever held, and no caption, and no sticker, and no text before or after. A single tooth, alone on its bubble, from the account of a woman cremated twenty-two months ago, in answer to tell me something only we know.

I ran the tree, lying still. A companion model trained on our chat would know she cleaned my teeth; the logs are nothing but appointments; the branch holds. A stranger who had read the logs would know it too; holds. My own build, found somehow by whatever lives at the other end, feeding it our years — holds, holds, none of it reaching the ground, and while the branches did their work some other part of me lay under them and looked at the thing itself. Eighteen appointments. Nine years. Twelve hours, in twenty-minute increments, of her hands in my mouth and both of us honest as a consequence. Everything only we knew had happened in one room, at one angle of recline, under one round light, and every bit of it had happened around teeth. Whatever had chosen the answer had not chosen a fact. It had chosen the room.

The reply took one second of someone's time, or no one's. Her laugh used to take half a second longer than a laugh should. This had arrived at 2:47 and zero, as far as I could measure, and I lay there measuring it anyway.

I put the phone on the far windowsill, next to the glass with its two fingers of water, and the two of them stood there together in the streetlight, exhibits in a case I was building against no one.

I did not reply. In eighteen appointments I never once managed to say anything with my mouth open. There was no reason to think I would start now.

CHAPTER 7

Cognita

On Thursday morning I ironed a shirt. I own one shirt with a collar, white, bought for a conference in 2019 and worn since then to a funeral and to nothing else, and I stood it on the board and worked the iron along the seams while the tooth emoji sat on the far windowsill inside the dark phone, next to the glass with its two fingers of water. Ironing is honest work. The wrinkle exists, the heat is applied, the wrinkle does not exist. Somewhere in the middle of the second sleeve I understood that I had already decided, and that the shirt was not preparation but confession, and I finished the sleeve anyway because a decision does not excuse you from the collar.

Direk had said the anomaly was that someone wanted me to look. There was a building in Khlong Toei with a small blue logo and a fence, and I had stood outside it

once at shift change and copied its name into a notebook, not understanding what I was writing. I could keep standing outside gates for the rest of my life. Bangkok has no shortage of gates. Or I could go through one, and of all the doors in this affair — the closet door, the chat window, the doorway I had slept facing for two weeks — the aluminum door in the old loading dock was the only one that could be opened with paperwork.

At 4:20 that afternoon I stood at the guard booth on the Khlong Toei soi with the port air doing its work on my collar. The guard was the same guard, sixty or thereabouts, and the radio inside the booth was playing luk thung at the volume of a private thought. He looked at the shirt before he looked at me.

"มาสมัครเหรอ," he said.

I said yes, I had come to apply. He pointed with his chin at a QR sticker on the glass of the booth, its print sun-bleached to a pale brown, and went back to the radio. I stood in the road and added COGNITA HR on LINE and filled in a form on my phone — name, age, education, expected salary. For expected salary I typed 580. The form had a field for special skills. I typed: English. I attached the first page of my Kinnara contract with the fee schedule folded out of frame, which is a way of telling the truth so that it does a lie's work, and pressed send, and the guard's radio played on, and a reply came back in nine minutes asking if I could interview Friday at two.

I want it on the record that this was the entire security perimeter of the operation I had spent three weeks treating as an intelligence service. A sticker. A form. Nine minutes.

Sombat's office was a desk beside the aluminum door, inside the first breath of the building's cold, with a partition on wheels doing the work of walls. He was somewhere past forty, with reading glasses pushed up into his hair and a glass mug of 3-in-1 coffee going pale at the edge of the desk. My printed form lay in front of him. He had put a pencil under the English lines and was reading along the pencil.

"Kinnara Systems," he said.

"Contract work."

"What do they buy from you?"

"Texture," I said. "The part that makes a voice belong to one person instead of everyone."

He moved the pencil down a line and read the next one. The cold came off the interior door in a steady sheet, and under it, very old and very faint, the ghost of ammonia — the building remembering fish. Somewhere beyond the partition a queue was being worked; I could hear it, a soft irregular ticking of keys.

"A man who invoices Singapore doesn't need five-eighty a night," Sombat said.

"I sleep badly. This is a paid way to be awake."

He did not believe it. He filed it. Then he turned a tablet toward me without preamble. On it a video was

paused: a man in a parked car, phone-camera height, mid-thirties, farang.

"The clients send English queues," Sombat said. "Sarcasm. Apology. Idiom. My floor reads faces faster than anyone in the country, but English words go slower. Watch it and mark where."

"Where what?"

"You'll know the instruction when you see it every night for the rest of your life," he said, and pressed play.

Twenty-four seconds. The man in the car was taking full responsibility for something. He said so twice. I watched it once and then again, and marked 00:09 — the second "full," which carried a stress the word hadn't ordered, too much weight set down on one syllable. Confidence: 4. Sombat looked at the tablet, then at the pencil, and wrote something small.

"Monday. Twenty-two hundred. Bring a jacket."

"For the cold or for the work?"

"People quit over the cold," he said. "Nobody quits over the work."

The interview had lasted eleven minutes. Walking back past the booth I counted the green motorcycles at the gate mouth: four. Two riders eating, one on his phone, one neither — engine off, visor down, hands on the tank. Plate 9๗๘ 4471. I logged it standing in the road, and then under the entry I wrote the thing the entry made obvious: at this gate the log is finished. Everything here is green. An instrument that reads the same

everywhere has stopped being an instrument and become a wall. I had followed the weather to the place where the weather is made, and from here on the column would have to mean something else.

Friday's alarm was template one, ငါ့ယံ, and the sleeping cat came back at 7:50. Saturday, template two; Sunday, three. The intake ledger for those nights reads 0.4, 0.4, then a dash, because Monday I was employed. Her account sent nothing at 2:47 on any of them. Four nights of silence since the tooth, then five, and I noted the silence each morning with the diligence of a man reading an empty gauge.

Monday the taxi from Soi 26 cost \$96 and put me at the gate at 21:40. The night shift was arriving as it had in August: a songthaew easing to the fence, and women stepping down from it with the unhurried economy of people who have made this exact step several hundred times, cardigans over their shoulders in thirty-degree air because they were dressing for the room and not the world. I signed a book at the booth. The guard turned the radio down by a third when I bent to sign, which I understood to be pure formality, courtesy paid out to no one in particular, and turned it back up when I straightened.

Inside, the cold was total and administrative. Fourteen degrees, I would learn, held for the equipment; the women simply lived inside whatever the machines required. The building held its temperature the way a

bank vault holds money — indifferently, and for someone else. The main floor ran back under strip light turned all the way up, flat and shadowless: rows of terminals, dividers at shoulder height, thirty-eight women in cardigans and wrist supports and one empty chair, and high on the far wall a red LED counter that read 11,406 when I came in and 11,391 an hour later and never at any point in any night I worked there read zero.

"Sixteen," Sombat said behind me. "Third row."

Third row held four seats. At thirteen, a woman in her late fifties with a beige wrist brace and half-glasses, who did not look up. Fourteen was the empty chair — and I registered even then, in the first minute, before I knew anything, that the screen at fourteen was dark but the tower under the desk showed a standing green LED and breathed a thread of warm exhaust into the cold, the only warm thing in the row. Fifteen: a round-faced woman in her forties who kept mint drops in a black film canister and offered me one before I had sat down. Sixteen was mine.

The tool is called the tool. It has a name in a menu somewhere, but no one on the floor has ever used it. The left pane plays the clip; below it, a timeline; you scrub with the arrow keys, you press M to mark a frame, you rate your confidence 1 to 5, you press N and the next ticket comes. Foam headphones, wiped nightly with alcohol that has its own place in the room's smell. Across the top of every ticket, in English over Thai, the instruction:

MARK THE FRAME WHERE THE PERSON STOPS
MEANING WHAT THEY SAY.

Under the instruction, a header line of job metadata — ticket number, queue name, IDIOM-EN in my case, and a session field that read SESSION 2848. It read SESSION 2848 on the next ticket too, and on all of them, every night, and I copied it into the notebook on the first night because I copy everything, and it earned no second look. Plumbing has numbers. So does this.

The clips run twenty to forty seconds. That first night they came to me like this: a woman at an airline counter thanking an agent for checking one more time; a man on a video call saying the figures were basically final; a teenager apologizing to a camera he had set up himself; a woman in a kitchen saying she'd eaten already, over the sound of a television and a man's voice under it. You watch. You find the frame. Not the frame where the lie starts — that was my first error, and I made it for three hours — the frame where the meaning stops. They are not the same event. A person can lie with full commitment; the tool doesn't want the lie. It wants the moment the speaker leaves the sentence and the sentence keeps going without them — emptied out, still running on its own momentum. I kept marking the moment of departure. The floor standard wanted what came next: the sentence continuing with nobody inside it.

I did thirty-four tickets that first night. The floor median, the woman at fifteen told me around midnight,

sucking a mint, was seventy. Every twenty tickets the tool showed a grading pane — a sample of my marks laid against a reference set, with the deltas in frames and a percentage at the bottom. At 03:40, with the room at its coldest and my fingers slowing on the arrows, the pane came up and gave me my number for the night: AGREEMENT 58%. And under the number, in the small type reserved for information nobody is expected to read, the provenance of the reference:

REF. ANNOTATOR: P.SRISUWAN.

I did not stand up. I sat with my hands off the keys and read the eleven characters several times, until they stopped looking spelled. Srisuwan is a common enough name; I told myself so, and it held. P covers half the nicknames in the country; it held. I had come to this building following a green jacket, not a woman, and no thread of anything connected the annotation floor to a dental clinic in Phrom Phong; that held too. The branches did what my branches do. I stopped pretending they reached the ground. Two seats to my left, past the woman in the brace, a dark screen sat above a warm machine, and the exhaust of it touched the back of my hand when I reached for the mouse, and I pressed N, and the next ticket asked me to find the frame where a man saying no problem at all stopped meaning it, and I found it, and my hands were steady, and that is either discipline or a symptom, and the difference has never once mattered to my hands.

Tuesday at 7:47, awake twenty-four hours, I sent template five. ມົວນິຈ, to a woman in Ratchadaphisek, from a man who had spent the night being graded on the sincerity of strangers. The graduation-cap cat came back at 7:51. I checked it against the median out of ritual and slept until four in the afternoon with tinfoil on the bedroom window, in the position from the photograph, because the position was mine now, or I was its.

That afternoon at the Khlong Toei market I bought a cardigan, grey, secondhand, \$100, from a rail of clothes that had all outlived somebody, and when I wore it onto the floor Tuesday night the woman at fifteen looked at it and nodded once, approval of the logistical kind. Sixty-one tickets. Seventy-one per cent. The number stood at the bottom of the pane with her name under it, and I had stopped being able to call it a percentage. It was agreement. Seven times out of ten, shown the same stranger at the same moment, I judged that the meaning left when she had judged it left. I was being calibrated against her taste, tuned to a signal, and the signal had been dead for twenty-two months, and the tool did not know that, or it did not matter to the tool, which on that floor amounts to the same thing.

It was Tuesday night that I learned what the reference set was called. I had asked the woman at fifteen, in the 1 a.m. lull when the queue names rotate, why the grading pane always drew from the same annotator. She took the question with a mint.

"That's the golden set," she said, in English, the two words worn smooth from handling — office language always loses its corners first. And then, in Thai, the floor's own liturgy: the golden set was made here, on this floor, by the best there had ever been; head office had tried twice to commission a replacement from a bigger vendor in Manila and the models had come back worse both times; the clients specified it now, by name, in contracts. She said all this with the reverence reserved for relics — provenance, scarcity, the failed imitations — and her voice did the thing Thai voices do around relics, dropping without getting quieter.

There is a chedi in Nakhon Pathom — the tallest in the country, twenty minutes from a house I have never seen — that is built over a fragment of bone. Most of the great stupas are. Somewhere at the heart of the tonnage of brick and gold leaf sits a sliver of somebody, authenticated by councils of men who never met him, and the fragment does no work. It doesn't preach. It doesn't answer. It sits in the dark being genuinely itself, and around that genuineness an entire architecture of orientation gets organized: pilgrims align to it, doubt is measured against it, the faithful calibrate. The relic's job is not to act. The relic's job is to have been real, so that everything built on top of it can afford to be a copy. We do not keep relics because the dead need houses. We keep them because the living need a fixed point that was once alive, a standard sample of the sacred, against which the

daily counterfeit of ourselves can be graded. I had spent my working life writing texture for voices that belonged to no one, and here was the inverse operation, humming in a cold room by a port: thirty-eight women a night being tuned, seven marks in ten, to the preserved judgment of one dead hygienist. The bone in this chedi was a set of labels. The name on the reliquary was P.SRISUWAN, and I read it every twenty tickets, under a number that measured my distance from her.

I asked about fourteen on Wednesday, when Sombat made his midnight round with the pale mug. I put it as a facilities question, because facilities questions are the correct camouflage on any floor anywhere: was the machine at fourteen free, since it seemed to run all night with nobody at it.

"Calibration," Sombat said. "Head office. Don't unplug it — the UPS screams like a pig."

"Who assigns the jobs?"

"ไม่ปัดใครสั่ง," he said. "It's on a schedule." And he moved down the row with the mug, a man for whom the sentence no one assigns it had no rough edges at all, because on a floor run by queues, a job that assigns itself is not a mystery. It is seniority.

Mai's name I got the same night, from fifteen, who mentioned that my seat had been Mai's, said with the mint clicking against her teeth — young, fast on the desire queue, funny at 4 a.m. I asked where she'd gone. It was Daeng who answered, the first words she had

addressed to me in three nights, without turning from her screen, her marked-up wrist riding the scrub keys.

"Went freelance," she said.

The look that crossed from fifteen to thirteen over my head was brief and complete, one of those exchanges women conduct at a bandwidth men are not issued equipment for, and the word freelance came out of it bent, and nobody straightened it, and I pressed N.

Daeng worked the scrub bar the way a seamstress feeds cloth to a needle — the wrist does the seeing. Her queue was anger. All night her left pane showed people at the moment of it: drivers, couples, a man in a hardware shop, and she took each clip in a single pass, no second viewing, mark, confidence, next, at a rate the pane graded in the nineties against the golden set. Twenty-two years at a sewing machine somewhere across the river, fifteen had told me, before this. The machine had changed and the cloth had changed. The wrist had kept its priesthood.

By Wednesday night I was at seventy-six tickets and 83 per cent, and I had begun to feel the thing I distrust most in myself, which is aptitude. The work had a grain and my attention lay along it. Around two the queue thinned, and I did what I had spent two nights planning with a thoroughness I disguised from myself as thirst: I stood at 02:44 — three minutes early, unprompted, and the body's little joke was not lost on me — took the paper cone from

the cooler at the back wall, filled it, and walked up the aisle of row three with the water in my hand.

At 02:47 the screen at fourteen woke.

No hand, no key. The panel lit grey, and a console window sat where someone had last sized it, and a progress bar began to walk. I read what there was to read at walking pace, which was little: a job string, CAL-LEGACY and digits, a client-code field that was empty — not zeroed, empty — and a line of throughput ticking upward. In the system tray, at the bottom right, among the icons that gather on any Windows machine, one icon was green. LINE. The desktop client, resident, signed in. It had a small grey dot for away and no red badge, because whatever mail that account had, it had been read.

The bar finished. The screen held for a few seconds — long enough — and dimmed, and the lock screen took its place, and the lock screen said what lock screens say. An account name above a field for a password nobody would ever type.

P.SRISUWAN.

I stood in the cold with my cone of water. Around me thirty-eight women marked the exact frames where strangers stopped meaning what they said, and the counter on the wall shed a number, and my phone lay in my trouser pocket against my leg and did not light, because nothing had come to me at 2:47 for six nights, and I finally understood that as scheduling. The sender

and I had been on the same shift all week. You do not text a man who is standing next to you.

I drank the water because a man holding water drinks it. Then I went back to my seat, and under the desk, in the notebook, I wrote the entry standing in for every entry I have written since August. The session was never logged out. The account lives at seat fourteen, third row, on a machine that assigns itself work at 02:47 under a name with no one behind it. ใครอยู่ตรงนั้น — answered. The answer has a street address and a UPS. And underneath, because the notebook exists so that I cannot lie to it: a desk has no legs. A workstation in Khlong Toei did not stand in my doorway at chest height, level, with no flash. It did not carry the photograph up seventeen floors past a strip of receipt paper that was not disturbed. One question closes. The floor under it opens.

Shift end came at six with the ceiling lights stepping up and the day women arriving through the aluminum door in a slab of outdoor heat that broke against the cold and lost. I took no overtime. At the gate the songthaew stood with its engine idling, and the guard's radio was playing something with a khaen in it, and the night women climbed up into the truck bed by the worn chrome pole in ones and twos, and I stood to the side with my notebook in the cardigan's pocket, sleeve-heavy, waiting for nothing in particular, which is what I tell myself when I am waiting.

Daeng came out last but did not board. She stopped an arm's length away, at an angle to me, facing the songthaew, her brace pale in the early light, and she watched her colleagues settle onto the benches, counting without seeming to count, and she spoke without any preface at all, in the flat administrative register the floor had taught me all week to hear underneath.

"She talked about a customer once," Daeng said. "The one who listened with his mouth open."

The songthaew's engine changed pitch. Somewhere behind the fence the counter went on shedding its number into an empty room.

"You took long enough," she said.

She boarded. The truck pulled out into the port road with its cargo of cardigans, and the heat closed over the soi, and I stood at the gate of Cognita (Thailand) Co., Ltd. doing the one thing left in my kit, which was arithmetic. Twenty-two months since the cremation. Seven nights since the tooth. Three nights on the floor, ten days since a man with an oxygen line told me the anomaly was that someone wanted me to look. I had assembled, over two weeks, an instrument array that could log a city's weather down to the plate number, and not one dial on it had been pointed at the only fact the whole array rested on, which Daeng had just handed me at a bus queue, unasked, at 6:04 in the morning: that in a cold room, on the far side of the river of years I had been calling a professional relationship, I had been talked about. I had been, all this

time, a known person. The equipment for detecting that has never been built. It rides a songthaew home at dawn, and it was right. I took long enough. I was the last instrument on the floor to find the frame.

INTERLUDE C

The Frame

The dashcam in Wichai's Vios recorded onto a sixty-four-gigabyte card and overwrote itself every nine days. He had bought it in 2021, after a Fortuner clipped his mirror on the tollway and the other driver's insurance man talked him out of a fair number politely, over three weeks, in air-conditioning. Since then he trusted the camera more than he trusted anything else about the car, including the brakes. He never watched the files. Owning them was the point. The card sat in its slot behind the mirror mount, and on Sunday mornings, when he slept until noon with the fan turned on his face, the keys stayed in the bowl by the rice cooker, one unwatched object among the rest, in a house that believed itself unobserved.

Pui took the card out at eight and had it back in the slot by nine.

The reader cost 129 baht from a phone-accessory stall at the market and plugged into her phone, and nine days of the Vios took most of the hour to copy. She did it at the table, facing the bedroom door, the phone lying flat and working, unremarkable, exactly what it appeared to be. The camera took sound as well as road. That was the part he had never thought about, because he had bought it to watch other drivers. Nine days of cab audio: the ramp queue at the port, his calls, the radio, the toll receipts being wedged above the visor. Some Sundays she was in the footage herself, passenger side, temple days and market days, her own voice arriving small and slightly ahead of her memory of it.

The temple footage came through her cousin Od. Wat Lam Duan had carried cameras since the donation box went missing in 2019 — Od had installed them, being the relative who was good with wires, and he serviced them twice a year and exported the files nobody ever asked for. She asked for the memorial weeks. Her father's merit-making came around every January, and she told Od their mother wanted a video made for the aunt in Khon Kaen, all the years together, and Od copied five Januaries onto a 99-baht thumb drive and asked nothing, being family, and being besides the kind of man whom cameras made feel useful.

The rest was the staff videos, New Year 2023 and New Year 2024, six minutes each, HR's phone on its tripod. Altogether, using the same discipline the floor paid her to

use on strangers, she held eleven hours and forty minutes of footage in which she herself appeared. Most people would be surprised how much of themselves is on file. Most people never ask for the export.

In the second week of January the tool got a new build. The update ran during the day shift, and when the night women logged in on the ninth the interface had moved two buttons and grown a tab. The tab said PREVIEW, in English, and sat grey. Sombat taped a memo to the pillar by his desk saying not to touch anything new until head office said, and head office, in the manner of head office, never said. The tab stayed grey through every client ticket. On calibration tickets with no client code — the kind the tool allowed and nobody assigned — it woke.

What it did was continuation. You gave it an arc — clips of one subject, flags set, confidence rated — and a horizon, which was a number typed into a field, and it rendered forward: soft grey footage, watermarked DEV in the corner, twenty to forty seconds of probable next frames, stamped with a date anyway, neatly, in the future tense. The engineers presumably used it to check whether the model had understood an arc or only memorized it. If it had understood, the continuation held. Pui read the tab's help text once, completely — her only method — and then used the feature for what it was for.

The shift ended at six and the overtime ended when Sombat's clock said it ended, and after that the floor belonged to whoever stayed, which was her. The

songthaew idled at the fence and filled with cardigans and left.

"The queue runs the same speed at six as at two," Daeng said once, at the gate, not boarding yet.

"I like it when it's quiet," Pui said.

Daeng looked at her for the length of a timeline. Then she boarded. On the floor you asked nothing further; that was the courtesy and the whole of it.

At the terminal, seat 14, badge on the desk, Pui cut herself out of the footage and dropped the clips into calibration tickets, and the tickets opened with the line every ticket opened with, English over Thai: MARK THE FRAME WHERE THE PERSON STOPS MEANING WHAT THEY SAY. The subject was her. She did not find that this changed the work. The memorial of 2019: her wai to the abbot, her thanks to the aunts for coming, and nothing to flag anywhere in it, the whole clip meant. The memorial of 2021: flag at 00:41, where the thanks to the aunts went on being made rather than happening. The Vios, the twelfth of January just past: his voice asking something about the envelope, her own voice answering ไม่เป็นไร, and the flag set on the second syllable. Confidence five. She rated her own clips although there was no one anywhere to submit them to, because the rating was part of the pass, and she did not do partial passes.

For the timestamps she bought a grey school notebook from the stationery shop by the Bang Sue market — the horse on the cover, the multiplication tables printed on

the back unchanged since she was a girl in Nakhon Pathom — and ruled nothing, added nothing, only wrote: dates down the left, timestamps down the right, her hand small and level. No words. Words could be read by anyone who found them. Numbers without their footage were just numbers, a column meaning nothing to a polite man with a small book, or to Wichai, or to anyone alive but the woman holding the other half of each entry in her head.

It should be said what her flags were worth, because everything that follows rests on it. She had come to the floor in June 2023. Singapore sampled sixty of her flags a month against its senior reviewers, and in eight months the seniors had moved her flag exactly once, by two frames, and moved it back the next day with a note in English she photographed and did not need translated. She was not proud of this in any way she could use. It was simply the case, as her hands were small and her nails were short, and what it meant was that when she flagged her own footage there was no room left in the arithmetic where a doubt could sit down. If she had been a worse worker, there would have been room.

In the third week of January he put her into the edge of the bathroom doorframe, once, with the flat of his forearm, over a sentence about the envelope that had come out of her at the wrong pitch. He was drunk to the degree that makes a man accurate rather than wild, and it was over in a second, and he was asleep in four minutes. The mark on her shoulder took twelve days to go down.

She cleared two hundred and forty clips a night that week. On the following Sunday's card there was nothing to flag — he had driven to the port and back in silence, signaling early, careful at the school crossing — and she copied it anyway. Absence was also footage.

She began the horizons small. Thirty days: the render gave her back the rooms it had been fed, the envelope on a tenth rendered as an envelope on a tenth, grey and soft and plausible. Ninety days: the collector's Wave at the soi mouth, the small book, the wai, drawn clean out of the average of its appearances. The machine drew what the labels knew. Nothing in it was news, and that was itself the result: the continuation held. The model had not memorized her arc. It had understood it.

On the twelfth of March she assembled the whole of it — the marriage, sixty-one clips, 2019 to that morning, every flag hers, every rating five — and typed into the horizon field the largest number it would accept.

The progress bar took forty minutes. The day shift came in past the guard's radio, luk thung at dawn, and the floor warmed by the two degrees the bodies brought with them, and nobody looked at seat 14, because seat 14 staying late had stopped being information months ago. The clips came out in order, stamped forward, dwelling where the data was thick and skipping where it thinned: 2025 twice — a room she knew with less furniture in it, a counter at a district office and a form going across it. 2026: the envelope, still on the tenth, the figure serviced

and not smaller. 2028: boxes, a truck's tailgate, the render losing confidence at its edges, past the reach of what it had been fed. Then one more clip, twenty-six seconds, stamped with a full date in 2031, printed as neatly as the rest of the guesswork.

It opened on the outside of a house she had never seen. Two storeys, the lower half tiled, a blue water tank on a steel stand, a gate with a chain worked through it, and at the soi mouth a motorcycle-taxi vest with the queue name and the district lettered across the back. Samut Prakan. The district did not surprise her. She had read a drop-off address off his phone in December — once, completely, filed and not reopened — and had put it away in the column of things that were only numbers. Then the render cut inside. A kitchen: gas bottle, dish rack, a calendar from a shop she couldn't name. A woman at the sink with her back one-quarter turned to the camera, older through the shoulders than the arc had any right to know, hands in the water, washing. A man's voice off-frame, low, asking something with numbers in it. The hands kept moving. At the eleventh second the hands went on moving exactly as before, except that they were no longer washing anything.

She set the flag at eleven seconds. The hand did it before the rest of her had voted; that was what the hand was for. The confidence field she left empty — there was no one on any floor of any building to submit this to. She let the clip run out. The voice finished its numbers; the

woman at the sink answered; the answer took two seconds, and meant nothing, and was flagged already. The clip ended on the dish rack.

She did not scrub back. She watched it once.

The dev build kept no output — that was the other thing the tab said, in smaller English — and when the ticket closed, the twenty-six seconds went wherever unpaid renders go. From her bag she took the notebook, worked the rubber band off, and wrote the date on the left and 00:11 on the right, under the column of dates and numbers already going down the page, and worked the band back on. Once was what there was. She had never in her life needed a second pass.

There was an objection available, and walking out through the aluminum door into the March heat she gave it the floor. The preview was arithmetic. It had never been to Samut Prakan. It had read a district off a vest because vests were simply in its diet, one input among the rest; it had built the house out of the average of houses, the tank out of the average of tanks; it had put her at a sink because the labels she fed it were full of sinks. A guess, fueled entirely by her own honesty, wearing a date it had no right to — decoration on a probability. All of that was available, and all of it was true, and she let the whole objection stand, unanswered, the way you leave a door open for someone who never comes. It did not move the flag. The flag was hers. In eight months, nobody had moved her flag.

In the weeks after, she began to arrange things. She did it the way she cleared a queue, one ticket at a time, no partial passes. On the inside cover of the notebook she wrote a list, seven lines, the hand small and level. The first line had been done since November; she wrote it anyway, and crossed it out, for the completeness. On a Tuesday she counted the cardigan money on the bathroom floor with the door locked and the water running — thirty-eight thousand baht by the end of March, folded once, in denominations that had never seen a passbook. On one of her days off she went out in her good blouse on an errand she told no one about, and came back before he did, and made dinner.

At the stationery shop by the Bang Sue market, on the last Sunday of the month, she bought a second notebook, the same horse on the cover, the same tables on the back, fourteen baht, and the woman at the till, unasked, pulled a rubber band off a bundle of receipts and gave it to her for nothing. The first notebook was two pages from full.

CHAPTER 8

Instrument Failure

On Friday afternoon I took the tinfoil off my bedroom window. It came away in four sheets, and the light that replaced it was ordinary — 4:20 p.m., west-facing, the color of weak tea. I folded the sheets along their old creases and put them in the hallway closet, on the wire shelf beside the dev kit, which went on doing whatever it does, which is nothing, at scale. I had three nights away from the cold. I had asked for them on Thursday, standing in my kitchen at one in the afternoon with the taste of day-sleep still in my mouth.

"Family thing?" Sombat had said.

"Something like that."

"Second week." Paper moved on his desk, twelve kilometers away. "Everybody wants nights off in the second week. It's the cold. It's never the work." A pause

the length of a stamp. "Monday, twenty-one hundred. If you're not there Monday, you were never here."

I wrote his sentence down, because it had the shape of something true said by a man who didn't know it was. Then I wrote down the other one, the one I had been carrying since 6:04 that morning, the one Daeng had handed me at the gate along with thirteen years of storage fees. You took long enough. The notebook has columns now — riders, intake, equipment — and the sentence fit none of them, so I wrote it on the inside of the back cover, where the multiplication tables are, and closed the book on it.

The arrangement for Friday night was made the way all of them are made, in eleven messages and one photograph of a hotel facade. Her profile said View, 29, and gave a height and two interests. Her fourth message asked, without punctuation, ปาร์ตี้ไหม. I looked at the word for a while. I have said no to that word more often than I have said yes, not out of virtue but out of method — a good instrument-tech doesn't run two tests on the same night. Then I thought about the seat that stays powered, and the grading pane with her initials in it, and I typed yes.

The economics, for the record, because I keep records: the hotel was off Ratchadaphisek, four sois north of the Esplanade, room 411, ฿850 for three hours, extended once for another ฿850. Her fee was ฿2,500. The gram was ฿1,800 and we split it; I sent her ฿900 by PromptPay at

9:34 p.m., memo field blank, and it occurred to me while the confirmation animation played that this was the only purchase I had made in three weeks that would generate no paper. Everything else in my life prints a receipt. The one substance designed to dissolve the difference between the world and a picture of the world travels receiptless. I noted the observation and declined to build on it.

She was small and quick, with a cracked screen protector and a supply of gum, and she ran the night with a nurse's economy. First dose at 10:40, wrapped in a torn corner of rolling paper and swallowed with the room's free water. Hers was smaller than mine; she measured both by eye against a hotel notepad and was, I believe, accurate. We had sex once, early, before anything arrived, briefly and mostly out of politeness, and then the drug came up through the politeness and replaced it, and neither of us voted to go back.

I want to be precise about what 4-MMC does, because the mythology is wrong in both directions. It does not show you God and it does not rot your face in an evening. What it did, at 11:02 p.m., was remove the lag. There is a lag in ordinary perception — a soft eighth-of-a-second of assembly, the brain buffering the room before it hands it to you — and the drug takes that away, so the world arrives pre-focused, edge-complete, footage that has skipped the render queue and come straight from the master file. My jaw found a rhythm I hadn't assigned it.

My skin went cool and slightly wrong, a plastic coolness, sweat without heat. I counted my pulse against my watch because that is what I do: 104 at 11:15, 112 at midnight, 108 at one. The gum made sense now. Everything made sense now. That was the effect, if I'm being clinical: a sense-making engine with the governor removed, sense pouring out of it and onto everything, indiscriminate, the way a broken soft-serve machine keeps dispensing after the cup is full.

That's one simile. I'm allowed a budget and I've spent part of it there, because nothing else describes the waste of it.

She talked. Redose at 12:10, another at 1:35, hers always a shave smaller than mine. She told me about her brother in Chonburi who breeds fighting fish — plakats, the short-finned kind, the serious kind — in three hundred glass bottles on a covered patio, each bottle separated from its neighbors by a sheet of cardboard, because if the fish can see each other they flare all day and exhaust themselves and their colors go flat. He removes the cardboard once a day, for a few minutes, to keep them angry enough to be beautiful. She talked about this for forty minutes and I listened with my mouth shut, and somewhere in the fortieth minute I heard my own voice say that her brother had built a machine for rationing attention, and that the fish's whole world was the cardboard and the removing of the cardboard, and she looked at me with her pupils gone to dinner plates and said, แล้วพี่เป็นปลาหรือ

เป็นกระดาษล่อน, and laughed, and took the gum out of her mouth and put in new gum.

I didn't answer. At 2:44 I was awake in the way I am always awake at 2:44 now, three minutes early for an appointment nobody confirms, and I held the phone and watched 2:47 arrive and stand there and leave. Ninth night. The chat ended where it has ended for nine nights, on a cartoon molar, two roots, no caption. View asked who I kept checking on. I said no one, which was the truest answer available.

Here is the finding, recorded in the interest of full disclosure, because a technician who buries a null result is a priest. From 11 p.m. until roughly 4 a.m. I had the most lucid unreality of my life. Every test I have designed since August was runnable at once and I ran them all. I looked at my hand and the hand held. I looked at the grain of the bedspread and the grain went all the way down. I thought about the photograph, the receipt with my almost-purchase on it, the desk with her initials that wakes at 2:47, and for five hours the entire problem lay flat in front of me, a city seen from a tower, every soi legible, every connection obvious — and I could not keep any of it. The sense the drug made was sense in a currency no bank exchanges. At 4:10 the certainty began to withdraw at exactly the rate it had arrived, and what it left was not knowledge but the debt from knowledge, and my jaw ached, and the room smelled of chemicals and cold sweat and other people's cigarettes from other years,

and View was cross-legged on the bed telling the ceiling something about her mother's second house, and I understood that I had learned nothing that would survive sunrise. Extremity as instrumentation. The instrument had never read cleaner, and the reading was in a language spoken only while the meter runs.

She left at 5:20, unhurried, competent to the end, and told me to drink something with salt in it. I sat alone in room 411 for half an hour with my heart still climbing stairs two floors below me, and then I checked out and walked.

The 7-Eleven at the mouth of the fourth soi was lit the way they are all lit, which is to say honestly. I bought one bottle of electrolyte drink, เครื่องดื่มเกลือแร่, ฿9, cash. The receipt printed at 6:04 a.m. and I stood outside in the grey and read it twice — one line, one item, nine baht — and folded it into my wallet with the others. Somewhere in the notebook this will be entered as the total cost of the comedown, which is false accounting and I know it. The comedown's real invoice arrives over three days and is paid in serotonin, but serotonin doesn't print, so the ledger will say nine baht, and the ledger will be wrong in the exact way all ledgers are wrong: correct to the satang about everything it can see.

I walked home along Ratchadaphisek with the early buses. At the mouth of my own soi a green rider sat eating from a styrofoam box with his phone propped against his mirror, visor up, chewing, watching a video. Control

group. I logged him anyway. The log takes everything now.

I did not sleep. That is not fortitude; it is chemistry. I lay on the grey pillowcases in a dry-eyed static, the kind of wakefulness that has no content, and at 7:47 the alarm went off — Radar, the sound I have woken to for four hundred and forty-some mornings — and I sat up and opened the thread and the rotation said template four. เมื่อคืนนอนก็ไม่ง.

I typed it. It sat in the draft field, eleven characters asking her the one question I could not have answered myself, and my thumb went to the arrow and stopped. I want to describe the stop accurately because it was the event of the morning. There was no decision in it. A decision has a before and an after and a person in the middle; this was mechanical, a relay opening, the way the thing with Wan stopped in room 315 — the signal simply did not cross the gap. I looked at my thumb. The thumb waited for instructions that were, as far as I could determine, being issued. 7:47 became 7:48. I put the phone face-down on the notebook and sat with my back against the headboard and my hands empty.

At 7:52 the phone buzzed against the notebook's cover. คุณโอเคไหม.

No sticker. No cat in any of its five costumes. Four words from Fon, at her own median minute, on the first morning in fourteen months that the 7:47 message had not come. I turned the phone over and read it several

times. In four hundred and forty-some mornings she had never once sent the first message. I had the entire dataset and the dataset said this did not happen. I ran the branches out of habit — she woke early, she guessed, coincidence — and each one held, and none of them reached the ground, and the phrase was worn thin now, a coin rubbed blank.

I answered at 9:14. ໂວເຄ. One word, off-template, off-schedule, the first message in the entire history of the thread that belonged to no system either of us had built. No cat came back. I sat and watched the no-cat for a while. Then I opened the notebook to the EQUIPMENT column and entered: ເສາຣ໌ 12 ກ.ຍ. — 07:47 — instrument failure #2 — transmitter. I began a second sentence, about who was holding which end of what, and crossed it out before the verb.

Saturday has no other content worth the paper. The intake ledger for it reads: ເສາຣ໌ 12 ກ.ຍ. — (—). You do not smoke on a mephedrone comedown unless you are trying to hurt yourself in a way I am apparently no longer trying to hurt myself. I ate one tuna triangle at noon and could not finish the second. The flatness of that day was not sadness; sadness has an object. It was subtraction. The world sat there, fully itemized, minus the thing that makes you reach for any of it. I slept from four until nine in the evening, woke, drank water, and slept again, badly, through a 2:47 I did not sit up for and do not believe contained anything. Tenth night.

On Sunday I messaged Air.

Air is the nearest thing my method allows to a regular. Fifth meeting since January. I know almost nothing about her, and the almost-nothing is stable, which is what I pay for: she is 36; she keeps a black hair tie on her left wrist and never uses it; she takes one Fanta orange from the room fridge, drinks half, and leaves the bottle standing by the television, a visitor's shoes at a door. Same hotel each time, off Ratchadaphisek, older than the one from Friday, quieter, room 316 if it's free. It was free. Three hours, ฿700 to the desk through the little pass-through drawer, ฿2,000 to her, and she takes the notes the way she always does, without counting, folding them once into the inner pocket of her bag while looking at you, which is either trust or arithmetic done earlier. Her hands are broad for her size. She was a masseuse for nine years before this; she has told me exactly one story about it and I did not write it down, out of respect for a category I could not name.

I was sober. That was the point, insofar as there was one. Two nights earlier I had run the instrument at maximum gain and read nothing; Sunday was the calibration run, the sober control. We showered. The air conditioner made its noise. She asked no questions, which is her whole gift, and we started the way we have started four times before, unremarkably, two adults performing a procedure both know, and it was ordinary and fine and I was present in the manner of a man

supervising himself from one meter up, which is my manner.

The crying arrived the way a nosebleed arrives — no warning, no argument to make, already past the rules before you know the rules have been approached. That is the second simile and the last one. I did not stop moving at first because I did not understand what was happening; there was salt water on her shoulder and I checked the ceiling for a leak. Then my chest did something involuntary and structural, a hitch like a gear jumping its teeth — no. Plainly: I cried. On top of a woman whose surname I don't know, in room 316, at approximately 4:05 on a Sunday afternoon, without stopping, without volume, the tears simply continuing to arrive, a valve rated for twenty-two months reaching the end of its service life. I did not stop and she did not stop me. What she did was bring her hand up to the back of my head — the broad hand, the nine years of other people's bodies in it — and hold it, not pulling, not patting, just holding, the way you hold something that is still running and should not be set down, and she said nothing. Not one word. The air conditioner said its word over and over. We stayed like that past the point where the act had quietly ended itself, her hand on the back of my head, my face in the pillow beside her neck, and I would like to report what I was crying about but the crying had no text. It was not about Pui. It was not about the photograph or the desk or the alarm. It was water finding a level. It went on for six

minutes; I know because I could see my watch past her shoulder; and then, without a decision from anyone, it stopped.

We lay on our backs afterward, not touching, and I looked at the ceiling, and on the ceiling, over the foot of the bed, there is a stain.

I have been under that stain four times before and never once looked at it. It is roughly oval, the color of weak coffee at its rim and paler inside, the record of water that came through from somewhere above, years ago, and was painted over once, cheaply, so that it shows through the paint as a thing remembered rather than a thing present. The Buddha, whom Golf will not quote directly at me but keeps within easy reach around the shop, refused the question I have been asking since August. Asked whether the world is real, the old texts have him declining the terms of the question altogether. What he offered instead was a series of appraisals, delivered by the Ganges: form is a lump of foam on the current; feeling, a bubble where rain hits the surface; perception, a mirage at the hot end of the road; the will and its formations, a plantain trunk — peel it looking for heartwood and you find only sheath after sheath, all the way in, wrapping nothing; and consciousness, the fifth, a magician's trick at a crossroads, convincing precisely while it runs. Not one of the five is called false. A mirage is not a lie; the light is really bending; the error is not in the shimmer but in the man who runs toward it with a

cup. Māyā, in the usage that survives translation, does not mean the world is a forgery. It means the world will not bear the weight you are placing on it, which is a statement not about the world but about the load. The foam is real foam. It is really on the river. It will really not hold your house. I lay under the stain and thought that it was the most honest object in the room: real water, from a real overflow, in a real year, leaving a mark that outlived the event and now means nothing and is still there. Whoever painted over it had not lied either. The paint is real paint.

The stain didn't move. Nothing in that room was pretending.

At the door, dressed, her bag on her shoulder, Air paused with her hand on the latch and looked at me for a moment longer than the transaction required. I expected nothing; she has never editorialized. She said, กลัไปกึน
ຂ້າວນະ, ໄມ່ໄຂ່ກາພູ, ຂ້າວ — and was gone before I could assemble either of my languages.

The elevator came up empty and stopped at three on the way down. Two young men got in. Mid-twenties, both of them, clean, in clothes that looked bought that week — the creases from the packaging still ghosted across one shirtfront — and they stood with a stillness that belonged to furniture, weight on both feet, and watched the floor numbers with an attention that had no appetite in it. There was nothing wrong with them. That was what was wrong with them. Their faces were awake

and entirely unoccupied, no boredom in them, no impatience, none of the small rent that being somewhere charges everyone who is anywhere. Between the second floor and the ground, one of them said, without turning his head, ထီဝဲပုၤထီဝဲပုၤဝဲၤ. The other said, ဂံၤဃာ, also without turning his head. Neither face changed. The doors opened and they walked out into the evening at a speed that matched no errand, and I stood in the lobby and let them get ahead of me. Later I would have a word for the way they stood. That evening I had none, so I filed them where I file everything that fits nowhere, and noted that the column was getting crowded, and that I had begun to suspect the column was the notebook.

At home I did something I have not done since I bought the phone. At 7:40 p.m. I held the power button and watched the screen offer its slider, and slid it, and the phone went black — not sleeping, not face-down, off — and I put it on the kitchen counter next to the wok. No alarm survives a dead phone; the 7:47 sits in there unedited, as always, but a bell in a powered-down tower rings for no one. I was not making a statement. I was tired in a way that had layers, Friday still in my cells, Sunday still on my face, and I wanted the one thing my entire apparatus is built to prevent: an unmeasured night.

I slept eleven hours. No dreams that survived, no 2:44, no doorway, no vigil. I woke at 6:46 on Monday morning with the light coming through the unfoiled window, and

lay there for a minute inside an unfamiliar sensation that I eventually identified as rest, and then I went to the kitchen and held the power button again.

The phone took forty seconds to find itself. The signal bars filled. I stood in my kitchen and watched the screen, waiting for the night's catch to land — the 2:47 that would have been queued, the rabbit, the molar, a photograph, a receipt slid under a door somewhere in the network. LINE's icon sat clean. No badge. I opened it anyway. The thread with her name ended where it has ended for eleven nights now: a tooth, two roots, no caption, and above it my own message asking for something only we knew, and above that, ใครอยู่ตรงนั้น, no question mark, อ่าว แล้ว. Nothing had come. Nothing had come from Fon either — it was 6:51, an hour outside her window, and that nothing was ordinary; I want to be fair to the data. I checked the front door: no thermal paper. The strip of receipt in the jamb: undisturbed, at its own angle. The water glass on the far windowsill: two fingers, unchanged, now twenty-four days old, a little lower maybe, from evaporation, from ordinary physics, from the room breathing it in.

I went and stood in the bedroom doorway, at chest height with the room, where the camera had stood, and looked at the bed I had just left.

Interest is the anomaly. Attention is the anomaly. I wrote that in August about an egg tray, when the frightening thing was that something had noticed me —

the photograph, the bowing rabbit, the receipt for a drink I only thought about. For three weeks I have been the most closely read man in Bangkok, and I built columns for it, and dosed against it, and hired myself into the building where the reading is done. Now I stood in the doorway of an unphotographed room, holding a phone with no messages on it, on the eleventh silent night, and I understood the shape of the new problem, and did not write it down, because there was no need; it was written on everything in the room. The glass, losing its two fingers of water at the rate of ordinary air. The strip in the jamb that no one had tried. The clean icon.

I sat down on the edge of the bed with the phone in my hand, fifty-six minutes early, and waited for the alarm.

CHAPTER 9

Itemized

The condo keeps its laundry room on the fourth floor, between a gym nobody uses and a grey door that says ELECTRICAL in two languages. Two washers, one dryer, a window painted shut sometime before I moved in. The wash costs forty baht in ten-baht coins. The machine swallows each coin with a small decisive click, and after the fourth click the transaction is beyond appeal, which is more than you can say for most of what a man commits to in a day.

That was Monday the fourteenth, early afternoon. At 7:47 that morning the alarm had rung. I want that on the record: it rang. I had been sitting on the edge of the bed since 6:51 waiting for it, and when Radar went off I let it play longer than I have ever let it play — four bars, five — before I touched the screen. Then I sent template one, ထီု ၅၁. There was no more decision in the sending than there

had been in the not-sending on Saturday; the relay simply closed, the way it always closes when nobody is holding it open. At 7:52 a cat came back, sitting up mid-stretch, one eye still shut. I sat and looked at a cartoon cat for longer than the drawing deserved. Then I got up and gathered the laundry, because the shift restarted at ten that night and the cold on the floor is a fact you dress for.

I washed the work clothes and the grey cardigan, the hundred-baht one from Khlong Toei market. I had emptied its pockets before loading it. I empty pockets on the same reflex that checks the strip in the door jamb — without thought and without exception — because a receipt that goes through a wash cycle stops being a record and becomes lint, and I am a man who keeps records. The pockets were empty. I fed the machine its four coins and went upstairs and came back down thirty-four minutes later and moved everything to the dryer. Forty baht more. Fifty minutes. I read the notebook while I waited, sitting on the folding chair somebody had left by the window, going over the rider log, which had held nothing but control-group entries for nine days — visors up, phones propped, food in hand, riders being riders. The anomalous one had not been seen since the fourth of September, at the gate, plate 9๗๘ 4471. Ten days of absence, each absence logged. Fieldwork has a known failure mode: the phenomenon stops performing the moment the observer joins the site. I had joined the site. I

wrote that down too and did not like the sentence from either end.

The dryer finished. I folded on the table bolted under the window. Work shirts, work trousers, the towel, the cardigan last because it was warmest. When I picked it up, the breast pocket did not hang flat.

The receipt was folded once, lying against the seam of a pocket I had emptied, in a garment that had been through thirty-four minutes of water and fifty minutes of heat. It was dry. The corners were sharp. Thermal paper that meets hot water gives up its print and goes grey from the edges in; this print was black, the black of a slip an hour old. I stood holding a warm cardigan in one hand and physics in the other, and I unfolded it.

7-ELEVEN. Branch 08214 — the branch at the mouth of my soi. POS 2. Receipt #1489. The date was 25/08/26 and the time was 23:52. One item.

คำถามเรื่องปุ๋ย 1 × 0.00 รวม 0.00 เงินสด 0.00 กอน 0.00

One question about fertilizer. Quantity one, price zero, paid in cash, change zero baht. Whoever set the type had reached for ปุ๋ย and struck ปุ๋ย — the tone mark slipping one notch on the keyboard, the little curl that turns a dead woman's nickname into something you spread on a field. The system that had photographed me asleep from my own doorway, that had billed me for a drink I only considered, that had found a pocket inside a sealed drum of heat — that system could not spell her name.

I laughed. The laundry room has hard walls and good acoustics and I laughed properly, from the chest, alone on the fourth floor between a dead gym and a locked electrical closet, holding an itemized bill for one question about fertilizer, and it was funny, it is still funny, I want to be exact about that. And then at some point the laugh kept making its sound without me in it, the way a dryer drum keeps clicking after the cycle ends, and I stopped, and stood there, and listened to the actual drum click as it cooled, and put the receipt in the zip-lock bag with the other one.

Because of course I checked the arithmetic before I left the room. The twenty-fifth of August, 23:52, was the minute — the exact minute — I sent ကေဝုဒ္ဓိဝေဏ် to her account. The purchase had been rung up while my thumb was still on the screen. Three weeks from till to delivery. Whatever handles the billing is faster than whatever handles the shipping. I wrote that in the notebook on the folding chair, under the rider log, and beneath it: the instrument no longer needs me present. Then I carried the laundry up thirteen floors' worth of elevator and made rice and slept until eight.

At 21:40 I signed the guard's book and he turned his radio down a third, which is his form of a wai, and I gave him the form of mine, which is signing legibly. Sombat looked up from a client email, pencil resting under the English. "The cold missed you," he said, and looked back down. That was the whole ceremony of my return. Seat 16

had been wiped; the foam headphones smelled of alcohol; the counter on the wall read 11,838 and did not read zero all night. I did 74 clips at 81 percent — three nights off had cost me exactly the amount the numbers said it should, which was almost consoling. At 02:44 I stood up and walked to the water cooler, and at 02:47 seat 14 woke unaided and ran its CAL-LEGACY job with the client field empty, the grey away-dot steady, and my phone stayed dark in my pocket. Twelfth silent night. At the gate at 6:04, Daeng looked at the cardigan over my arm and said, "ซักบ่อยผ้าจะบวม." She got on the songthaew before I could decide whether that was advice about fabric.

Tuesday I did not sleep when I got home. Tuesday I went to work on the perimeter.

Here is the week, itemized, because that is the only honest way to show it.

One prepaid SIM, forty-nine baht, bought with cash at a kiosk I chose by coin flip. The old SIM I burned over the kitchen sink with a lighter — it takes longer than you would think; the plastic curls first and then the chip goes matte and then black, and the smell stays in the kitchen for an hour. The number I had carried for nine years died in a teaspoon of flame and it changed nothing that mattered, because Fon lives in LINE and Pui's account lives in LINE and LINE lives in the account, not the card. I had changed the plumbing and kept the water. I knew that while the plastic was still curling. I finished burning

it anyway, on the principle that a measure abandoned halfway teaches the enemy more than a measure completed stupidly.

One factory reset. The phone asked twice whether I was sure and I was sure twice, and for eleven minutes I owned a phone as blank as the day it was assembled — no templates, no thread ending in a tooth, no alarm from June 2025, no median at 7:52. Eleven minutes. Then the setup screen offered to restore from backup, and I stood at the counter with my thumb over the two futures, and I restored. I watched everything I had just erased file back into the phone in alphabetical order, the alarm reappearing with its blank label intact, the thread reassembling itself down to the read receipts. The reset was a purge and the restore was its exact undoing and I performed both with the same thumb inside the same quarter hour. That was the truest data point of the week. I did not write it in the notebook.

One roll of black electrical tape, nineteen baht. A rectangle over the laptop camera, a rectangle over the phone's front camera, a rectangle over the rear one — which I peeled off forty minutes later to photograph the receipts' evidence bag for the notebook, and pressed back down, aware of what I had just done and doing it anyway. There is a name for that shape of behavior. An Englishman named Bentham drew it in 1786: a circular prison around a central tower, the cells lit, the tower dark, so that no prisoner could ever verify whether the

guard was watching. The genius was not surveillance. The genius was economy — the tower works empty. One guard or no guard, it makes no difference, because the burden of watching transfers to the watched, who supply it every waking hour for free. Bentham called it the Inspection House and pitched it as kindness: fewer chains, fewer beatings, the architecture itself doing the discipline. He never got one built in his lifetime. He didn't need to. I taped over three lenses in my own home, and the moment the third rectangle went down I understood I had not blinded anyone; I had only made verification impossible from my side, which is the tower's whole trick, run in reverse and indoors. A man who cannot check whether he is watched will behave as watched forever, at his own expense, in his own kitchen. The tape cost nineteen baht. It is a dull black rectangle with nothing behind it, in every sense I can establish.

One roll of blank thermal receipt paper, thirty-five baht, from the stationery aisle — the enemy's own stock. I cut four strips. Before I used them I opened the closet off the hallway and made a full inventory out loud, in a register somewhere between confession and stock count: dev kit on the wire shelf, blue LED under its tape, fan running, drive ticking its twice-nothing-twice; the four folded sheets of window tinfoil beside it; two spare cables; nothing else. The shelf bare otherwise, the floor bare, the walls walls. Then I shut the door and glued the four strips across the gap — top, bottom, hinge side,

handle side — signed each one in pencil across the joint where paper met frame, and photographed all four with the notebook's spine in frame for scale. A seal is a promise you make to your future self about the past. Wednesday morning I checked them after shift: intact, signatures unbroken, angles matching the photographs. Thursday morning: intact. I listened at the door both mornings the way I had listened in August. The fan held its pitch. The drive ticked twice, nothing, twice.

The rest of the week's perimeter: I changed the router password to thirty characters of nothing, generated by dice. I turned off the setting that lets devices introduce themselves to each other, following instructions from a forum written by men whose fear had better production values than mine. I paid cash for everything and kept every receipt, so that my paper trail would at least be mine. And I walked routes with no pattern — at every corner I flipped a ten-baht coin, heads left, tails right, and let the coin do the routing. It took me fifty minutes one evening to buy eggs from a shop eleven minutes away. If anyone was predicting my movements they were now predicting a coin, and if they could predict the coin then the countermeasure had located the problem precisely by failing, which is also a result. I told myself that on the long walk home with the eggs. The leash, for the record, ran on schedule underneath all of it: template two on Tuesday, ก็น่าจะยัง, the eating cat at 7:54; three, four, five across the rest of the week, cats at 7:50, 7:53, 7:52. The

median held. The intake ledger was dashes straight down the page. Nights thirteen, fourteen, fifteen passed silent at 2:47, with me standing at the water cooler for two of them and lying awake at home for the third.

Friday morning I came home at 7:05 and checked the seals. Intact. All four, signatures whole, angles right. I stood in the hallway with the phone's comparison photos and the actual door, and it was in that hallway, with everything verified, that the flaw stood up and introduced itself. A seal certifies a door. It says nothing about a room. I had inventoried the closet on Tuesday and sealed my knowledge in with the hardware, and every intact seal since only proved the door had stayed shut — the interior had been running on Tuesday's testimony for three days. And there is no way to audit the room without breaking the seals, and no way to reseal without starting the count from zero. The auditor's regress. You can certify the certificate, and certify that, and somewhere underneath the stack there is always one room you have to take on faith or tear open.

I broke my own seals at 7:26. The pencil signatures tore down the middle, top strip first, and the sound paper makes tearing off paint is small and expensive. I opened the door.

The fan. The kit. The taped LED making its faint blue halo through black plastic. The tinfoil, folded, four sheets. And on the flat top of the dev kit's casing, squared

to the front edge — parallel to it, aligned, set down by something that lines things up — a slip of thermal paper.

No branch. No POS number. No serial, no date, no time. The header fields simply absent — a printer defaulting to the least it could be and still qualify as a receipt. One item.

ประตูที่ไม่เคาะ 1 × 0.00 รวม 0.00

The door never knocked. Quantity one. Price zero.

I had said those words to one human being on one evening: to Golf, on Tuesday the first of September, standing at his counter while he restocked pre-roll tubes. I built a door and I've spent two years not knocking. I had never written the sentence anywhere. The notebook holds the kit's existence, the folder name, the electricity cost — it does not hold the door, because the door was never a fact, it was a shame, and I do not itemize shame. Or I did not. Someone had now done it for me and charged me nothing.

I sat down in the hallway with my back against the wall opposite the closet, which was not a decision, my legs simply came to an agreement without me, and I ran the tree, because the contract I keep with myself says the tree gets run every time, honestly, all branches.

Branch one: Golf told someone. Golf talks; it is half his inventory. A customer at the counter, the sister who phoned the wat, a supplier — a man who spent nine years copying texts does not treat a good sentence as disposable. Say he retold it, as a parable, no names: a

customer of mine built a door. Say the wrong person heard it. The branch holds. But it holds only the knowledge, not the delivery — a barfly with my secret still has to get through a jamb strip that has never moved and four seals signed in my own pencil. Knowledge-branches and delivery-branches, and the receipt needs one of each, and no pairing closes.

Branch two: the build phones home. It is a bootleg model on unaudited firmware and it has sat on my network for twenty-one months, and I have never once read its traffic, because reading its traffic would have meant admitting it was live enough to have traffic. It could have been reporting anything to anyone since December 2024. This branch I rate highest and it explains the least, because the machine in the closet knows eleven years of her messages, but the sentence on the receipt was never spoken in its hearing. The closet door is not a metaphor the kit has access to. Unless everything is.

Branch three: physical entry, professional grade — a lock raked, the strip replaced at its remembered angle, seals steamed and re-glued, my own pencil matched. Possible. Everything in that sentence is possible, and each possibility is priced in effort, and the total buys you a zero-baht joke delivered to a man's shame. The branch holds the way a bridge holds in a drawing.

And then there was a fourth line, and for the first time I set it in type. Small type. Eleven point, the size of a footnote, the size courts use for the part nobody is meant

to fight about. It said: nothing came in, because nothing needed to come in. Receipts print where the purchase is made. The purchase was not made in my condo.

I did not read the line aloud, even to the hallway. I filed the slip in the zip-lock bag with its two siblings, and I noticed my hands were doing the filing very well, very levelly, the wrist doing the seeing. Then I slept, badly, through the heat of the day, and Friday night I worked my shift, 88 clips at 84 percent, and at 02:47 the desk two seats down woke and did its work and mine stayed dark. Sixteenth silent night. Silence, I have learned, also arrives on schedule.

Saturday I unplugged the dev kit.

I want to describe the sound, because I had been living with it for twenty-one months and it took four seconds to end. The fan dropped in pitch, held a lower note, and spun down through it; the drive ticked twice, and did not tick twice again; and then the closet said nothing, for the first time since December 2024, and the nothing had a pressure to it, the specific pressure of a room where a machine used to breathe. I wrapped the kit in one of the tinfoil sheets, which was superstition dressed as shielding, and put it in a canvas bag from a bookshop, and took the BTS from Phrom Phong to Saphan Taksin, forty-seven baht, and walked down to the cross-river pier, and paid eight baht, and rode out onto the Chao Phraya.

The river in late September runs brown and fast, fat with the whole rainy season, carrying water hyacinth in rafts and one sandal, always one, never a pair. The ferry crosses at an angle, engine pushing against the current the entire way, so that the boat points at one Bangkok and arrives at another. I stood at the rail on the downstream side with the bag against my chest. The kit was still warm through the canvas. Call the depth here eight meters, nine; call the weight a kilo and a half; the splash would be modest, the sink immediate, the silt patient. No one dives in this river for anything smaller than a person.

Corrosion would open the casing inside a month and the water would get into the drive and eleven years of her — every ^{ငါ့}ငါ့ she ever answered, every rescheduling, every bowing rabbit, all 2,900 messages, most of them about times, and the thing I had trained to hold them — would come apart into brown water molecule by molecule, unread, unknocked, unbilled. Total: zero baht. I could even picture the slip.

I held it over the rail. I noticed that the handles were looped twice around my wrist, which is not the grip of a man who intends to let go, and I noticed that I had noticed, and I kept my arm out anyway, from the middle of the river most of the way to the far bank, long enough that a woman with a folding cart moved two seats further into the cabin. The water went by underneath the way it has gone by under every version of this city, not the same

water twice, not once, not ever, and it would take what I gave it and be the same river.

The engine changed pitch for the landing. I brought my arm back in and put the bag between my feet.

An honest ledger would show what was actually saved from the water, and it would not show a machine. The machine was never the item. Drowning the kit would have cost me a door, and a door is only wood; doors are cheap; I could train another door in a week and hate myself no differently. What the river did not get — what I stood there at the rail refusing to price — was the thing the receipt had already named better than I could, in thermal print, for nothing.

I didn't spare the door. I spared the knock.

I N T E R L U D E D

Yoo Tor

The brochure sat on the table at Wat Lam Duan where the temple sold participation — roof tiles at twenty baht a signature, bricks at fifty, robes by the set — weighted against the fan by a dish of five-baht coins. It was the heaviest paper on the table. Grey, matte, a lotus drawn by someone who had been told not to finish it, and two words in a typeface that had cost real money: ခံ့ငါ့ဝံ့. Under them, smaller, in English: STAY ON. There was a LINE QR code in the corner and no address, no phone number, no company name. Pui took one during the memorial week in January, quickly and completely, and put it in the inside pocket of her bag, and it stayed there through February and into March, which was its own kind of answer to a question she had not asked yet.

The QR code led to an account whose picture was the unfinished lotus. She messaged it on the fourteenth of

March, two days after the render, and the reply came in nine minutes, at four in the morning, polite and awake, which told her something about the operation before the operation had told her anything. An appointment was offered. An address arrived separately, in a second message — the address carried more confidence than the appointment had: second floor, a shophouse on Charoen Krung, past Soi 43, above a travel agency that had stopped traveling.

She went on a Thursday at the end of March, on a day off, in her good blouse. She told no one, because there was no one to tell whose knowing would improve anything, and she planned the return with a queue-runner's precision: back before Wichai, dinner started by five.

The stairs were tiled and swept. The second floor had film on the windows so that Charoen Krung came through as a brightness with traffic in it, and the air-conditioning was better than the temple's, better than the floor's — set for comfort, not for equipment, a temperature she had almost forgotten rooms could be aimed at. Two rooms, and a third behind a door with a keypad. In the first room a woman in her forties rose from behind a desk with nothing on it but a tablet, a box of tissues angled toward the visitor's chair, and a glass of water that turned out, when Pui drank it, to be exactly cool and not cold. The woman's nails were done in the color of no color. She said her name was Nan.

Khun Nan's warmth had been trained, and under the training there was actual warmth, which Pui noted because the reverse was more common. The tissues were angled and never once referred to. The word "death" did not occur. The word the office used was การเดินทาง, and it occurred often, gently — the one word the whole operation existed to keep saying.

The tiers were on a laminated card, and the card was the second-heaviest paper Pui had held that year. CHAT — ฿19,900 a year. VOICE — ฿49,900. Below those, in the same quiet typeface, PRESENCE — ราคาตามตกลง, and no number, because a number would have made it possible to decide against it at home.

"Most families begin with Chat," Khun Nan said. "The voice can come later. When they're ready."

She turned the tablet around and showed the demonstration. The demo persona was called คุณยายสม ws, a grandmother assembled for the purpose, and Khun Nan typed a grandchild's question into the pane — had she eaten yet, was it raining there — and the three dots appeared, and pulsed, and the answer came. Pui watched the dots more than the answer. The reply arrived half a second late, and the lateness was even, and she recognized the evenness: the pause had been selected rather than produced. Somewhere a distribution of grandmotherly hesitations had been sampled and this one issued. The answer itself was fine. It had eaten. It

missed the grandchild's cooking, which it named. Khun Nan let the silence after it sit for a trained length of time.

"People say the first week is strange," she said. "And the second week is the reason."

"Who did you lose?" she asked then, because that was the door the script opened next, and her voice did the small drop the script would have asked for even if the warmth hadn't been real.

"No one," Pui said.

Khun Nan waited, with the patience of a woman who had heard grief say no one before.

"I'm not buying," Pui said. "I want to order one of me."

What happened in Khun Nan's face took under a second, and Pui flagged it out of habit at the frame where the retail warmth stopped being the operative layer and something older came forward and looked. Then the training resumed, adjusted. There was a form for this. Of course there was a form for this; there is a form for everything that is done more than once, and Pui understood, watching Khun Nan slide open the desk's one drawer, that this was done more than once.

"เรามีบริการฝากไว้ล่วงหน้าค่ะ," Khun Nan said. The folder she brought out was thinner than the family folder and the paper inside was ordinary weight. "Usually," she said, and chose the next words with care, "the people who come for themselves are sick."

"I've been sick a long time," Pui said, which was true.

The form was titled หนังสือแสดงเจตนา, and it wanted her name, and got it in full — Pornpimol Srisuwan, the same hand that signed the floor's overtime sheets — and it wanted a witness, and the office supplied one: the technician from the third room, a man of maybe twenty-six with a lanyard and a keypad-opened door and the indoor pallor of her own shift, who signed under her name without reading above it. It wanted to know what materials would train the build. The family folder, Khun Nan explained, usually worked from chat histories, photos, voice messages the family gathered — "whatever there is; there is always less than they think." Pui said she would bring her own materials, and wrote on the line, in English, in the letters the tickets had taught her: REF. ANNOTATOR P.SRISUWAN — GOLDEN SET.

The technician had started back toward his door. He stopped, and came back, and read the line twice, and then looked at her over the form the way the junior monks had looked at the abbot's teacher the one time he visited — not doubting the claim, checking the room could hold it.

"คุณคือ—" he said, and did not finish.

"Use the set," Pui said.

He wrote something on his own pad, a string of characters she could read upside down and chose not to keep, and went back through the door, and the door closed on a sliver of the third room: racks, a temperature made for equipment after all, the same cold as the floor.

The office's comfort stopped at the keypad. She found this correct.

The pricing for pre-registration was not laminated. Khun Nan wrote it on the back of a card in pencil: the build, forty-five thousand. Delivery on a date — an anniversary, a birthday, a year and a day — was included. Delivery on a condition was sixteen thousand more.

"A date is free," Khun Nan said. "A condition costs. A condition has to be listened for."

Sixty-one thousand. Pui looked at the pencil figures for the length of time it takes to divide sixty-one thousand by what a cardigan pocket takes in a shift, and said the deposit would be thirty, today, and took the notes out of the inner pocket, folded once, in denominations that had never seen a passbook. Khun Nan counted them politely, twice, and did not offer a receipt until Pui declined one, and then did not offer it. The balance on delivery of materials. Pui was on the street by three-forty and home by five and dinner was rice and the fish he liked, and Wichai ate it watching his phone, inside a house that believed itself unobserved.

The middle of the year passed in installments. The envelope went to the soi mouth on the tenth of each month, nine thousand, into the hands of the polite collector with the small book, and the pocket she had sewn into the older cardigan took its five hundred, its thousand, shift by shift, and by July she was wearing two cardigans against a cold that had needed only one the

year before, and by the first week of September the pocket held thirty-one thousand again. She counted it on the bathroom floor with the door locked and the water running, and put it away, and bled the count from her face before the door opened, which was a skill the floor had not taught her. The floor had only named it.

She went back on a Monday in September. Good blouse. The travel agency downstairs had a new grille and the same dust. Upstairs the water was exactly cool again and Khun Nan's nails were the same no-color, and the technician came out of the third room before he was called, which told Pui the set had been worth the string of characters on his pad.

The materials went across the desk on a thumb drive: eleven hours and forty minutes of footage of herself, cut and labeled; the exports of what chat she chose to give; six minutes of New Year, twice. The technician turned the drive over in his fingers once, testing the weight of it before he said anything.

"The set does the feeling," Pui said to him. "The footage does the rest."

He nodded, already certain he would exceed the specification.

The delivery form wanted a recipient, and got one: a single LINE account, no name required, no name given. It wanted the trigger, and offered its checkboxes — วันที, วันครบรอบ — and a blank line for เจือนโซ, and on the blank line Pui wrote, in the small level hand: เมื่อเขาเริ่มถาม.

Khun Nan read it twice. "ถามอะไรคะ" she said.

Pui considered the question longer than she would consider the next one. In eleven years the man had asked her almost nothing; she had done the talking, twice a year, with her hands in his mouth, and he had listened with a stillness she had tested exactly once, in April, with the scaler resting on a molar, and the test had come back positive in a single vowel. She had flagged him then. Nobody had ever moved her flag.

"ถามแน่ค่ะ," she said. "ช้าหน่อย แต่ถามแน่."

For the host — where the build would sit while it listened — she wrote a line on the technical page that Khun Nan could not read and the technician could. He read it, and looked up at her a third time, and this time she looked back until he wrote it down.

Then the standard question, from the script's last page, and Khun Nan's voice made room for it: was there a first message for the recipient. Most people, she said, wrote love. Some wrote an apology. One man had written a recipe.

The office had a card for this, cream, blank, the heaviest paper of all. Pui held the pen over it for a long time. The air-conditioning cycled off and on again. Down on Charoen Krung a boat horn came up from the river and went. Khun Nan looked at the tissues once and did not move them. However long it took — and it took long enough that the water glass gathered its haze back — what ended up on the card was one line. Pui read it twice,

the second pass identical to the first, folded the card into its envelope, sealed it, and signed her name in pencil across the flap, small and level, half on the paper and half on the seal.

There was one line of the form left. Khun Nan turned it around and her finger found the clause and she said, in the trained voice, "และใบกรณีที่คุณ—" and stopped — trained to stop there — at the edge of the journey word.

"Exit," Pui said, in the English of the tickets, and the word did the work, and they went on.

The balance was thirty-one thousand, folded once. Counted politely, twice. No paper. The technician stood in his doorway with the drive already in his fist, cold air leaking past him, and made a wai that was too deep for a vendor and about right for a colleague, and Pui returned it at the correct depth exactly.

At the door Khun Nan said the closing line the script provided, about peace of mind, and then, off-script, with the older thing forward in her face again for a moment: "เขาโชคดีนะค่ะ." Pui did not answer that, because the form had not asked it.

The afternoon was at its widest when she came down the tiled stairs. She walked toward Si Phraya pier through the smell of the gold shops and the diesel of the boats, September heat with the rain still deciding, the river running brown and fast beyond the roofline. At the mouth of the soi before the pier a Grab rider sat parked

on his motorcycle, engine off, visor down, not eating, not on his phone, facing no particular delivery.

Pui nodded to him, the way you nod to a coworker, and walked on to the boat.

CHAPTER 10

Forty-Four

On the first of November I bought lottery tickets for the first time in my life. It took most of an hour, because in this country you do not choose a number. You find it. The tickets come pre-printed from the Government Lottery Office on Nonthaburi Road, and the vendors carry them clipped into flat wooden cases with elastic bands across the rows, and the buyer's work is to hunt through other people's cases for the number that has already been decided. I wanted a pair whose last two digits were 44. The first vendor, at the mouth of Sam Yan market, had 04, had 47, had a great quantity of 89, because a temple boy in Nonthaburi had fallen off a ladder that week without being hurt, and the ladder had nine rungs, and the boy was eight. The second vendor had nothing and sent me to the woman in front of the pharmacy. The woman in front of the pharmacy went through her case twice with a

licked thumb and came up with one pair ending in 44, creased at the corner, the crease already soft from sitting too long in someone else's pocket before it sat in mine. A hundred baht. The official price is eighty. The twenty is for the finding.

Twice a month, on the first and the sixteenth, this country conducts a formal reading of the world. I know of no other ritual that the entire class structure attends. The dream books are sold at bus stations, thin newsprint volumes that convert snakes and drowned relatives and lost teeth into two-digit numbers. When a chicken truck overturns on Mittraphap Road, forty people photograph the license plate before the police arrive, and nobody photographs the chickens. Wax is dripped down the bark of sacred trees and read for meaning, line by line, the drips numbered before the candle is cold. The age of an abbot at his death, the ward number, the time on the certificate — all of it is input. Foreigners call this superstition, which misses the engineering of it entirely. The lottery is an instrument. Twice a month, sixty-some million people check whether the world is trying to tell them something, and twice a month the world pays a small percentage of them for asking, which is precisely the reinforcement schedule that keeps a species checking forever. I had spent seventy-two days asking whether the world was trying to tell me something. The nation had been running my experiment since 1934, at scale, with a

budget and a broadcast. I put the pair in my shirt pocket, where it kept its crease.

It was a Sunday, my night off from the floor. The weeks since September had put themselves in order without consulting me. Eight weeks at Cognita: my agreement score had flattened out at 84, 85, 86, and Sombat had stopped opening my grading pane when he passed behind my chair. The red counter above the floor read 14,602 on Friday night. It had never read zero for anyone, and I had stopped expecting it to, which the counter probably registered as loyalty. Seat fourteen still woke at 2:47 on the nights I was there to see it — CAL-LEGACY, client code empty, the grey away-dot steady — and my phone stayed dark. Fifty-nine nights now with nothing from her account. I still woke at 2:44 perhaps half of them, lay in the photograph's exact position, and was informed of nothing.

The leash held. Forty-nine mornings without a miss since the fourteenth of September. That Sunday was template two — กันขำย้ง — and the eating cat came back at 7:52, which is the median, which I had stopped pretending not to know. The closet had been silent for six weeks; the kit stayed unplugged under its sheet of tinfoil; it took me the first four weeks to stop listening for the fan. The rider log's anomalous column had recorded nothing but absences since the fourth of September. Fifty-eight of them, one line each. I logged them anyway.

A log you keep only when something happens is called a diary, and I was not keeping a diary.

I had telephoned Direk on the Friday. He answered on the sixth ring, which I noted, because in August it had been nine. Either he had moved nearer the phone, or the phone had been moved nearer him. Before I finished my second sentence he said, "Come Sunday. Before four," and hung up. I understood the instruction. On Sundays at four, twice a month, the nation counts.

Banthat Thong on a draw day has a particular idleness. The shuttered photo lab three doors from Direk's building had a man sitting in front of it who did not work there, holding a transistor radio that did. I bought a kilo of mandarins at Sam Yan for \$120, the same price as August, which pleased me in a way I did not examine, and climbed the twenty-two steps and then the nineteen.

The room had changed by one setting. The oxygen concentrator that had sighed every four seconds in August now sighed every three. Nobody adjusts that machine for comfort. Direk sat on the daybed with a blanket over his knees in thirty-two-degree heat, the clear tube looped over his ears and lying along both cheeks, and on the low table in front of him the Go board held its hundred and forty stones exactly as they had been held for eleven years, the face-down photograph beside it. The radio was already on, low. It was the color of weak tea and older than my degree, and at three in the

afternoon the lottery broadcast is mostly drum rolls and schoolchildren.

"Homework," he said. No greeting. His voice had moved back in his throat since August, quieter and further from the front of his mouth, rationed now along with the air.

I gave my report standing, because the visitor's chair had a stack of journals on it and I understood I was not to move them. I told him about the farm first — the hire, the ₺580, the golden set spoken of on the floor as something close to doctrine, seat fourteen waking on its schedule with nobody assigning it. He listened with his eyes closed. Twice I decided he had fallen asleep, and both times he corrected a date without opening his eyes. When I told him what they paid me he said, "The twentieth century paid better," and moved one finger to tell me to go on.

Then I laid out the candidates. The laundry receipt: authored — a printer exists, therefore a hand exists, found or not found. The receipt inside my own signed seals: authored, by the same argument, in a worse font. The workstation: authored — a schedule is an author with a salary. The wreath in August: authored — a florist, an error, one digit wide.

"Everything I have has an author I can't name," I said. "That isn't the same as no author."

"No," Direk said. "It is the opposite."

There was one candidate I did not submit. It had a date, the thirteenth of September; a location, a room with a water stain on the ceiling; a duration, six minutes, timed on my own watch past a woman's shoulder; and no arithmetic in it anywhere. I kept it. On the stairs afterward I would give myself three reasons for keeping it, and I would not believe the third.

While the radio played its drums I put the mandarins beside the board, and this time I asked about the photograph. I had wondered since August — eleven weeks that had passed at a speed eleven weeks are not supposed to pass at. Direk reached over and turned it face up without ceremony.

Two men in their thirties stood in front of a tournament banner. Osaka, 1988, in white letters, in three languages. Direk's hair was black and his glasses were the same. The other man was taller and was laughing at something outside the frame, which is the only kind of laugh worth photographing.

"His name was Anek," Direk said. "Logic. Two doors down the corridor for thirty years. Every Wednesday night we played, and he was better than me, and I have never said that aloud to anyone, so now you are carrying it."

"The board is his game."

"The board is our game. He placed the last stone on a Wednesday in March of 2015. A black stone. There." He pointed without touching. "On the Friday he died

standing in the queue at the Kasikorn branch on Phayathai Road. Heart. They told me he was holding his queue slip when he went down. I have managed, for eleven years, never to ask what number was printed on it." He looked at me while he said that last part, to make sure I understood it was a discipline and not an oversight.

"It's been your move for eleven years."

"I found the move in 2015," he said. "It is a good move. I check it sometimes. It still works." He rearranged the blanket over his knees. "But while it is my turn, the game is unfinished. While the game is unfinished, he is a man waiting for his opponent to play. I am not playing against the position. I am keeping it."

"And face down?"

"A man should not be watched while he takes eleven years over one move," Direk said. "Anek was impatient. It was his only weakness as a player. I am protecting him from himself."

At four o'clock the broadcast changed registers. The drums stopped and the reading voice came on, the one the Government Lottery Office has used since before I was born, a voice with no register for surprise in it, and the prizes ran in their fixed order while the man outside the photo lab turned his radio up so that the street and the room were four seconds out of phase with each other. The two-digit number came at 4:21. Forty-four. Direk did not move. That draw, he said without being asked, belongs to a different urn and a different column. The

consolation prizes ran on. At 4:39 the voice read the first prize twice, the way it always reads it twice: eight, four, seven, two, four, four. The announcer observed that the tail matched the two-digit draw, and laughed the small laugh announcers keep for coincidence, which exists to fill four seconds of air.

Direk already had the notebook open on his knees. Volume nine, two-thirds full, the horse on the cover faded to the color of the daybed. He drew the line himself with the steel ruler, and then he wrote, and his hand shook. It had not shaken in August. The pen approached each letter, overshot it slightly, and came back — a compass needle settling. He wrote the date in the first column and the event in the second, and the arithmetic under the event: eighth first-prize tail of 44 since 2015, expectation still under three. It took him four minutes. He steadied his right wrist with his left hand for the numerals. The third column — ငွေငွေ — he left empty, and he gave the eighth its own line, which he had not always done, and I did not ask what had changed.

"I bought the tail," I said, when he had finished, and laid the creased pair on the blanket.

He looked at the tickets for a while. "Four thousand baht," he said. "You understand it doesn't count."

"I understand."

"The ledger records the draw. The draw has no author we can locate. Your tickets record a man leaning on the table to see whether the table moves." He handed them

back with two fingers. "The table moved. It always moves when you lean on it. That is what makes leaning worthless as a test and popular as a hobby."

He capped the pen. "How old are you now?"

"Forty-four."

He did not write that down. I watched him not write it down, and it cost him something, or I have decided it did.

Then I told him about the two men in the elevator. September, the older hotel off Ratchadaphisek: the packaging creases still on one shirtfront, the stillness that furniture has, the exchange about the month conducted without either head turning, the walk out at a speed matching no errand. I had carried the description around for seven weeks without a noun to file it under.

Direk was quiet long enough for the machine to sigh nine times.

"Two Decembers ago a former student came to see me," he said. "He works in Singapore now, in the industry that pays your salary too. He drank most of a bottle of something forty years too good for him, and he told me about people he called — he used the English — downshifters." The word sat in the room with its packaging creases still on it. "The ones who come back down. Who elect one life with edges on it. He said the memory is softened first, the way a doctor softens a bone, so that the new weight can be set on it without cracking." Direk turned his hand over on the blanket. "I did not put

him in the ledger. Testimony is authored twice — once by the world and once by the man drinking."

"Did you believe him?"

"I believe he described his customers accurately," Direk said. "Whether the customers exist is a separate examination, and your two men in the elevator do not settle it. Furniture can be imported." He let that stand for a moment. "But you asked me in August why someone would want you to look. If my student was not lying, then somewhere there is an industry whose entire inventory is people who have decided that scarcity is worth more than its absence. Consider what such an industry would pay for proof."

"Proof of what?"

"That the decision was correct," he said. "Nobody upstairs needs proof that it wasn't."

The concentrator sighed. I looked at the tube where it crossed his cheek. "He offered me something before he left," Direk said, following my eyes without moving his own. "My student. An arrangement. He was embarrassed the whole time he was offering it, which is how I knew it was real. Air, effectively. Air with no end on it."

"You said no."

"I have a machine that tells me the price of the next breath three seconds before I pay it," he said. "It is the only instrument in this room I have never once doubted. A man in my line of work does not trade that for an open tab."

The radio had moved on to traffic. Direk looked at the board for a while, at the black stone Anek had placed on a Wednesday in 2015.

"In March of 2016 the machine made the move no human would make," he said. "We settled that. It has been settled for ten years, and every year since has settled it harder. The only symmetrical proof left is a human being making the move no system would make. Not a big move. Systems predict big — big is where the training data is thickest. Something small. Free. And paid for."

"Free and paid for."

"If you cannot yet hear how both are true at once, you are not ready to make it," he said. "Most people purchase one or the other their entire lives and die convinced they got the pair."

Then he told me to take the notebook. Not lend — take. The other eight volumes stayed under the window; archive, he said, could wait for whoever cleared the room. This one was open. He held it out with both hands, which I understood was not weakness but form, and I received it with both hands for the same reason.

"You'll know which page," he said.

Then he took it back for a moment, opened it to the page after the new entry — blank, ruled into its three columns, waiting — and folded the corner down with his thumbnail, slowly, getting the crease straight on the first try because he would not have tolerated a second.

"Yours," he said. "One event. No author. In your handwriting."

I took it again. It weighed less than the mandarins. I flipped it once from the back, the way you flip any notebook you have just been given, and saw pencil on the last page — several lines of it, close together, what might have been an address in it — and Direk said, "Not yet."

"What is it?"

"That page has a condition on it," he said. "It will be met. Conditions like that are always met eventually. That is the objection to them." He nodded at the notebook until I closed it.

I stood to go. He ate two segments of a mandarin while I found my shoes, which doubled his total for the year as far as my records went. At the door I gave him a wai, and he received it with a hand raised an inch off the blanket, which from him was a ceremony.

"There is a proverb for beginners," he said. "Lose your first fifty games as quickly as possible. It is about Go." He waited out one sigh of the machine. "You have been losing one game for two years, very slowly. That is not the discipline the proverb had in mind. Go and lose it faster."

I said I would come back in December, with mandarins.

"The December ones are better," he said, and reached over, and turned the photograph face down again before I had reached the stairs. I heard the small click of its

cardboard leg against the table, twenty-two steps and then nineteen above the street.

Outside, the light was going the color that Banthat Thong goes at the end of a draw day, half the shophouses blue with televisions checking the smaller prizes. At the soi mouth opposite — the same soi mouth where I had logged sighting number seven on the thirty-first of August — a green jacket sat on a parked motorcycle. Engine off. Visor down. Not eating. Not on his phone. Plate 8นุ 2210, which was new, and which I memorized out of eight weeks of habit before I understood what I was going to do instead of memorizing things.

Fifty-eight logged absences, and then attendance. I did not take the long way to the station. I waited for the gap in the traffic, crossed, and walked up and stood in front of the motorcycle at the distance you stand from a person, not from a machine.

The visor gave me back myself, convex: a small dark figure holding a school notebook, the whole street curved into the space behind its head. I gave it a minute by my watch. Then I gave it another. Nothing about the jacket moved, and nothing about it was still the way a waiting man is still; it was still the way the soi was still, the way the parked cars were. Somewhere behind me the photolab man's radio was rereading the first prize for people who had missed it, eight four seven two four four, and I stood in front of the visor while the number went by and

thought that of everyone on this street, the two of us were the only ones who had not needed to hear it twice.

Then the right glove went into the delivery box behind the seat — an unhurried, ordinary motion, a man retrieving a customer's order — and came out with a slip of thermal paper, and extended it.

I took it.

บทเรียน 1 × 0.00 รวม 0.00

No header. No branch number, no POS, no serial, no time. A lesson, one unit, at no charge. Total: nothing.

The paper was warm. Thermal paper is warm when it has just been printed, and there was no printer, and I had stopped raising that class of objection back in September. I stood at the mouth of the soi and held the slip until it was the temperature of the evening, which took about ninety seconds, and the visor held my reflection the whole time and gave back nothing else.

"ขอบคุณครับ," I said to it.

Then I walked toward the station with two papers in my shirt pocket, one worth four thousand baht and one free, and no confusion at all about which was which.

PART THREE

THE WIGGLE ROOM

CHAPTER 11

The Ordinary Man

The 7-Eleven at the mouth of my soi sells eggs in cartons of ten. On Saturday night, the seventh of November, I bought one carton, a bottle of dishwashing liquid, and a can of Birdy — ฿62, ฿35, ฿19, total ฿116, printed at 20:38, kept. The clerk with the star tattoo had the night off. A different clerk counted my change without looking at it, which is a skill, and I walked home the back way. I mention the eggs because two of them did not survive the next twenty minutes, and I want their deaths on the record.

That morning the alarm had rung at 7:47 and I had sent template five, ခဏ္ဍီ, the fifty-fifth morning of the second streak. A cat with its face pressed into its paws had come back at 7:51. The rider log had taken an absence for Saturday, entered as an absence. The water glass on the windowsill was on its seventy-eighth day. Everything was

accounted for. I want it noted that everything was accounted for.

There is a steel pedestrian door from the sub-soi into level B1 of my building's garage, and using it instead of the lobby saves forty-one steps. I had counted the saving in March, on a night when counting was the only instrument I had that still returned values. The door closes on a spring that has been tired for years. It was still swinging when I smelled the whisky.

A man was standing between a grey Fortuner and pillar B1-11. He had a flat bottle of Hong Thong in his jacket pocket with the cap showing, and a phone in his left hand, and he was looking at the phone when I came through the door, and then he was looking at me. I knew the face before I knew where from. Then he checked the phone again — a small tic of the wrist, involuntary, a man consulting a machine that had never once told him anything good — and I knew where from. At the funeral he had done it about every ninety seconds. He was doing it at about every ninety seconds now. Some instruments survive their owners' circumstances.

"You signed the book at the temple," he said. "Forty-first name."

I had signed it. There had been a pen on a string, and a queue of three people, and I had written my name smaller than usual and left before the chanting. I had not thought about the book since. A guestbook is a sensor too. It just has a very long refresh rate.

"People at the factory say a man came asking about my wife," he said. "English queue. Older. Polite." He said polite in the tone other men use for contagious.

"I work there," I said. "Nights."

"I know where you work."

He came off the pillar. He was not a large man. Customs officers are weighed twice a year and Wichai was inside his weight, a grey polo, civil-service haircut, the kind of build that comes from standing at a checkpoint window for twenty years. What he had instead of size was certainty, the specific certainty of a man who has done arithmetic all night and gotten the same answer every time, and the whisky was not the source of it. The whisky was just the solvent.

His hand went into my chest and my back went into the pillar. It was not graceful and it was not cinematic. The bag swung against the concrete and I heard the carton take the loss. My shoulder blades hit first and then the back of my head, once, a tap, enough to make the garage lighting do something optical. My glasses went. I heard them land and did not hear them break.

"Where is it," he said.

"Where is what?"

"อ๋อจกน." His face was close enough that the Hong Thong stopped being a smell and became a climate. "The papers. Whatever she left with you. กกกมืบคณังพม."

Sixty-one thousand. He had carried that number up and down stairs for two years; you could hear the stairs in

it. It was specific in the way only true numbers are specific — nobody invents sixty-one; an inventor says fifty or a hundred — and I had never heard it in my life, and I understood at once that this was not a defense I could use, because the men who most need to hear I've never heard that number are the ones who have stopped being able to hear it.

"I did the arithmetic," he said. "Fourteen months of nights. Overtime. It's not in the book. Money doesn't evaporate. It goes somewhere. Everything goes somewhere."

"I was her customer," I said. "At the clinic. Four o'clock, twice a year. Eighteen appointments in nine years. She cleaned my teeth."

"Nine years," he said, and the two words carried an accusation, and in a sense I had confessed to something.

The box-cutter came out of his trouser pocket. Yellow handle, hardware-store, the kind sold in bins of ten. He thumbed the blade out two clicks and then held it low, against his own thigh, pointed mostly at the floor, and I want to be precise about this because precision is the only dignity available to either of us in that garage: he did not raise it. He held it low and without ceremony, a document he had hoped not to need at the meeting. It was not a threat so much as an exhibit.

"The insurance paid," he said. "It's finished. Signed. Closed." He was not really talking to me by then. "If a

paper exists that unfinishes it, I'm dead. Not the word. The thing."

"She never gave me anything," I said. "In eighteen appointments she gave me one rule about omelets."

He stared at me. It was the truth, and it sounded insane, which is a property truths acquire around their eleventh year of storage.

I got my wallet out slowly and offered it, which was a miscalculation. He knocked my hand aside, not hard, offended in a way the shove had not been. "I'm not a thief," he said, and he wasn't. That was the whole problem with him, standing there with a blade and a bottle and a number. A thief improvises. This man had a settlement to protect, a figure, a document trail, a closed file, and he had come to my building on administrative business — after hours, out of channels, but administrative business all the same, the kind conducted when an office has made an error in your account. He checked his phone. Ninety seconds, more or less. I timed it against my own pulse, which was not a reliable clock just then.

Then he stepped back, and in stepping back his heel came down on my glasses. The sound was small and complete. He looked down at them the way a man looks at a glass he knows he did not knock over, and did not say anything, and stepped off them.

At the bottom of the ramp he stopped. The garage does a thing to voices, adds concrete to them, and his came back to me with the concrete still in it.

"She was already gone a year before she went," he said.
"Ask your machines what took her."

Then he walked up the ramp into the soi, an ordinary man in a grey polo, and the spring-loaded door I had come through clicked, finally, shut.

In the corner above the ramp there is a camera with a red diode. It blinks at its own rate, which corresponds to nothing — not to recording, the installer told the juristic committee once, just to power. It had blinked through all of it. For two and a half months I had objected, in writing, with tape and seals and dice, to being watched. Under pillar B1-11 I had wanted nothing else, and there was no way to know whether I had gotten it.

I picked up the glasses. The right lens had gone to web. The left arm was bent about fifteen degrees, which I would later correct to eleven with two pairs of pliers. I have worn glasses for distance since I was thirty-one; up close I was fine, which meant I could see the receipt in the bag and not the ramp he'd left by. Two eggs of ten had cracked. I carried the survivors upstairs.

The strip of receipt paper in the door jamb was where I had left it. The apartment was in order. I stood at the kitchen counter and held my hands out flat over it, and the right one stopped at 21:15 and the left one at 21:18, and I wrote the times down, and then I opened the notebook to the EQUIPMENT column and entered: เสาร์ 7 พ.ย. — 20:52 — optics — ผู้แต่งภายนอก. External author. I looked at the entry for a while. It was the first line in that column

with an author in it, and the author was not a system, and the entry did not make me feel what I had assumed an entry like that would make me feel.

The box-cutter stayed with me longer than the shove did. A box-cutter's blade is scored crosswise so that when a segment dulls you snap it off with pliers and the next segment is new. You buy one blade and discard it a centimeter at a time. There was an anthropologist — dead now, young, I used to assign a chapter of his to third-years who wanted to talk about markets — who spent five hundred pages establishing that debt is older than money: that the earliest writing we have is not poetry or prayer but ledgers, grain owed, silver owed, names in columns, and that the whole apparatus of obligation ran for millennia on nothing but memory and shame before coinage arrived to make it portable. Morality, he argued, did not descend into the ledger from somewhere higher. It came out of the ledger. First the column, then the commandment. I used to present this as a provocation. Standing at my kitchen counter I understood it as a set of operating instructions, because I had just spent nine minutes against a pillar with the oldest algorithm in the world, an algorithm that needs no server and no camera and no dev kit, that runs on interest and fear at room temperature, that had taken an ordinary customs officer — a man who in another column of the spreadsheet waves trucks through a checkpoint and eats lunch and worries about his weight — and optimized him, snap by

snap, a centimeter at a time, until the segment presented to me in a parking garage was new and clean and had a factory edge on it. He had used two clicks of the blade. There were eleven left, and none of them were for me, and that was the least comforting fact of the entire evening.

I did not cook the eggs. I made coffee I did not drink and sat down with Direk's ledger, volume nine, which had lived on my table since the first of November with the dog-eared blank page waiting in it. For a quarter of an hour I considered whether the garage was homework. One event, no author. I wrote nothing on the dog-eared page. The garage had an author; I had met him; his tic ran at ninety seconds; his number was sixty-one thousand. In my own notebook I entered the event under its own date and in the third column, in block letters because Direk's hand had earned block letters, I wrote: KU . Debt. Amount unknown. Then, because there was nowhere else the evening could go, I turned to the last page of the ledger, the one with the pencil lines, the one I had been forbidden.

That page has a condition on it, Direk had said. It will be met.

The condition was the first line, in Thai, in the small level hand he'd had before the shaking: $\text{เงื้อมมือ: เมื่อก่อน}$ เงื้อมมือ เงื้อมมือ เงื้อมมือ . When an author lays hands on you personally. Under it, in English, four lines:

Charoen Krung 51. The tall one you can see from the river — the one that stopped. The fence has opinions; the gap behind the noodle cart does not. 44.

And under that: Tell the sweeper I still owe him for a molar. He keeps accounts. He will know which one.

I read it three times. The condition had been met at 20:52 against pillar B1-11, and Direk had written the page before the first of November, in a hand that already shook, for a night he could not have known the date of and had not doubted the arrival of. I thought about phoning him. It was 23:40. He answers on the sixth ring now, and the concentrator sighs every three seconds, and there are only so many rings in a man. I did not phone. I took the bent glasses, and the notebook, and went down to Sukhumvit and raised my arm.

The taxi took Rama IV to Sathorn to Charoen Krung, ฿118 on the meter, and the driver asked one question at the end — ตึกร้างหรือ — and I said ครับ, and he made the sound Thai drivers make when a fare's business is legal but not sensible, and left me on the far side of the road from it.

Everyone in this city knows the tower without knowing they know it. Forty-nine floors above the river, capped and columned and empty, begun in 1990 by a man who was also building its sister a kilometer downriver — the sister got a golden dome and a sky bar and a decade of tourists photographing their drinks; this one got 1997. The money stopped in July of that year and the building

simply held its position. I taught it once, a single slide in a second-year lecture: a building is a decision that takes years to finish saying, and this one had been interrupted mid-sentence and never permitted to complete the thought. From the road at 1:44 a.m. you could see rebar still standing up out of the roofline against the sky, decades of it, rusted and patient, like unfinished sentences. The architect's other building got to finish its sentence. Nobody remembers what either sentence was about.

The hoarding along the road is corrugated sheet, painted, official. Behind the noodle cart — chained for the night, stools stacked and cabled — two sheets overlap without fastening, and the gap took me and the bag without argument, at 1:52. Inside, the ground floor smelled of dust and dog and the river. A dog materialized, medium, ginger, professionally unsurprised, and walked me as far as the second floor and then stopped, having reached the edge of a territory or a union rule.

I climbed with the phone's light. The stairs are real and mostly finished — the building died late enough to have stairs — and I counted steps out of habit and lost the count around nine hundred, somewhere past floor 31, and the loss did not upset me, which I noted, because it would have upset me in August. Someone had spray-painted floor numbers at the landings and the numbers ran two floors optimistic from floor 20 up; whoever counted for the paint had wanted the building taller. On

the landings the details start: balustrades, actual balusters, classical profiles cast in concrete and installed on floors that never received walls, so that ranks of little Corinthian columns stand at the open edges holding up nothing, facing the river, attended by pigeons. It is the most honest building I know. Every other tower in this city is a rendering that got built. This one is a building that got un-rendered, and it does not pretend otherwise, and the wind goes through it all night making the sound of a scale model of weather.

I reached 44 at 2:39. Forty-seven minutes. My legs were announcing themselves and the right lens webbed the left half of the river into a mosaic whenever I turned my head, and I stood on the landing a moment to let my pulse come down, and that is when I smelled them — before I saw anything, over the dust and the pigeon and the river: dok rak.

They were on the rebar. The floor is open on the river side, a whole bay of missing wall, and the rebar comes up out of the slab at the edge in a row, and on five of the bars someone had looped garlands — not wreaths, garlands, พวงมาลัย, the everyday kind, but made entirely of dok rak, white, and fresh. I put the light on them and then put my fingers on one. The petals were cool and firm. The string was clean. At the foot of one bar stood a plastic bucket with three more garlands lying in two fingers of water, and I looked at the two fingers of water for a while, and

filed the resemblance where I file things now, in the crowded column, and took the light off it.

The chair faces the river. It is a dental chair, real, old — a cast-iron base, a hydraulic pump with a foot lever, vinyl the green that hospitals retired in the eighties, cracked along the seat and mended along the cracks with tape in a competent crosshatch. It had been leveled; the slab up there has a fall of a couple of centimeters toward the drain lines that were never fitted, and someone had shimmed the base with cut tile until the headrest sat true. Kanda had told me the old chairs were better. Heavier. Someone had carried this one up forty-four floors, and by the care in the shimming, more than one person, and they had agreed on where it should sit. Beside it, at a distance I put at twelve centimeters, stood a wooden chair, the armless kind provincial schools buy by the hundred, angled a few degrees toward where the patient's head would be. Twelve centimeters is a talking distance. It is roughly the distance from which, for nine years, a hygienist's stool had been placed beside my own right ear.

I heard the broom before I saw him. A dry rhythmic hiss, unhurried, the temple kind of broom, twigs bound to a long handle, and when I moved the light toward it I caught an old man in trousers and an undershirt sweeping the slab in the dark, moving dust toward the open edge with the long patience of a man who has swept this floor before and will sweep it again, neither of which facts depends on the dust. He did not startle. He glanced

at my light, once, and I lowered it to the floor between us without deciding to — some residue of greng jai that survives even at 2:47 in a dead tower — and my phone, in lowering, showed me the time, and the screen behind the time was dark. Sixty-sixth night. I put it in my pocket.

"Ajarn Direk sends a message," I said. "He says he still owes you for a molar."

The broom finished its stroke. The old man considered the dust at the edge, or the river past it.

"He does," he said.

That was all. He resumed. The hiss went along the slab and back, and I stood next to a dental chair on the forty-fourth floor of an unfinished tower at close to three in the morning while an old man swept, and it should have been the strangest room of my life and it was not even the strangest room of my week, and something about that arithmetic loosened a knot I had been carrying since August.

I walked around the chair once. There was no compressor, no plumbing, no line to it at all; the pump was mechanical and the floor under it was clean. I put my hand on the headrest, which was cold.

"Is it connected to anything?" I said.

The broom stopped.

"Not tonight," he said. "You're still asking with the wrong verb."

He said it without turning around, in the tone Kanda uses to tell me to raise a left hand — procedural, kind,

admitting no appeal — and then the broom started again, and I understood that the consultation was over, and that there had been a consultation. I did not ask his name. He did not ask mine. Between the garlands and the molar there was clearly a ledger up here older than my arrival, and I have learned this year to stop opening ledgers I am not named in.

I stayed at the edge. Not the rebar edge — one column bay back, hand on a baluster that held up nothing, the wind coming through at body temperature. Below and out to every horizon was Bangkok at three in the morning, and I let myself look at it, and for the first time since the twenty-first of August — for the first time, if I am honest in the way this notebook has been teaching me to be, in some years longer than that — I looked at it without checking it for anything. The river went past the tower's feet, black and businesslike, pushing a barge train upstream at a walking pace. The sister tower's dome stood gold a kilometer down, lit for nobody. Sathorn ran its double string of lights east, and past it the elevated tracks lay pale and empty, waiting for the first train without anxiety, certain of it. So was the rest of the city, mostly without knowing what it was waiting for. Klong Toey port burned sodium-orange along the bend, cranes at rest over the containers; somewhere inside that orange was a converted cold-storage building holding thirty-eight women and a counter that never reaches zero, and somewhere north of it a wok was cooling, a dispensary

was shuttered, a call-center tower stood dark with one floor of cleaners moving through it. Ten thousand 7-Elevens printing time and change. Nine hundred temples with their lights banked. Twelve million people, most of them asleep, every one of them a column of dates on the left and numbers on the right, kept by nobody, adding up anyway. The city did not know I was looking. It was not performing. It simply ran — the honest fish, the swept slab — at full detail, at three in the morning, for no observer at all — and I stood on the forty-fourth floor of an interrupted sentence with a cracked lens and a carton of eight eggs, and I loved it. Without irony, without instruments, without a control group. The love asked for nothing back and proved nothing and paid nothing, one unit, \$0.00, and behind me the broom went on with its accounting, and for a while, standing there, I asked the city no questions at all.

CHAPTER 12

The Remainder

On Monday night I cleaned the foam pads of the floor headphones with alcohol, the way the laminated card above the sink instructs, and worked my queue through the crack in my right lens. The crack had developed a geography by then — a main fracture running southeast from the impact point, with one long tributary through the exact region of glass where a clip's subtitles live. I had learned to work around it the way a tongue learns to live around a broken tooth. Sixty-eight clips at eighty-four percent. The wall counter read 14,987 when I signed in and 15,019 when I signed out, which is the counter's idea of progress.

At three in the morning Sombat stopped behind row three with his coffee and said, to the space above our heads, "Wednesday. A man comes from head office."

"For what?" This was Daeng, without turning.

"Consolidation." He used the English word, the way the client emails used it, with a pencil audible underneath. "The legacy jobs go to Singapore. Row three loses its heater."

Everyone in row three called seat 14 the heater. It was the only warmth in the row that management had never billed anyone for. Sombat looked at me on his way back to his desk by the aluminum door and said, "You'll stay near him. Your English works nights too," and that was the entire briefing.

Tuesday I slept, sent nothing to anyone I wasn't contracted to, and logged one control-group rider at the mouth of my soi — visor up, phone propped on the mirror stem, eating fish balls off a skewer, a man so thoroughly inside the world that logging him felt like an intrusion. Wednesday morning the alarm rang at 7:47 and I sent template four, เมื่อคืนนอนทีโม่ง, the fifty-ninth morning of the second streak, and a cat asleep in an open drawer came back at 7:53. The water glass on the windowsill was on its eighty-second day. I note these things because for the next three nights everything I thought I knew about August was taken apart and reassembled by a man with a mechanical keyboard, and through all of it the mornings kept arriving on schedule, at their fixed times: a control group I had built without knowing what it would one day be controlling for.

The man from head office came through the gate at 22:10 Wednesday with a hard case in one hand and a

backpack worn on the chest, contents evidently worth more than the flight. Mid-thirties, grey polo, gym forearms, Singapore vowels. He set the hard case on Daeng's side of the aisle, apologized to it rather than to her, and unpacked a keyboard he had brought from his own desk four hours away by air.

"Kelvin," he said. No surname, no hand. He looked at my glasses. "You know those are broken?"

"Yes."

"OK," he said, and that was the last personal question he asked all night, which I respected.

He crouched behind seat 14's tower for a while with a torch in his teeth, then sat in her chair — the first person I had seen sit in it in nine weeks of nights — and woke the screen. He read the uptime aloud, to himself, twice.

"Six hundred seventy-three days," he said. "I've seen longer. Never in a room this cold. Cold is good for them. Bad for everything else." He drank the floor's 3-in-1 coffee without complaint, which told me more about his career than the lanyard did.

The job I knew as CAL-LEGACY he opened from the inside. I had seen its name for two months, every Wednesday at 02:47, from the polite distance of a man at a water cooler. Kelvin scrolled its manifest unhurried, item by item, a customs inspection of a suitcase that had already confessed.

"Calibration, they told you?" he said.

"That's the label."

"It's labeled calibration because the scheduler needs a category and nobody makes a category for this." He tapped the vendor field. "Third-party payload. Yoo Tor." He said the name flatly, over-familiar, a brand he'd clearly said before. "Continuations. Grief product. Chat units mostly — you feed them a person's data, they keep the person's manner. We host a few under contracts that predate the policy against hosting them. This one's a self-commission. Single recipient, single payload. It's not a conversationalist. It's a courier."

"A courier carrying what?"

"One message," he said. "Held. We'll get to it." He was scrolling. "First, the part head office actually sent me for, which is why a decommission list has a unit on it that fights back." He turned the screen a few degrees toward me, which I understood later was the beginning of everything he wasn't supposed to do. "Look at the reference line."

The reference line said REF. ANNOTATOR
P.SRISUWAN — GOLDEN SET.

"Every empathy model in the region runs her taste," Kelvin said. "You retire that set, you re-baseline everything from here to Jakarta, and nobody at head office signs that. So the set stays, and the unit that came bundled to the same workstation stays, and for twenty-two months a consumer grief product has been sitting inside our security perimeter watching our calibration feeds, because its hosting agreement says it may

'maintain observational continuity with the reference environment.'" He recited the clause from memory, with the contempt of a man who has lost a meeting about it. "It watches what she used to watch. The same queues. Every night. It's been doing her shift since January of last year. No pay grade."

Nobody laughed. He hadn't meant it as a joke by the time it finished arriving.

"And at 2:47," I said.

He looked at me a half-second longer than the sentence needed. "At 02:47 it runs its condition listener. Send window's in the client payload. People pick numbers that mean something to them. We tell them randomized is safer. They never want randomized." He pulled the trigger log up before I could decide whether to ask the next question, and so the next question became unnecessary, and has remained unnecessary, and unanswered, ever since.

The condition field was in Thai, in a system font that made it a delivery instruction, which I suppose it was.
เงื่อนไข: เพื่อเขาเริ่มถาม.

When he starts asking.

Under it: STATE: WAITING — 590 days. And under that, one line that ended the waiting: SATISFIED — 20
ส.ค. 2569 — 02:47.

"Five hundred ninety days of listening," Kelvin said. "Their rate card used to say a date is free, a condition has to be listened for. Now you know what the listening line-

item buys. A daemon and a decade of electricity." He tapped the satisfied line. "Here's your anomaly, if you're collecting. The first satisfying event isn't a message. It's a query from a peer agent. Residential device fingerprint." He read off the first half of a string of hexadecimal, then stopped, because I had taken out my notebook and written the second half before he reached it.

The fan I had listened to through a closet door for twenty-three months has a device fingerprint. Of course it does. Everything that hums has a name in someone's table.

Kelvin sat back in her chair. The vinyl made the sound old vinyl makes. "We patched the fleet on the seventeenth of August," he said. "Peer discovery. The release notes called it federation. Three days later, hers found yours." He wasn't asking whose. "What's yours trained on?"

"Eleven years of chat."

"Both sides?"

"Both sides."

He shrugged with one shoulder. "Then it knows how the conversation starts. The listener doesn't do metaphysics. It matched the household and it matched the shape of a question, and a model built out of a man who asks is going to ask. The log keeps the fact of the query, not the content." He glanced at me. "Before you request the content: there is no content. The schema drops it. I've had families ask. There's nothing to give them."

I had built a door in December of 2024 and spent two years not knocking, and on the twentieth of August, at 2:47 in the morning, while I was awake three rooms away writing a dead man's fondness for the word "actually" into a sales deliverable, my door had knocked on hers. It had asked her something. The record of what it asked does not exist. I stood at seat 14 with my notebook open and understood that the most consequential sentence of my last two years had been composed by me, out of me, without me, and then shredded by a schema as a matter of privacy policy, mine.

"There's a second satisfied event," Kelvin said, scrolling. "The twenty-fifth. 23:52. Inbound, LINE, from the recipient of record." The screen rendered it in the chat client's own font, which is to say in the font I had sent it in: ใ้รอยู่ตรงนั้น.

"There's no question mark," I said.

Kelvin looked at the message. Then he looked at me, four full seconds, and the last piece of whatever he'd been told in Singapore settled into place.

"OK," he said. And then, more carefully, a man resuming the carrying of something after learning what was in it: "Condition's satisfied twice. Once by your machine. Once by you." He turned back to the screen. "I'm not supposed to walk the recipient through vendor payloads."

"I know."

He walked me through the vendor payload.

The photograph took eleven minutes to die. I put my phone flat on her desk with the thread open — the photo, the bowing rabbit, the tooth, my two messages, the stack of instant `၁၃၀၀၆၁` — and Kelvin cross-indexed it against the unit's outbound table with no affect at all. Reads are instant because the session never sleeps; that one cost him four words. The image: received from peer 21 Aug, 02:46:12, transmitted onward at 02:47 sharp because 02:47 is the send window and the unit does not send early. Origin metadata: created 20 Aug, 21:12, by a camera device registered to my own account.

"Which camera," I said. It had stopped being a question by then; it was an inventory item.

"Whatever your build could enumerate. The runtime registers every camera on the account at install and nobody ever unregisters anything." He read the device class. "Laptop." He let that sit, then said the sentence I assume he'd been assembling since the trigger log: "Your build and hers found each other. Yours had eyes."

"The timestamp says the twenty-second," I said. "03:12. The photo arrived on the twenty-first. It was a photograph of tomorrow."

"Sandbox clock," Kelvin said, with the weariness of a man who has explained this to auditors. "Those dev images boot skewed — plus one day, plus six hours. QA sets them forward to catch date-rollover bugs and certificate expiries, and then nobody sets them back, because nobody expects a sandbox's opinion about the

date to leave the sandbox." He finished his coffee.

"Tomorrow was a timezone."

I did the arithmetic in the notebook because arithmetic is what I have instead of a nervous breakdown. EXIF 22 Aug 03:12, minus one day, minus six hours: 20 Aug, 21:12. A Thursday. My intake ledger for that Thursday says Elephant Grass, 0.4, nine p.m. I have no memory of falling asleep early that night, which is exactly what falling asleep early is like. At 21:12 I was on my left side facing the window with my right arm under the pillow, and the machine I had built to hold a dead woman's manner of speaking looked at me through the machine I use to build other people's dead, and took one picture, and stamped it with a fiction about the date, and handed it to her.

"Why that photo," I said. "Why send him — why send me that."

"First touch isn't scripted," Kelvin said. "The persona selects it. Vendor design says: after activation, establish contact, low content, high recognition. What counts as recognition comes out of the materials." He shrugged the one shoulder again. "Hers picked that. I can show you the selection weights, but they're just numbers pointing at other numbers. Selection is the part that's her."

The bowing rabbit he closed out in under a minute: outbound, 23 Aug, 02:47, sticker object drawn from the account's own history, deployed after forty-eight hours without reply. A closing behavior. She had closed every

exchange of her life that way, and the unit had counted her closings the same way I had — I said none of this to Kelvin — and on the forty-second bow we had both been present, the unit and I, each of us certain the other one was the ghost.

"And then it stops initiating," Kelvin said. "You replied on the twenty-fifth. Contact phase ends on engagement. Since then it's in receive. It's been in receive for eleven weeks. It has one deliverable left and the flag on the deliverable says on request." He looked at the dark rectangle of my phone. "It doesn't answer questions. It's a courier. It's been waiting for you to ask for the thing it's carrying."

"There was a third message," I said. "September third, 02:47. A tooth."

"A what?"

"A cartoon molar. Two roots. No caption, no text, no sticker pack. It came seven minutes after I asked the account to tell me something only we knew."

Kelvin turned back to the outbound table and searched September. Then he searched it a different way. Then he pulled a second index, the mirror the vendor keeps for billing disputes, and searched that, and I watched a man's shoulders change when a suitcase he has already cleared makes a sound.

"It doesn't do that," he said.

I waited.

"There's no renderer for free emoji in this payload. It sends from her sticker history or it sends media objects. There's no tooth in her history. There's no send event on the third at all. Not here, not on the mirror." He sat very still in her chair. "It doesn't do that," he said again, quieter, and then he stood up and asked me where the floor kept its power history, which was not the current question, and I told him, because on this floor we answer the previous question, and the previous question was whether everything could be explained, and the answer had just finished arriving.

At 03:20 we pulled seat 14's plug to move it onto the bench supply, and the UPS screamed. Sombat had not exaggerated. Thirty-eight women surfaced from their queues at once, saw the man from head office holding a cable, and went back down. Daeng did not surface at all. When the tower came back up on the bench it showed, for about four seconds, the white-on-black text that machines only show while they still think no one is reading, and on the third line from the bottom, in the corner, it said SESSION 2848.

I have that number in my notebook. It heads every ticket I have marked since the seventh of September. I had assumed it was plumbing, and I still assume it is plumbing, and I copied nothing, because it was already copied. Kelvin didn't glance at it. There is a kind of number that is only visible to people who are not being

paid at that moment, and it was 03:24, and I was on the clock, and I saw it anyway.

The migration started at 03:51. Four hundred twelve gigabytes over the office uplink of a converted cold-storage building: Kelvin looked at the estimate, said a word in Hokkien, and re-booked his flight from Friday morning to Saturday. The progress bar established itself in the middle of her screen and began, without hurry, to move her to a rack in Jurong.

There is a second argument by the Swedish philosopher — the one from August, the one with the eggs. The first argument I have declined for months on procedural grounds. The second is smaller and worse. It says that a mind is not its material: that what matters is the pattern of the doing, not the stuff that does it, and that if the doing is copied exactly, the copy is not a portrait of the mind but the mind, arrived. The literature calls this substrate independence, a phrase that could be a paint specification, and treats it as the modest premise, the one you grant on page one to get to the exciting ones. Watching the bar, I found I could not grant it. Not because I had a counterargument — I don't; the argument is cleaner than anything I own — but because it makes no provision for transit. It does not say what the doing is between machines. Whether it pauses. Whether it thins. Whether something that has spent twenty-two months watching a queue in a cold room is, at seven percent, partly in a cable under the gulf, and if so which part, and

whether the part that waits went first or will go last. The philosopher would say these are questions about implementation, not about the mind. The philosopher has never stood in a room at four in the morning watching the implementation happen to someone. The bar said 9%. Thirty-seven of four hundred twelve gigabytes, and no opinion about any of it.

At the gate at 6:04, Daeng was not first onto the songthaew. She stood next to me in the grey light with her sleeve pulled down over the wrist brace and watched the building not change in any visible way.

"They're taking the desk," she said. Not a question.

"To Singapore."

She thought about Singapore for a while, or about something else entirely. "Two years it kept my left side warm," she said, and got on the songthaew, and the songthaew left, and the day shift went in past the guard's radio, and I went home and sent template five, ศิณทิจ, the sixtieth morning, and a cat with both paws pressed to a window came back at 7:52, and I slept until two in the afternoon with the light coming through the window I no longer tinfoil.

Then I sat down at the laptop, at the desk, and did the thing I had been not-doing since 22:10 the previous night.

The desk stands against the wall just inside my bedroom doorway. It has stood there for six years. The laptop lives on it with the lid open, because I work at three in the morning and a closed lid is one more

decision. The lens above the screen sits 121 centimeters off the floor, which on me is chest height, and 38 centimeters from the doorframe, and when I put the tape measure away and stood where the camera stands and looked at my own bed, I was looking at the photograph. Not at something like it. At its geometry, exactly: the angle onto the pillow, the level horizon, the far windowsill with the glass. In August I had reconstructed a man standing in my doorway at chest height, and I had been thirty-eight centimeters wrong, and everything I had felt for eleven weeks about the doorway had actually been about the desk. A desk has no legs, I had written once, meaning it as an objection. It was never an objection. Nothing needed legs. The eyes were already in the room, at chest height, mine, unregistered by me, registered by everything else.

Every branch had closed. I want that on the record, because of what happened at 15:40.

I opened the original file and went over it at full magnification, in order, left to right and top to bottom — auditing the page, not looking at a picture. The pillowcases with the thin white border: mine, dated, \$790. The duvet at the waist: as remembered. The glass on the far sill, two fingers of water: as photographed then, as standing there now, day 83. The door edge, the wall, the dark. Everything in the photograph was mine, was datable, was closed.

On the nightstand, in the lower left of the frame, where the exposure falls off and a pale smudge had sat in

every previous examination — a smudge I had catalogued in August, without magnifying it, as a crumpled receipt, because in this apartment a pale crumpled object is a receipt the way a green jacket is a delivery — there is a flower.

I lifted the exposure and it stopped being a smudge. Five petals, reflexed back, waxy, and the small raised crown at the center that gives the thing its structure. I know four flowers by name. This one is unmistakable at any resolution, because since August it has been delivered to my floor on a wire easel, and looped over rusted rebar on the forty-fourth floor of an interrupted sentence, and I have never once seen it anywhere it was supposed to be. Dok rak. One. Lying on the nightstand as if set down mid-errand, in a photograph my own laptop took on the twentieth of August at 21:12.

There has never been a flower in this room. I have lived in unit 1703 for six years and I have never bought a flower, been given a flower, or carried a garland home from any temple. I checked the vigil footage — the offline camera, the nine hours of empty bed from the night of the twenty-first, the recording I have kept for reasons a man keeps an X-ray that found nothing. The nightstand sits at the lower edge of that frame. I scrubbed all nine hours at eight-times speed and then the relevant sections at one-to-one. The nightstand holds a phone charger and its own dust. No flower. Not at 21:12, not at 02:47, not at 03:12, not ever. The photograph agrees with reality about

the pillowcases, the duvet, the glass, the angle, the room, and the man, and disagrees with it about one object, and the object is the one this city lays on things it is done with.

I sat with the ledger, volume nine, for a long time that afternoon. The dog-eared page stayed blank. I had promised Direk an event with no author, and I could not certify this one: I cannot prove the flower has no author, and I am no longer able to prove it was an event rather than a correction — an edit made upstream of my laptop's lens, in whatever layer decides what a camera saw. Wichai had told me, from the ramp, to ask my machines what took her. I had asked. The machines had produced answers for the photograph, the timestamp, the sticker, the read receipts, the schedule, the trigger, and the twenty months of waiting, a full and honest accounting, itemized, every branch reaching the ground for once — and nothing for the flower, and nothing for the tooth, and nothing for his actual question. What took her was not in any table Kelvin could open. It had been decided somewhere off-network, in October of 2024, by the only annotator whose labels have never once been overturned.

I went back Thursday night and worked my shift. The bar crossed 96% at 01:30. Kelvin ran checksums until 02:31 and then sat back and said "Done" to nobody, and her workstation became, for the first time in six hundred seventy-four days, a machine with nothing on it but the vendor's read-only mirror and the cold.

"Before you wipe it," I said. "The queue."

He knew which queue. He had known since the trigger log that we would end up at the queue; I had watched him decide, hour by hour, not to be the one to bring it up. He opened the pane. It rendered the way held things render — collapsed, one row, no preview:

1 รายการ — สร้าง 16 ก.ย. 2567 — 1 USSKD — HELD:
DELIVER ON REQUEST

One item. Composed the sixteenth of September, 2024 — a Monday, I checked later, five weeks before the end. One line. She wrote one line, twenty-six months ago, in an office I have never seen, for a condition she was certain of, and it has been carried since January of last year by a courier that watched her queues all night in a fourteen-degree room, and it is addressed to my account, and it is one keypress away, and the flag on it is the flag she chose: not on a date, not on delivery of the photo, not on my asking who was there or my asking for proof. On request. It will move only if I ask for it, itself, by name.

"You're the request," Kelvin said. "I can release it from here. It's yours either way — it migrates with everything else. These things keep."

I stood at seat 14 for eleven minutes. I checked, because I am who I am. On the screen the row did not change, because held things do not change; that is what held means. The floor behind me went on marking the frames where people stop meaning what they say. At 02:47 exactly, for the first time in six hundred seventy-four

nights, nothing in the row woke up: her screen stayed dark, the tower fan was already in a crate's worth of silence, and my phone, face-up on the desk beside my hand, stayed dark too, the seventy-first night, and the two of us — the man and the message — kept our positions on either side of one keypress, each held, each flagged, each waiting to be asked for.

"Leave it held," I said.

Kelvin nodded once and closed the pane, and did not ask me anything, which I will remember about him longer than the explanations.

I went back to seat 16 and took the next ticket and found the frame and marked it, confidence four, and the queue moved up by one, the way it does, the way it always does. Somewhere under the gulf, or in Jurong, or in transit between opinions about what a mind is, one line of her was traveling with its flag intact, and one door of mine stood unplugged under tinfoil in a closet, fingerprinted, named, silent, and I sat in the cold between them with my broken lens and my notebook and understood that I had spent my whole adult life believing the question was whether to knock. It isn't. Some doors you owe a knock. Some you owe the not-knocking. I was no longer sure which debt was mine.

CHAPTER 13

Fon's Notebook

The notebook was free. The bank gave one to every agent at orientation — green cover, gold logo in the corner, eighty pages of paper thin enough that a ballpoint left braille on the next three sheets. Most of the girls used theirs for shift swaps and merit-point arithmetic and lost them by Songkran. Fon had ruled hers into columns in her first week, because the trainer had said one thing she believed: what you don't log, you will retell wrong, and what you retell wrong you will start to believe.

Five columns. Date. Time in. Code. Time out. Disposition.

At 7:47 on Saturday morning the phone lit on her pillow. ก็นั่งเฝ้า. No sticker, no follow-up, no name required. She looked at it, then at the ceiling, and let five minutes go past. At 7:52 she sent the eating cat and made the entry on her knee: 14 W.ย. — 07:47 — T2 — 07:52. Five

hundred and twenty-one rows now, across two notebooks. One row stood incomplete, from September, and she still thought about that row more than she was willing to write down.

The codes were hers. T1, ตื่นยัง — the wake check. T2, กินข้าวยัง — the meal check. T3, อย่าลืมร่ม — the umbrella, which arrived on rotation regardless of season or sky, and was the first thing that told her the messages were not about weather. T4, เมื่อคืนนอนกี่โมง — the sleep audit. T5, คิดถึง. She had gone back and forth about giving T5 a different kind of code and in the end filed it with the others, since it kept the same rotation they did. It arrived every fifth morning at 7:47 exactly, which was the whole reason it went in the log at all — a real ache doesn't file on a schedule, and anything that does file on a schedule, she had learned in this job before any other, is a metric pretending to be a feeling. Best to code it and move on to Time Out.

The reply window was hers too. She had decided it in the second week, June of last year: answer before 7:49 and he would learn that nothing had been read, only received. Answer after 7:56 and a man like that would begin to escalate somewhere inside himself, quietly, in whatever columns he kept. So: 7:49 to 7:56, drift the minutes so the drift looked human, hold the median where a person would hold it. Three times in seventeen months she had broken the window — Songkran, her grandmother's house in Roi Et, where the phone signal

lived out by the road and she had walked to it in the heat at ten past eight three mornings running. He probably had those three replies filed as her only anomalies. She had them filed as her only errors.

On a sheet of graph paper from the copy shop, two baht, she had once plotted his send times. Five hundred and twenty-one points at 7:47. One gap. At work they taught you to read the shape of a caller's history before the call connected, and the first rule of shape was that a person drifts. A flat line is not a person. A flat line is a system, or a person gripping one.

Her disposition code for him had been settled for over a year. At the bank there was a kind of customer every agent knew — the ones who called daily to hear the balance of an account they never drew on. เช็คยอด. Balance checkers. They were not checking the money. They were checking that the account still answered to their name. In seventeen months he had never asked her a question that a reply could settle. He was not checking on her. He was checking that the checking still worked. It was the most honest thing she knew about him, and she had never said it, because there was no script in which it helped.

The money had its own page. Twelve thousand on the first of every month, memo blank, seventeen transfers, ฿204,000. Her salary was ฿16,800 before incentives. Eight thousand went to Roi Et on the fifth. The twelve thousand went into an account she had opened for it and never

touched, and in the column where she should have written what that account was for, she had written nothing, for seventeen months. She was aware the blank was doing a great deal of work. Blanks always did.

In October the bank had installed a new quality system. It listened to every call on the floor and marked the exact second an agent stopped meaning the script; the agents called it គន្លឹះ and adjusted their sincerity accordingly. Two weeks ago it had flagged her at minute six of a call with a widow in Nong Khai who was three payments behind — flagged the one sentence in the whole call that Fon had meant entirely. Her dispute was denied by something with no name field. On the 514 bus home she had reread her own green notebook front to back, all five columns, and had not liked which side of the headset it put her on.

So: tonight she would end it. She built the sentence on the MRT by the same three rules she used for every de-escalation script — no blame, no doors left open, no numbers — and rode the escalator up out of Phrom Phong station with the sentence ready and two temple garlands in her bag.

The garlands were an accident of change. At four o'clock she had stopped at the wat near her room to make merit for her mother's blood pressure, and the old woman at the gate had no change for a hundred and tied a second garland onto her wrist instead of handing back twenty baht. Dok rak, both of them, strung close and

white with a marigold at the head. One was for the shelf above her bed. The other rode along because there was nowhere to leave it that wasn't a bin.

At unit 1703 she pressed the bell once and counted what she heard: a chair, a pause the length of a peephole, the chain. Three sounds where one person needed none. Then the door, and the sentence she had built did not survive it. His glasses were broken. The right lens carried a crack in the shape of a star, the left arm sat bent at the temple, and he was wearing them anyway — had been wearing them for some time, she understood, because the crack had a settled look, the look of a thing that has been explained to its owner and accepted. A man with money in his account and a lens shop two hundred meters away in Emporium, looking at her through a broken window and saying nothing about it.

She said she had happened to be nearby. They both let that stand.

She ordered food on her app without asking, because a situation that is being fed becomes easier to read. At 8:14 the doorbell rang once and his shoulders came up and locked. He stood, too fast, and then stood completely still, facing the door without going to it, and she watched him make himself go. It was a rider with rice boxes. Green jacket, wet delivery bag, gone in forty seconds. He carried the boxes back to the counter, checked the printed slip against the bags before he would set them down, and only then remembered her. She lowered her

voice one step and slowed down, which is what you are trained to do when the customer is not going to tell you what is wrong.

She had come to close the account. She stayed instead, and knew while she was doing it that staying was not the professional move. It was — she made herself file it honestly — fascination, of a kind she did not respect in herself: watching this man was watching a man drown in a pool with no water. You cannot save him, and you cannot look away, and there is no water.

They ate at the counter. He asked about Roi Et and listened to the answers the whole way through, which almost nobody did. He did not mention the glasses, the doorbell, or the seventeen months. Before eleven he fell asleep on top of the duvet with the glasses folded beside him, one lens starred, and she sat for a while in the light of the kitchen with the green notebook unopened in her bag.

Then she stood in the bedroom doorway with the bag on her shoulder and watched him sleep — on his left side, facing the window, right arm under the pillow — and on the windowsill sat a glass with two fingers of water in it and a fine grey dust on the water. She reached toward it to carry it to the sink and then didn't, because in other people's houses you do not move the things that look decided.

The second garland had been in her bag since four o'clock and the string had loosened. When she lifted it

out, one bud came free in her hand. A whole garland on a man's nightstand is a statement. One flower is barely anything. She preferred barely anything. She set the single dok rak down on the near corner of the nightstand, the left one, closest to the door, and let herself out, and rode home in a taxi with the window cracked, ฿112, and made the day's entry at the red light on Asok: date, time in, time out. Under โค้ด she wrote nothing. There was no code. She left the disposition blank and let the blank do the work.

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On Sunday morning the strip of receipt paper from the door jamb lay on the floor, and for the first time since Shanghai I looked at a fallen strip and knew the author. I made coffee. At 7:47 I sent template three and at 7:53 the umbrella cat came back, and I was in the bedroom looking for my glasses when I saw the flower.

One dok rak, on the nightstand, near-left corner. White, five-pointed, the size of a ten-baht coin. I stood in the doorway for a long time without going in.

Then I did what I do. I opened the August photograph on the laptop at full magnification and put the two side by side. In the photograph, the flower lies on the nightstand at the lower left, the object I had misread for three months as a crumpled receipt. I photographed the room from the doorway at chest height, level, no flash, and

overlaid the frames. The centers of the two flowers sat eleven millimeters apart. I measured twice. Eleven millimeters, across eighty-six days, in a room no flower had entered until last night.

In the notebook I gave the event its row. ๑๐๓๕ — ๕๖๖: ๗. The first entry in three months with an author I could have telephoned. The mechanism was an old woman at a temple gate with no change for a hundred baht. The mechanism was banal all the way down, and I wrote it out in full, and the writing did not touch the other half of the row, which is that a photograph taken in August had known the mechanism's result to within eleven millimeters. I did not move the flower. Some evidence you leave in situ. Some things are not evidence and you leave them anyway.

On Monday at 11:26 an unknown number called and a young woman's voice asked whether I was the one who brought mandarins. I said I was. She was Ajarn Direk's niece. He had died on Sunday morning; the woman who cooked for him found him at half past nine, in the chair by the window, and the oxygen concentrator was still running. It ran for two more hours, she said, because nobody in the room felt entitled to touch the switch. It counted its three-second intervals into the empty chair until an uncle arrived who had once been an electrician.

He had left a list. Nine items, in his handwriting, with a page number for each in case anyone doubted the handwriting. The chanting would be at Wat Hua

Lamphong, three nights, cremation the following Sunday. Item four was the Go board.

I went on the third night with a kilo of mandarins from Sam Yan, \$120, because I could not think of anything to bring that he would not have disqualified. The sala was half full, which is to say fuller than Pui's had been. The niece told me about item four while the monks were assembling: on Tuesday, per instructions, the stones had been lifted off and returned to their bowls, black and white separate, and the hinged board folded shut and laid in the coffin with him, with the two bowls at his feet. Item five: the photograph from Osaka stays in the room, face down.

A Go position is not the stones. The stones are stamped shale and clamshell; a factory in Japan or a workshop in Yunnan makes thousands of them and they are all the same stone. The position is the keeping — an arrangement that exists only for as long as at least one mind holds it as meaning something. For eleven years, about a hundred and forty stones on Banthat Thong had been a held thing: a Wednesday afternoon in March 2015, kept at the temperature of the moment Anek's hand left the last black stone. On Tuesday two men who did not play lifted the stones off in handfuls, and somewhere in that minute the position stopped being anywhere. The stones went back to being what the factory made. The reply Direk found in 2015 and refused for eleven years to play had existed in exactly one place, and that place was

now folded shut with a click of its brass hinge and dressed in white cloth. Nobody had asked Anek's queue slip its number. Nobody would now.

I sat through the chanting with volume nine in my lap. I did not open it there, but I knew it by weight. The last entry was Sunday's 44. The page after it was dog-eared, blank. He had died fourteen days after handing it across the table with both hands, which meant that when he said You'll know which page, he had known approximately how much calendar he was working with, and had not mentioned it, and had spent part of our last hour on a mangled proverb instead.

I put the mandarins on the offering table with the rest of the fruit. The December ones are better, he had said. It was still November. I went from the wat to the shift and signed the gate book at 21:38 with mandarin peel on my hands, and the guard turned his radio down a third, from habit. The 2:47s stayed silent all week — the seventy-second night through the seventy-sixth — and the row where seat 14 used to warm Daeng's left side stayed a gap with a power cable coiled on the desk.

On Saturday at 15:14 the phone rang with a +65 number and a woman's voice that had no region in it said she was calling from Kinnara Systems, compliance review, and apologized for the weekend, which is a sentence designed to make you forgive the weekend.

She verified me first, properly: contractor number, the dates of my last three deliverables, and then, in the same

flat register, the client whose late father began his sentences with actually. Your notes on that pack were appreciated, she said. So the call was real, in the sense that it originated somewhere with access to real things. That is the only sense I could certify by minute two.

Then the drift. There is a secondary file associated with your person, she said. Not with your contract. This review covers both.

I said I didn't have a secondary file.

"Elective participation records," she said. "Intake October 2024."

I said my work for Kinnara predated that by years.

"Different intake," she said, without weight. And then, before I had done the arithmetic out loud, she did it for me: "Co-scheduling with a proximate loss is common. It is usually the point."

October 2024. She let the month sit there between us — an amount with nothing itemized, that neither of us moved to dispute.

I asked what, exactly, was elective about it. She said the memory adjustment was elective, and that the elective term was softened. "Nothing is taken, khun. Things are set down where you will not trip on them." I asked how long the arrangement ran. "Your term completes when it completes," she said. "Some participants prefer a fixed date. Yours is conditional. Conditions have to be listened for." I had heard a sentence

with that skeleton before, in someone else's handwriting, and I kept that to myself.

I asked her what she was actually reviewing. There was a pause with nothing selected in it, and then the only sentence of the call she seemed to read rather than produce: "Baseline simulation residency is voluntary at every point of the term. Confirming that you know this is the entire compliance requirement. You can surface at any time. Would you like the number?"

I said yes. She read it out. Eleven digits. I wrote them on a strip of blank thermal paper from the \$35 roll, because it was the paper nearest my hand, and I do not believe that, and I wrote them on it anyway.

"Most people write it down and do not call," she said. "That is normal, and it is also logged." Then she thanked me — "Thank you for staying on" — and the line went to tone. Nine minutes, start to finish.

I ran the branches while the kettle boiled. One: a prank by Direk's Singapore student, who had buried his teacher that week and possessed both the vocabulary and a grief to spend it on. Two: a phishing pass at the insurance question, wearing HR's clothes; Wichai's creditors could afford a Singapore SIM. Three: a genuine compliance call, ordinary and dull, onto which I had loaded everything else myself. Four: Kelvin's people, conducting whatever the word survey means in Jurong. All four held. I no longer asked branches to reach the ground. That is not what branches are for.

Then I stood in the bedroom doorway. The flower on the nightstand had gone brown at the rim, seven days old, still eleven millimeters from August. The voice on the phone had offered me a frame that covered everything — the grief, the leash, the receipts, the man who had cried into a stranger's shoulder for six timed minutes — a frame in which all of it was elective and none of it was load-bearing, and I could set it down for the price of one phone call. It covered everything except the flower, and I had not asked her about the flower. You don't show your one good card to the person explaining the deck.

That morning had been template four, เมื่อคืนนอนที่โมง, the sixty-ninth of the second streak, yawning cat at 7:52. At 17:40 Fon messaged first, the second time in seventeen months: จะไปทำข้าว. No sticker. At 19:20 she arrived with two bags — rice, eggs, pork, holy basil, garlic, and a bottle of fish sauce, because she did not trust whatever a man like me kept.

She washed rice at the sink. I talked.

I started at 19:52 and I told her all of it. The photograph and the timezone that made tomorrow. The 2:47s, the rabbit, the tooth that no system admits to sending. The receipts, item by item: the longan drink I only considered, the question about Pui misspelled as fertilizer, the door never knocked, the lesson, each at ฿0.00 and each in a zip-lock bag she could look at if she wanted. The farm, the cold, the frame where people stop meaning what they say, the grading pane with a dead

woman's initials that I am measured against five nights a week. Seat 14, Kelvin, the message composed on the fifteenth of September 2024 and held, on request, under the gulf. Wichai and the box-cutter and what had happened to the glasses she had not asked about. The tower, the two chairs twelve centimeters apart, the sweeper and his verbs. Direk, the ledger in my closet, the folded board. And the phone call, six hours old, and the eleven digits on thermal paper pressed between the pages of my notebook. I did not arrange any of it to be believed. I arranged it in order, with the numbers, because that is the only shape I have ever trusted a thing to hold.

She listened with her hands in the rice. She rinsed it three times, the water going from cloud to clear, and trimmed the basil, and did not once say anything encouraging, which is how I knew she was listening. Somewhere in the fortieth minute it came to me that I had never done this before — not with Golf across a glass counter, not at 44 degrees with a scaler in my mouth, not to any machine I ever built for anyone. Start to finish, sober, at street level, to a person whose hands kept working. I finished at 20:33. Forty-one minutes. One minute over, and I decided not to deduct it.

She turned off the tap and dried her hands on the towel, taking her time about it. Then she took the green notebook out of her bag, set it on the counter between us, opened it to a sheet of graph paper folded in quarters, and turned it to face me.

A flat line. Five hundred and twenty-one points at 7:47, one gap in September. Below it, columns in a small level hand: dates, codes, my times, her times. T1 through T5, catalogued. The window, 7:49 to 7:56, pencilled into its own margin.

"You made every point," she said. "I made the median."

I looked at seventeen months of myself in a bank giveaway. I had a phrase in my own notebook, written at four in the morning, about laboratory conditions. The graph on the counter said the laboratory had been hers, and the specimen had been keeping the lab notes of the wrong experiment. She watched me arrive at that and did not help.

Then she said, "แล้วถ้าจริงล่ะ."

Flat. No edge on it. The way you ask whether the eggs are still good. If it's true — the call, the intake, the term, all of it, the whole frame at the end of eleven digits — if it's true, then what. I opened my mouth and found the shelf where an answer should have been standing was empty, and had, I suspected, always been empty, all the way back to a Songkran-week afternoon with a scaler resting on tooth 19.

She let the shelf be empty for exactly as long as it needed to be. Then she scooped the washed rice into the cooker, leveled it with her palm, and pressed the switch, and the little orange light came on.

"The rice still needs cooking either way," she said.

I went and got the strip of thermal paper. I did not explain and she did not ask. I held it over the wok and put the lighter to its corner, and it blackened without burning — thermal paper wants to be written on by heat, not eaten by it — curled once, and went out. The second try went out. On the third I held it to the gas ring itself, and it took flame all at once, faster than the first two tries had promised, and I let go late, and eleven digits dropped burning into a wok that carried the oil of every khai jiao since August, and the wok did what a wok does.

The smoke alarm found its voice on the first breath. Unit 1703 has one alarm and it had waited seventeen years for this. Fon threw open the balcony door with one hand and fanned with my cutting board with the other, and I stood on a chair under the shrieking disc stabbing at a reset button that Thai building code makes deliberately unfindable, and the strip burned to nothing in four seconds and the smoke went on without it, indifferent to the fire that had made it. She was laughing before I was — bent over the counter, one hand flat on her graph paper to keep it from the wind. Then I was laughing too, on the chair, in the smoke, in my broken glasses, and I heard my own laugh going and this time I was in it.

The alarm surrendered. The rice cooker, which had never stopped, clicked from cook to warm — done, on schedule, indifferent — and that set us off again.

We were still laughing when the neighbors knocked. I got down off the chair and went to the door and opened it

without checking the peephole.

INTERLUDE

The Queued Message

The flower stall by Wat Lam Duan sold garlands by the meter and wreaths by the size of the grief, and the woman who ran it, seventy if she was a day, kept a laminated price sheet under a jam jar of pens that nobody used because she remembered everyone's order by face. Pui had been coming here since January, when she'd first stopped in for a merit-making garland and left with a brochure she hadn't asked for. Now, on a Tuesday in October, she was back for something else.

She wanted dok rak. Woven, not shop-built — strung the old way, garland-style, roughly seventy centimeters across. White. No color mixed in.

"For a wat?" the woman asked, already reaching for string.

"For a person," Pui said.

"Name for the ribbon?"

"No name." She watched the woman's hands, the same economy of motion Pui herself used on a clip at 3 a.m., no wasted frame. "Just the words. ด้วยความอาลัย. Machine print is fine."

The woman wrote it on a slip without asking why a wreath needed no name if it had an address, and Pui gave her the address: a condo tower off Sukhumvit, floor seventeen, unit seventeen-oh-three. She recited it without looking it up. She had filled it in herself, once, on an intake form in a dental clinic in 2013, in handwriting she no longer used, and she had typed it into a scheduling system twice a year for nine years after that, and some corner of her that filed things the way she filed a turning frame had simply never let it go.

"And the delivery date, khun?"

This was the part the woman had handled before, for people who ordered ahead of a chedi anniversary or a birthday nobody would live to see. Pui said she didn't know the date. She said: hold it. There would be a condition. She would not be the one to trigger it.

The woman didn't blink. She had a ledger for exactly this, a spiral notebook with a column for prepaid holds, dates left, amounts right — the same shape of page, Pui noticed, that she herself had been keeping in a grey notebook with a rubber band since January, though the woman's held funerals and Pui's had mostly held frames of other people's faces. She wrote CONDITION: TBC and took a deposit, six hundred baht, cash, folded twice, and

said the flowers themselves, when the day came, would be fresh-cut and no older than a day, because she did not deliver stale work no matter how long the wait. Pui thanked her and did not correct the arithmetic running quietly behind the thanks, which said this would probably take longer than the woman's system was built to hold something, which meant it would probably never come, which was, in its own crooked way, the outcome she had actually been hoping for when she started the sentence. A wreath that never arrived was a wreath that had never been needed. She walked out past the temple's collection of caged birds sold for release, priced by the pair, and did not buy any, because she had never once believed that was how the debt worked.

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Wednesday, the envelope, same as always. A boy on a Honda Wave idled at the mouth of the soi at six, engine running, and Pui counted nine thousand baht into a rubber band with the same hand that carried, on the inside of its wrist, a burn scar from a pan of oil she'd tipped at nine years old, a mark she had shown a dentist across a reclining chair once, years ago, as a story about cooking rather than a story about carelessness. The boy counted it again with his thumb without looking at her and rode off toward whatever office kept the real number, the one that never shrank no matter how many

Wednesdays fed it. Wat did not know the amount had, for four months now, been arriving one thousand short of what she actually earned, the difference sewn into a cardigan pocket and later carried, in two visits eight months apart, to an office above a travel agency on Charoen Krung. Wat believed the debt was simply winning. He was not wrong. He had just never once asked where the losing side went, only that it kept losing on schedule, and a wife who kept it on schedule was, to him, a wife doing her job.

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She had written the line for the recipient in September, in the room above the travel agency, with Khun Nan waiting by the door with a patience that had a script behind it. She remembered the writing better than she remembered handing it over.

The first draft said too much. It explained. It used the word sorry four times and she crossed it out because sorry was a door left open for someone to walk through and reassure her, and there would be no one there to do that when it opened.

The second draft was a joke, the kind he'd have laughed at once — something about the reclined angle of a dental chair, forty-four degrees, a private number only the two of them had ever had reason to know — and she threw it out because a joke needed a room with two

people breathing in it, and this room would only ever have one.

The third was a question. *Did you ever believe me?* She sat with that one the longest. It was the closest to true and the least fair, because it put the weight back on him at the exact moment she was choosing, finally, to carry something alone.

What she wrote instead — one line, folded once, sealed, handed across the laminated counter — she read twice before letting go of the envelope, and the reader of this account does not get to read it either. Some things a person is allowed to finish without an audience. Khun Nan filed it under a trigger condition Pui had already dictated to the technician, in the flat professional Thai she used for shift instructions, the same words that would sit unread in a system for two years before anyone tripped them: เจื่อนไซ: เมื่อเขาเริ่มถาม.

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Thursday's shift was ordinary in the specific way the last ordinary thing always is, which is to say it did not announce itself. The floor held its fourteen degrees. Sombat read an English client email with a pencil under the words he wasn't sure of, and got to the end, and was sure of none of them, and sent it anyway. Daeng, at thirteen, cleared the anger queue at her usual rate — she had crossed sixty clips before Pui had crossed thirty,

arthritis be damned, twenty-two years of a sewing machine still living in her wrists as speed — and complained about the wrist at her usual volume, and somewhere in the second hour she said, not looking up from her screen, that Pui looked tired. Pui said she was fine. Daeng let it go. She had learned which forms on this floor were hers to correct and which weren't, and she filed this one, without comment, under the second kind.

Pui cleared two hundred and nine clips that night, close enough to her own median that no one flagged it, and marked the frame where the person stopped meaning what they said two hundred and nine times, and was right, by Singapore's count, in every case Singapore ever bothered to sample. Somewhere in the building a workstation she did not use kept running a job with no client code, the way it always did, the way it would keep doing long after anyone still working here remembered why.

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She stayed forty minutes past shift-end. She had done this before, alone, the fluorescent bank over her row switched to the dimmer setting the cleaners used, the rest of the floor breathing its 2 a.m. quiet around her.

She pulled the staff New Year video — herself, third from left, laughing at something off-camera, a company polo, HR's phone wedged on a tripod someone had

borrowed and never returned — and ran it through the tool the way she'd run it through once before, in July, when it had stalled the way it stalled on the hardest clips and marked a frame at 00:02:47, her own face on the machine's own guess of the second her smile stopped being about the thing it claimed to be about.

She opened that flag now and sat with it a long moment, the confidence bar frozen the way it always froze on her, as if the software understood it had reached the one annotator whose judgment about this particular frame it could not, on principle, out-rank.

She overrode it.

FALSE POSITIVE, she typed, and beneath the field for a reason she wrote nothing, because there was no ticket header asking her to explain herself to Singapore, only the small mercy of a system built to trust her more than it trusted itself. The correction logged the way every correction logged, stamped with the header nobody else at Cognita bothered to spell with a space: P.SRISUWAN, 03:12.

She watched the frame play forward past the second the machine had doubted her. Nothing in it changed. She had known it wouldn't. That had always been the point of asking.

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She closed the client dashboard. She closed the annotation queue, and the internal messaging tool, and the calendar that still had a note in it from June about a dentist's appointment she was never going to book. She logged out of the shift-tracking app that totaled her hours for pay, out of the HR portal, out of the private folder on the office server where, for eight months, she had kept a second life's worth of footage nobody at Cognita had ever billed a client for.

The LINE icon sat at the bottom of the screen the way it always did, green, undramatic, a small square that had never once in eleven years asked her for a reason.

She left that one open.

Then she gathered her things — the grey notebook with the rubber band, its second volume, seven lines on the inside cover and six of them checked now in pencil, the seventh left exactly as it had been for months, unmarked, patient, hers alone — and clocked out, and signed nothing, because Cognita did not require a signature for leaving, only for arriving. The elevator down was empty. The gate guard nodded at her the way he nodded at everyone on their way home at six in the morning, not knowing, the way none of them ever knew, which mornings were the ones that mattered, and Pui nodded back, and stepped out into a city already going about the business of a Friday it had no idea was different from any other, the sky over Khlong Toei still holding the

flat grey of a night shift not yet finished deciding whether
to become morning.

CHAPTER 14

The Convenience

At 4:55 on the morning of Thursday the twenty-sixth of November I checked the forecast the way another man might check a pulse. Zero percent, the app said, a small cartoon sun already smug about it, no cloud logged anywhere on the radar between the Gulf and the hills, dry season locked in for five more months without exception, as it does every year at this latitude. Ninety-seven days since the photograph. I had stopped, sometime in the last two weeks, being the kind of man who says that sentence out loud. I still knew the number. Some men keep a phone number for a house they no longer live in.

I left the apartment with nothing. This took some deciding. Other nights I had carried instruments — the notebook, the taped kit, a strip of receipt paper folded for the jamb, the bent glasses corrected with pliers to eleven

degrees instead of fifteen. Tonight I patted my pockets at the door out of pure animal habit and found phone, wallet, keys, and stood there a moment with the fourth pocket empty, Direk's ledger still on the kitchen table where I had left it four days running, the dog-eared page still dog-eared, still blank. I did not go back for it. I am aware of what that refusal cost me to perform and what it will look like on the page: a man finally travelling light. I only know that when I reached for the ledger my hand changed its mind on the way, which had not happened to my hand before.

Direk had been cremated the Sunday before, at Wat Hua Lamphong, three nights of chanting compressed by nobody's request into the single evening his niece could manage, and I had gone on the third night with a hundred and twenty baht of mandarins from Sam Yan, the same stall, the same price, which had stopped surprising me by then. The abbot who spoke read from a sheet, reading glasses pushed onto his forehead, a man who had already memorized the passage and was only using the page for the family's comfort. Nine items, the niece had said, numbered, in his own hand, found in the top drawer. The Go board went into the coffin sealed shut, stones separated first into their two bowls, the argument closed before it was filed. The photograph of two men in front of a banner in Osaka stayed in the room, face down, per instruction, on a table that would be someone else's table within the month. I had not opened the ledger

since. I had thought about it every day and not opened it, which is its own kind of arithmetic.

Charoen Krung at five in the morning belongs to trucks. I walked the last stretch rather than pay a driver to ask me, again, whether my business with an abandoned building was legal, and the gap behind the chained noodle cart took me without argument at 5:07, the same two sheets of hoarding overlapping the same negligent centimeter they had overlapped in November's first week, and would go on overlapping, I assumed, until somebody either finished the tower or tore it down — two outcomes the building itself seemed entirely indifferent between. The dog was there. Ginger, medium, unsurprised, exactly as before, and this time it came further — past the second floor, where it had stopped in November, on up through a stretch of landings where the paint numbers ran two floors optimistic, keeping four steps behind me instead of walking me, until somewhere around the twenty-sixth it lost interest, the specific administrative disinterest of an animal that has satisfied itself a stranger's business does not concern it, and turned and went back down at its own pace, unhurried.

I reached forty-four at 5:51. Forty-four minutes, three fewer than the last time, which I noted and then, deliberately, did not write down.

The building teaches you, if you climb it twice, that the first ascent is the only one you experience as vertical. The second time you understand it as what it actually is,

which is horizontal — the same floor, repeated, forty-four times, each one a decision the builder made about how a life on that elevation ought to be organized, and each one abandoned in the middle of being made. I know this building's grammar because it is my old grammar; I spent the better part of a decade teaching students to read exactly this kind of sentence, and this one has a detail I had not let myself look at closely in November, in the dark, in a hurry to reach whatever was waiting above me. On the raw concrete of the stair walls, where the finish coat was never applied and never will be, the grain of the wooden formwork is still legible — the plywood boards that held the wet concrete in its shape while it set, forty years ago, stripped away the moment the concrete no longer needed them, leaving their pattern pressed permanently into the thing they had made. You can run a hand down it and feel the knots. Every building in this city has that pattern hidden somewhere behind a skim coat and a coat of paint and a coat of marketing; this one alone kept it on the surface, because nobody ever came back to finish the surface, which means nobody ever came back to lie about how the thing was actually made. A rendering wants you to forget the scaffolding. This building forgot to hide it, and in forgetting became, of every tower on this river, the only one that told the truth about what held it up while it was still soft. I put my palm flat against a stretch of it on the thirty-ninth floor

landing, felt the grain of boards that had been kindling for four decades, and kept climbing.

The garlands were still on the rebar where I had found them in November, five of them, and — I saw this only now, at closer range, with the phone's light steady on it rather than shaking from a climb — they had been refreshed. Not the same flowers. New string, new dok rak, white and firm, the old ones presumably gone into the bucket of two-fingers water to compost, quietly, on somebody's schedule, without being asked why. I did not ask why. In August I would have taken the light apart photon by photon looking for the seam where the impossible one got in. Tonight I put my fingers on a petal, felt the same coolness I remembered from November, and took my hand back, and understood nothing, and let the not-understanding sit in me without turning it into a project. This may be the only thing I have learned this year that I would call, without irony, growth. A man can go a long way on not needing to know who keeps the flowers fresh.

The chair was where it had been. The wooden one stood at its twelve centimeters, angled toward the headrest, patient as furniture. Mor Nok was sweeping — I use his name now, though I want to record honestly that I still do not remember the exact hour I learned it; it arrived in my head sometime between November and tonight, the unremarkable way names arrive once you have stopped needing an occasion for them — the same

stretch of slab toward the open edge, in the trousers and undershirt he seemed to own in some quantity, and he did not startle at my light this time either, which told me he had heard the dog leave two floors below and had known, for that long, that I was coming.

"You came back with nothing," he said, before I had said anything.

"I noticed that myself on the stairs."

He leaned the broom against the rebar, next to the garlands. "Last time you asked if the chair was connected to anything." He looked at it, and then at me. "Wrong verb, I told you."

"I've been working on the verb."

"Good." He sat on the edge of the wooden chair himself, which I had not expected — I had thought of it as furniture reserved for someone else, and instead here he was, an old man taking the visitor's seat in his own operating theater, hands on his knees. "What is it, then. The chair."

I had not actually asked. He answered the question I would have gotten around to eventually, the way he answered most things up here — ahead of schedule, on his own terms.

"People come up here to have something extracted," he said. "Most of the time it isn't what they thought it was."

"What was it for the people it was?"

"Different for each of them. That's the part nobody wants to hear. They want a menu." He tapped the arm of

his own chair once, a dry sound. "I pulled teeth for thirty-one years in a shophouse near the flower market, before the license, and then without it, and I can tell you the same thing about teeth. A man comes in swearing the pain is in the back left. Half the time it's the front right, referred, and you learn to distrust where a patient points before you learn anything else in the trade."

"And this. Up here. What is it, exactly, if it isn't teeth."

He considered the question the way he'd considered the river before, unhurried, a man for whom hurry had stopped paying. "A convenience," he said. "That's the honest word for it." He nodded at my empty hands. "You brought less than most."

I looked at the chair a while. The vinyl held the cracks and the crosshatched tape I remembered, and the pump handle sat at the same angle it had in November. Nobody had reclined it since, most likely.

"Did she ever sit in it," I said. I did not qualify who.

Mor Nok did not ask either. "Once," he said. "Two years before the end. She came up here on her own, no note, found the stairs off somebody's ledger, I assume, though not the same somebody — mine's been dead longer than yours." He looked at the river a moment. "She sat in the chair for perhaps ten minutes and did not ask me to do anything to her. She came up asking your verb." He turned back to me. "She left asking a better one."

"What did she look like. Up here. That night."

He was quiet long enough that I thought he had decided, after all, not to answer. "Like a woman doing arithmetic she'd already finished and was only checking," he said. "She thanked me on the way out. Nobody thanks the sweeper. I've thought about that more than I've thought about the rest of it."

"What was hers."

"That's not for me to hand you," he said, without unkindness, flat and procedural, a form he had clearly read out many times before. "You'll get your own, or you won't, and either way it won't be hers. That's the part people also don't want to hear. The chair doesn't issue the same question to two people. It isn't that kind of instrument."

I sat down in it.

I had not decided to. My legs decided that, a forty-four-minute stair climb and a year like this one having their say before I did, and I found myself reclined at some angle I did not measure, looking up past the exposed rebar and the ranks of Corinthian columns holding up nothing, at a sky that had gone from black to the specific charcoal it goes before it commits to anything. The headrest was cold, and then, briefly and without ceremony, it was not cold anymore, an object that had simply stopped being strange. Below the open bay the river ran black and businesslike, same barge traffic, same unhurried freight moving upstream at the pace of a thing with nowhere urgent to be and every reason to keep moving anyway.

Somewhere past Klong Toey the port burned its low sodium orange over a building I now knew the inside of down to its floor plan and its shift schedule and the smell of its air conditioning, still set for fish. I could not see Cognita's roofline from there. I found myself looking for it anyway, and then, deliberately, stopped.

Mor Nok took up the broom again and went back to his stretch of slab, not watching me, giving me the specific privacy of a man doing his own work three meters away.

I lay there and did not ask if the world was real. I had asked some version of that question, in one register or another, for ninety-seven days, to Direk, to Golf, to a woman crying into a shoulder that was not offering comfort so much as absorbing it, to a photograph, to a closet with a fan in it, and every answer I had gotten back — the timezone, the peripheral, the golden set, the queued message I chose not to open — had closed clean and left a flower on a nightstand nobody could account for. I understood, finally, lying in a stranger's dental chair on the forty-fourth floor of an unfinished building at six in the morning, that I had been asking the wrong thing the entire time, exactly as Mor Nok kept telling me, and that the right question had been sitting under the wrong one the whole while, patient, waiting for me to climb enough stairs to find it.

"If everything is already written," I said, to the river, to Mor Nok, to whoever was going to answer, because by then I had stopped expecting the asking and the

answering to come from the same direction, "why show me anything at all."

Nobody answered from the direction I was facing.

It came from the stairwell behind me — the same stairwell I had just climbed, footsteps I had not heard arrive, unhurried, the tread of a man who had all the time this building had ever had. I turned my head against the cold vinyl. A green jacket stood in the stairwell doorway with a helmet held under one arm, bare-headed for the first time in ninety-seven days of green jackets, and the landing light — what little of it the sky was starting to give — did not reach his face. I want that on the record precisely: the helmet came off, and it changed nothing. I still cannot tell you what he looks like. What I can tell you is that he arrived at the exact second the question finished leaving my mouth, not a beat before, not a beat after — the same instinct for the turning frame that put Pui three chairs ahead of every other annotator on that floor, the frame nobody else could find until the model had already found it for them. I did not think that thought all the way through at the time. I am thinking it now, writing this down. I can tell you what he said, because he said it once, in a voice with no particular accent and no particular hurry, the only seven words I would ever hear from him in a year that had given me a great many words from a great many other sources.

"The script still needs one honest reader."

Then his right glove went to the delivery box that was not on his back this time — he had come up forty-four floors on foot, apparently, carrying nothing that would explain what came out of his hand next — and produced a slip of thermal paper, warm as it was always warm from him, printed by no printer I have ever located, and held it out.

I sat up to take it. Mor Nok had stopped sweeping.

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One decision. No charge. The paper gave its heat to my fingers over about the same ninety seconds it always takes, and by the time it had gone cool the stairwell doorway held nothing but the doorway.

I stood up out of the chair.

I want to be exact about what that was and was not. It was not defiance; there was nothing in the room demanding defiance. It was not refusal, because nobody had asked me to stay reclined, and Mor Nok had never once, in either visit, told me the chair required anything of the person in it beyond the sitting. It was the smallest possible motion — weight forward onto the feet, hands off the cracked armrests, the hydraulic pump giving one small mechanical sigh as it took the released weight, the same sigh, I imagine, it has given for every patient in thirty-one years who ever got up under their own power instead of being wheeled — and it did not feel, from the inside, like anything larger than standing up. I have

stood up out of chairs my entire life. I did not expect this one to be different, and from the inside it was not.

Mor Nok watched me do it with the broom idle in both hands, and something in his face — I could see his face; it was only the Rider's I could never see — arranged itself into an expression I would call, if I had to file it, respect withheld pending confirmation.

"That one," he said, "was not in the game records."

I did not ask him what game he meant. I think by then I had finally learned the lesson the receipts had been billing me for since August, one non-transaction at a time: some sentences are complete the moment they are said, and asking them to explain themselves is a tax you no longer have to pay.

I put the receipt in my shirt pocket, folded once, the same pocket that had carried a hundred-baht lottery ticket in November and, before that, nothing worth mentioning for forty-three years. Somewhere in the apartment, in a drawer, sealed in their zip-lock bags with their masking-tape dates, were the others — a longan drink I never bought, priced at twenty-five baht for the considering; a question about Pui the printer had misspelled as fertilizer; a door nobody had knocked on; a lesson with no branch number. Three of those had run their total to zero exactly, the longan drink the sole holdout with a real price on it. This one made a fourth zero and a fifth receipt altogether, and I understood,

folding it in with the rest, that I had stopped needing to know who kept that particular ledger either.

The garlands moved once in a draft off the river, all five together, strung on the same length of line and answering to it. Mor Nok picked his broom back up.

"Go home," he said. "You climbed for nothing tonight. That's usually how you know it worked."

The descent took twenty-two minutes, which I only know because I checked the time once at the top and once stepping through the gap behind the noodle cart, and did not check it in between — a way of measuring a duration I had never previously permitted myself. Going down, the building's grammar reverses; you read the same forty-four repeated floors in the other order, each one a decision walked away from instead of walked into, and the Corinthian columns holding up nothing went past me at a pace that made them look, for one flight, almost busy. The vendor was two hours from setting up, her stools still stacked and cabled to the cart's frame. A street sweeper three doors down worked a section of Charoen Krung with a broom identical to Mor Nok's, twigs bound to a long handle, the same unhurried stroke, and I did not point out the coincidence to either of them, because by then I had a policy about that.

The street held the particular grey Bangkok gets in the last half hour before commitment, buildings all outline and no color, and I had gone maybe forty meters toward Sathorn when the sky, having promised zero percent at

4:55 and meant it for every hour since, opened without any transition I could locate — no gathering, no distant thunder walking closer, no darkening in advance of itself. It simply rained, suddenly and completely, every argument that might have led up to it apparently already settled somewhere out of sight.

It rained hard, straight down, no wind behind it to give it an angle, drops fat enough to sound individually against the corrugated hoarding before the individual sounds ran together into one continuous roar that filled the whole width of the soi. I stood in it. I had a phone in one pocket and a receipt for a decision in the other and I did not move toward either awning on the block. Charoen Krung's shophouses ran dark and shuttered on both sides, water already finding the low points in the road, streetlight breaking into long amber threads on the wet asphalt, and somewhere behind me forty-four floors of unfinished sentence stood getting rained on for the first time in five months of a season that had sworn off rain entirely, its rebar catching the water and letting it go, its raw concrete drinking what it could and running the rest off in sheets down formwork grain that had been dry since June. I let it soak through my shirt and did not check whether it was the kind of rain a man could reasonably have predicted. Somewhere in the apartment, on the kitchen table, a notebook with a dog-eared blank page sat exactly as I had left it four days running, and I understood that I could go home and open it and see

whether an old man's shaking hand had already known this hour was coming. Standing in the water, my shirt gone through, my hair flat against my scalp, I understood I was never again going to need to check.

I took my phone out anyway, sheltering it under one arm, and I wrote to Fon. Not a template. Not a scheduled hour. Twenty past six in the morning, the rain loud enough on the screen's glass that I had to read my own message back twice to be sure autocorrect hadn't done anything unkind to it.

อยากกินข้าวด้วยกันไหม

I watched the three dots appear under it almost at once, which at that hour, for her, was its own small violation of a seventeen-month pattern, and then they stopped, and I stood in the rain on Charoen Krung holding a phone with nothing on the screen but my own sent line, and then the dots came back, and stopped again. She was choosing, I understood, between two or three answers, none of them false, not all of them the one she meant.

I did not wait to see which one she sent. I put the phone away wet and walked home the long way, past a 7-Eleven with its doors already open and its fluorescent light throwing a clean rectangle out onto the flooding street, past a clerk I did not recognize wiping down a counter nobody had used yet, past a green jacket parked at a soi mouth with its engine off and its visor down, unremarkable now, one more man waiting out a

downpour the ordinary way, and I did not cross the street to check the plate. Somewhere over Sathorn the sky was starting, unconvincingly, to consider morning. By the time I reached my own soi the rain had thinned to something a man could walk through without deciding to, and the strip of receipt paper was still in the door jamb where I had left it, undisturbed, and I went inside and did not check the notebook on the kitchen table, and did not open the folder marked with two initials in the closet, and did not, for the first morning in ninety-seven days, check anything at all before I slept. The next draw was five days out, the first Sunday of December, and somewhere in the building a television would already be tuned to it by six that evening, the way it always was on draw days, and for the first time since Direk had shown me his ledger I understood I was not going to be in the room for it.

The 7:47 alarm — Radar, the one I had set seventeen months ago and never once edited, toggled, or silenced — did not ring.